RUPEE IN A FREE FALL

FUTURE OF WORK: THE MUSK WAY

BANKING/PE SPECIAL

SWEET MAKEOVER FOR CHITALE

SHAFALI VERMA ON HER MASTERCLASS

PRICE ₹200
DECEMBER 12, 2025

Forbes INDIA

Chrys Capitalism

How the largest homegrown PE firm holds its own against global biggies, and where its 10th and largest fund will take it



Sanjiv Kaul (left), partner, **Kunal Shroff** (seated), managing partner, and **Sanjay Kukreja**, partner and CIO, ChrysCapital

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Network 18 www.forbesindia.com

Welcome to the

Forbes INDIA

Digital Edition

Simone was also a Tata

Honestly, I am always sheepish about not putting women leaders on the cover of *Forbes India* often enough. I mean, look at the Rich List issue that came out a few days ago. Five covers. All men. Look at the cover of the issue you have in your hands. Three faces on the cover. All men.



This is an extreme irony because some of the finest and hardest working people in the *Forbes India* team—writers, editors, designers, photographers, researchers—are not men. For evidence, look at the names appearing in our magazine and on the website. There are more who continue with their immense contribution without perhaps getting enough credit.

But in our coverage, we struggle to achieve that kind of gender balance.

Honestly, again, we are painfully conscious of this imbalance and always try to look for highlighting women leaders and achievers. We make the extra effort to make sure we do not miss out on good names across genders in every area we cover.

And you will find some excellent personalities there: In artificial intelligence, longevity, young companies to watch out for, startups, tech, etc. We also bring out a magazine issue every year dedicated to women leaders. But quite often, we find our hands tied.

Despite the best of intentions, the presence of women in leading roles across sectors remains limited. A study by Khaitan & Co, the law firm, says women's board representation in the Nifty-500 has grown from around 6 percent in 2013 to approximately 21 percent in 2025. The year 2013 was when it became mandatory for all listed companies in the country to have at least one woman on their boards.

In the immediate aftermath of the regulatory action, we were presented with the curious phenomenon of *bahu-beti-biwi-bhanji* boards. Instead of finding worthy candidates, several companies took the convenient option of appointing a family member to meet the woman quota. Even now, debate continues over the meaningfulness of several appointments—whether they are actually moving the needle when it comes to having more effective female leadership.

Which is why the death of Simone Tata on December 5 hits differently. She came to India on holiday in 1953—all of 23 and still called Simone Dunoyer. She fell in love with Naval Hormusji Tata, 26 years her senior. They married two years later.

Simone was appointed as the managing director of Lakme, the cosmetics company, in 1961. It was a minor play for the Tata Group. But Simone was quick to identify the market potential of the aspiring new Indian woman and her desire to express her personality. Over the next two decades, she made Lakme India's largest cosmetics brand. But that is not the most striking thing on her resume.

In the 1990s, she spearheaded Tata's foray into retail as Lakme found its way into the arms of Hindustan Unilever Ltd, which was then called Hindustan Lever Ltd. The Tata Group ploughed the money from that transaction into retail, which is now a shining part of the conglomerate.

Simone was mother to a very well-known corporate figure and stepmother to another one. However, we are not invoking the names of the two gentlemen here to keep the focus solely on the lady.

Simone should be remembered for who she was, not who she was related to. That she was her own person was reinforced when she attended Cyrus Mistry's funeral—the only member of the Tata family to do so.

In such tributes, it is customary to say she was ahead of her time. Maybe. Or maybe we are behind the times, considering we still struggle to strike gender balance in our coverage.



Best,



Suveen Sinha
Editor, *Forbes India*
suveen.sinha@nw18.com

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The ChrysCapital team: (from left) Ashley Menezes, partner and COO; Gaurav Ahuja, partner; Kunal Shroff, managing partner; Sanjay Kukreja, partner and CIO; Sanjiv Kaul, partner

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HOME TEAM

In a landscape dotted with the biggest global names, ChrysCapital has held its own. Now, having raised the largest India-focussed fund ever, it must break fresh ground

PHOTO BY MADHU KAPPARATH

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PHOTO BY BAJIRAO PAWAR FOR FORBES INDIA



Kedar (left) and Indraneel Chitale, managing partners, Chitale Group

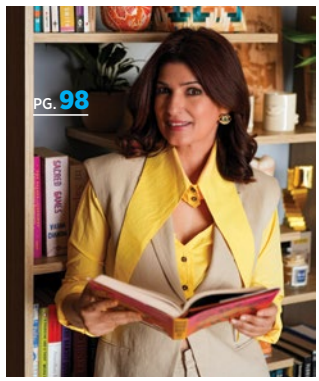


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INDIA Forbes

STEEP FALL

The rupee hit an all-time low due to a strong US dollar, widening trade deficit and capital outflows

By SAMREEN WANI

The rupee breached the 90-mark and hit a lifetime-low against the US dollar on December 3, due to a strong US dollar, record trade deficit, foreign investment outflows.

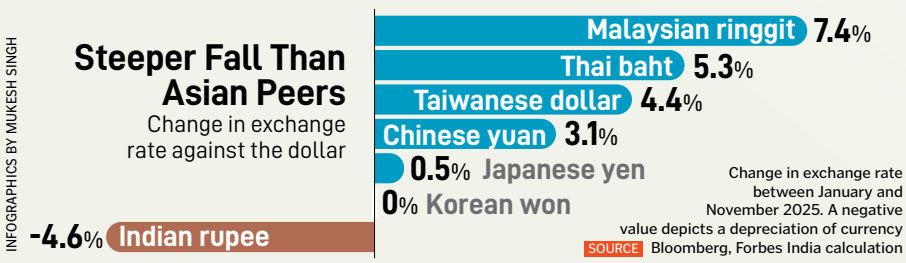
Starting the year around the 85.7-mark in early January, the rupee consistently weakened and touched 88 in late August before dropping to its previous lowest in November, after which the RBI intervened to stop the slide. While currencies across Asia are also under pressure from a strong dollar, the rupee's decline is significantly steeper. The crisis is being amplified by the strength of the US dollar, which crossed over 100 in November, showing global demand for the greenback. Uncertainty over the pending India-US trade deal and the ongoing negative effects of US tariffs on Indian goods pushed up the October trade deficit to the highest this year.

Foreign investors have aggressively withdrawn funds from Indian equities. The current account deficit has widened in the September quarter and forex reserves have dipped in October. Meanwhile, a long stretch of undervaluation continues, with the rupee's Real Effective Exchange Rate being under 100 since February, which is unusual.

A depreciating rupee makes Indian exports cheaper, but the negative trade-off is the widespread economic burden from higher import costs, impacting both corporate and household finances.



Note: Inverted graph SOURCE CMIE



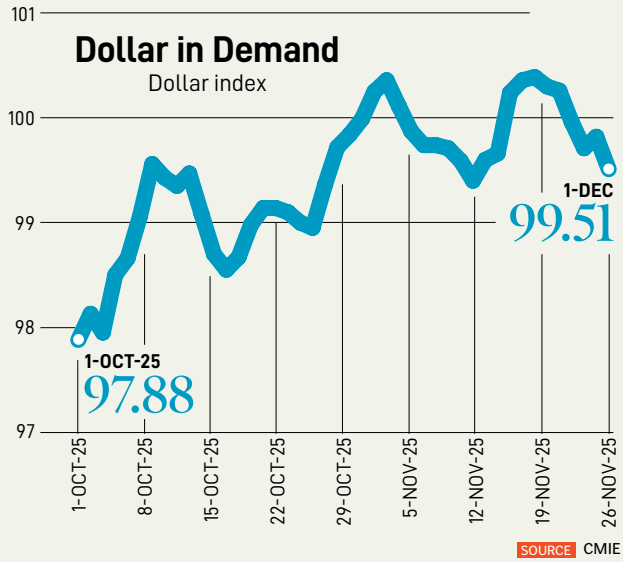
Change in exchange rate between January and November 2025. A negative value depicts a depreciation of currency

SOURCE Bloomberg, Forbes India calculation

INFOGRAPHICS BY MUKESH SINGH

Dollar in Demand

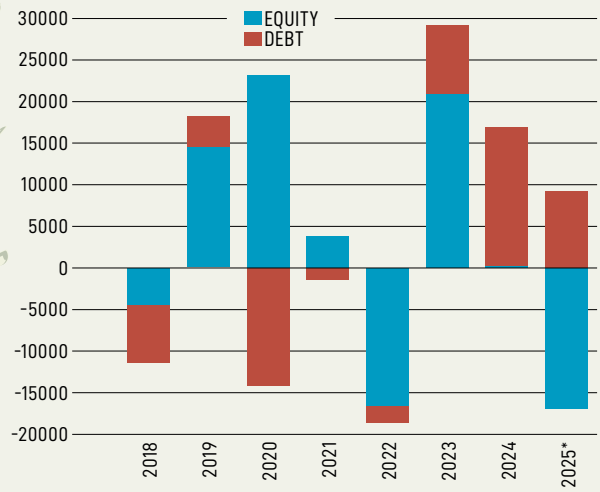
Dollar index



SOURCE CMIE

FPI Outflows

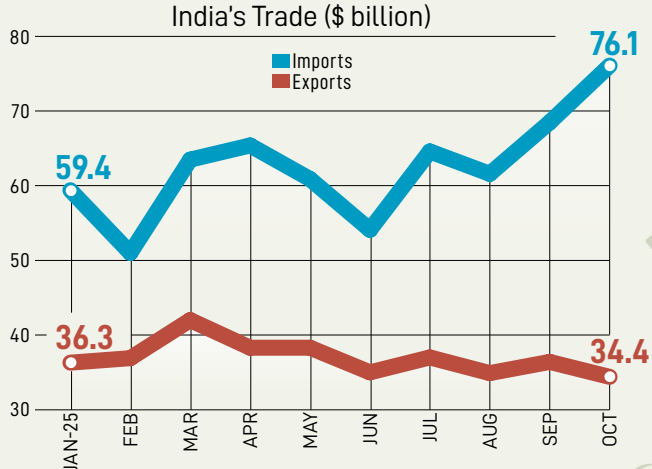
FPI net investment (In $ million)



*Data till 2 Dec SOURCE NSDL

Widening Deficit

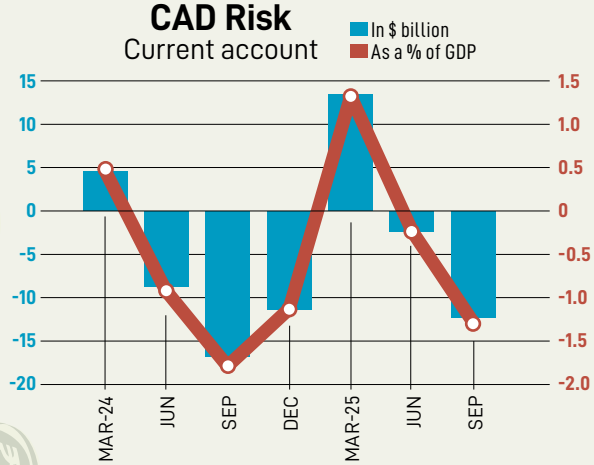
India's Trade ($ billion)



SOURCE Ministry of Commerce

CAD Risk

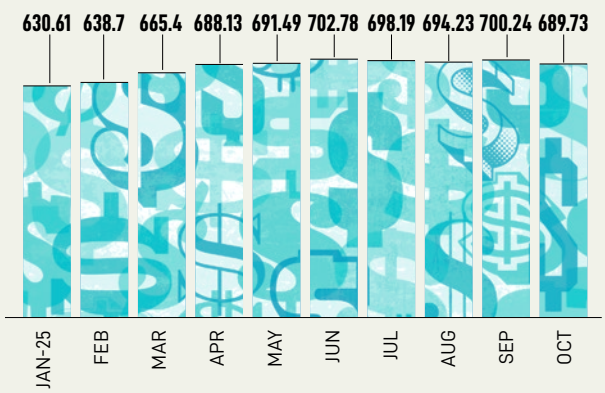
Current account



SOURCE RBI

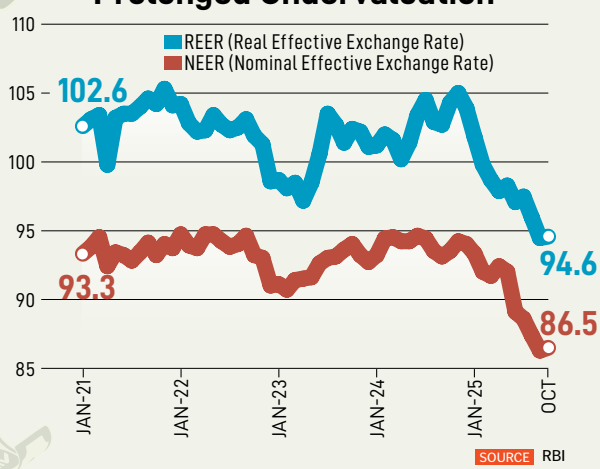
Forex Buffer

Forex reserves (in $ billion)



SOURCE CMIE

Prolonged Undervaluation



SOURCE RBI

LAWS

Labour Reset

India's biggest labour code overhaul promises simpler compliance and social security, but employers face shifts in costs, payroll structures and state-level uncertainties

By VASUDHA MUKHERJEE & SAMREEN WANI



PHOTO BY PRIYANSHU SINGH / REUTERS

THE CONSOLIDATED LABOUR reform project was rolled out on November 21 with the enforcement of the Code on Wages 2019, the Industrial Relations Code 2020, the Code on Social Security 2020, and the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions (OSHWC) Code 2020. Together, they subsume 29 earlier laws. The Ministry of Labour and Employment describes the shift as a move to a "future-ready workforce" through measures such as single registration, a unified annual return and digital systems, including the Shram Suvidha portal.

THE CHANGES

The Code on Wages 2019 now mandates universal minimum wages and requires employers to follow strict timelines for salary payments. The Code on Social Security 2020 extends the Employees' Provident Fund (EPF), the Employees' State Insurance Corporation (ESIC) and other welfare benefits to gig and platform workers for the first time. Fixed-term employees are eligible for gratuity after one year of service. The OSHWC Code 2020 introduces annual health check-ups for eligible workers, limits weekly working hours and places ceilings on overtime.

SHIFTING PAY STRUCTURES

For employers, the most immediate and disruptive change is the unified definition of wages. Basic pay, dearness allowance and retaining allowance must constitute at least half of an employee's total remuneration. This raises the base used to calculate statutory outflows such as EPF contributions, ESIC premiums, statutory bonus, gratuity and retrenchment compensation.

Suchita Dutta, executive director

Pressure On The Rupee
The stress on the currency will remain; the RBI may still lower rates P/14

Musk On Money
The business tycoon about his outlook on business, wealth and politics P/18

A Square Cut Above
Cricketer Deepti Sharma has moved from the fringes to the spotlight P/29

of the Indian Staffing Federation (ISF), highlights that, "allowances cannot exceed 50 percent of total remuneration, compelling firms to restructure salaries". She adds that the provision that "basic pay must now constitute at least 50 percent of gross salary", up from typical 30 to 40 percent structures, affects provident fund calculations, gratuity and bonuses, and "experts estimate a 10 to 15 percent rise in employer contributions to EPF".

"The formal staffing industry currently employing 7.23 million contract workers will not be affected as much. Though the changes could result in a 10 to 15 percent overall CTC escalation for informal firms that have not yet planned to overhaul the pay structures," adds Dutta.

Legal advisers echo this concern. Pooja Ramchandani, partner at Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas and Co, says the new wage definition will have "a far-reaching impact on gratuity payments". She adds employers can no longer rely on low basic pay and must be prepared for increases in PF and other statutory costs. "Any excluded allowances in excess of 50 percent of remuneration must be ploughed back to wages for statutory calculations," she says.

HR ADAPTATION

Despite the adjustment costs, several HR leaders believe the new clarity will improve hiring sentiment. Santhosh Nair, director and COO of CIEL HR, says, "The labour codes are expected to create a healthier environment for job creation across industries." According to him, simplification via a single licence, single registration and single return "reduces the administrative load that often slows down hiring decisions". He adds that "organisations can focus on growth rather than paperwork".

Companies face a period of dual compliance because some provisions require new state rules before they can be implemented

HR teams are also navigating considerable employee communication challenges. Partha Neog, CEO and co-founder of Vantage Circle, an employee engagement SaaS-platform, says early conversations with clients regarding the new labour code are about helping employees understand changes in their take-home pay. "One of the key requests we are receiving from HR teams is guidance on how to explain changes in take-home pay in a way that is transparent and reassuring," he says. Non-monetary benefits are becoming more important. "Employee recognition and rewards, wellness initiatives and experience-driven benefits" are being used to maintain morale, he adds.

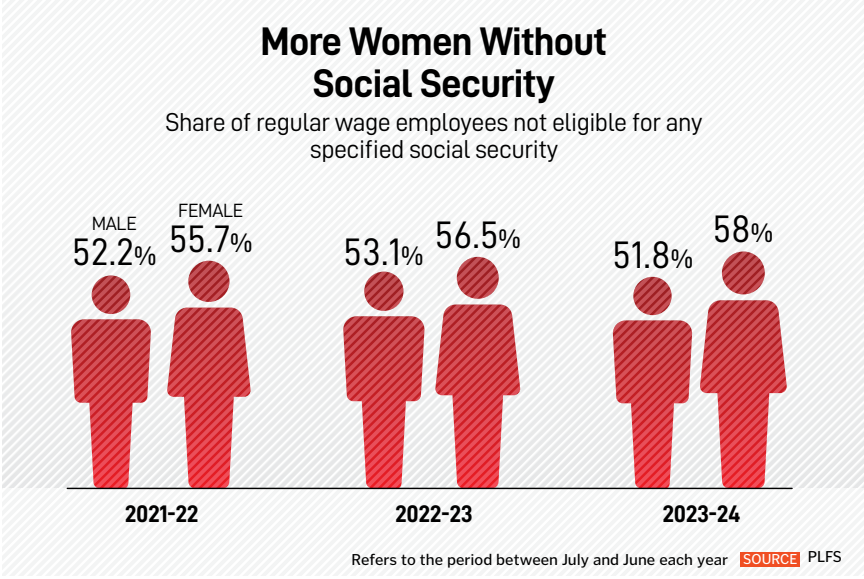
HR tech adoption is accelerating as well. Neog says, "The new labour codes are encouraging HR teams to adopt platforms and tools that provide structure, visibility and predictability, including digital record-keeping and automated compliance systems."

STATE & SECTOR GAPS

Even with nationwide enforcement, companies face a period of dual compliance because some provisions require new state rules before they can be fully implemented. Ramchandani notes that "pending notification of central and state rules, full-scale implementation remains measured" and that many employers are waiting for "complete regulatory clarity before making any major structural changes".

On November 27, Kerala announced that it does not plan to implement the codes. After a meeting with trade union representatives in Thiruvananthapuram, Labour Minister V Sivankutty said the state has "no intention" of moving to the new framework. The meeting passed a resolution calling for the codes to be withdrawn, arguing that they were drafted without sufficient consultation and dilute worker protections.

Dutta notes that "state-level variations persist" and warns that inconsistent adoption can create dual



INFOGRAPHICS BY MUKESH SINGH

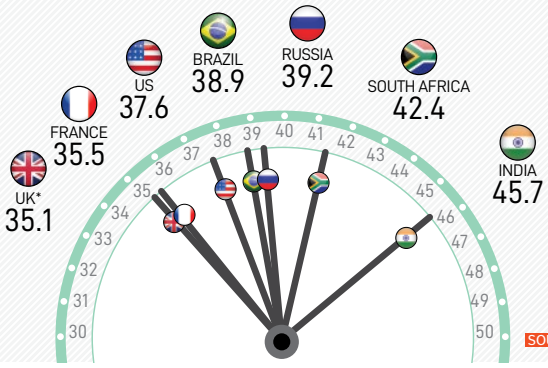
7.23 mln

Contract workers employed by staffing firms; Indian employees work 46 hours a week on an average



Indians Work Longer Hours

Mean weekly hours worked per employed person in 2024

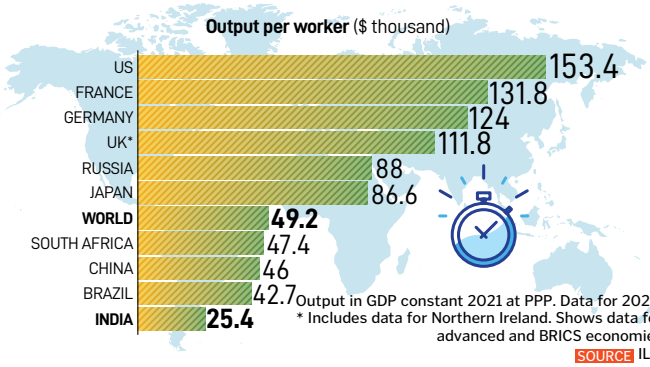


*Includes data for Northern Ireland

SOURCE ILO

Indians Have Lower Productivity

Output per worker ($ thousand)

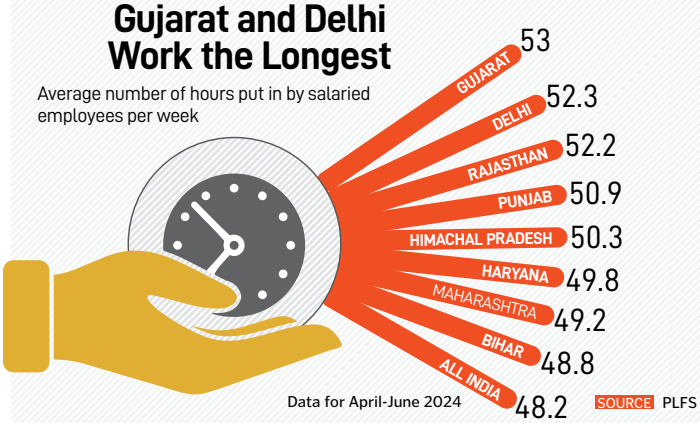


Output in GDP constant 2021 at PPP. Data for 2025.
* Includes data for Northern Ireland. Shows data for advanced and BRICS economies

SOURCE ILO

Gujarat and Delhi Work the Longest

Average number of hours put in by salaried employees per week

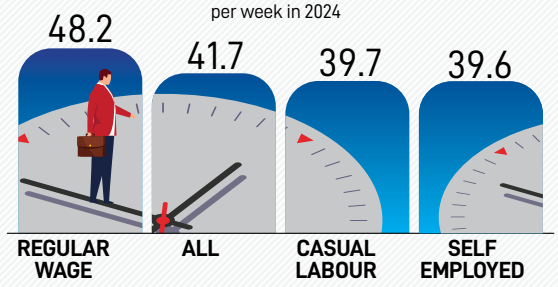


Data for April-June 2024

SOURCE PLFS

Salaried Employees Work Longer

Average number of hours worked per week in 2024



Data for April-June quarter

SOURCE PLFS

compliance burdens for companies operating across jurisdictions.

Sectors with complex workforce structures will feel the strain the most. Gig and platform companies must account for new aggregator contribution requirements, while manufacturing, construction and logistics firms face tighter rules for contract labour and wider welfare mandates.

WORK VERSUS OUTPUT

Given that a larger proportion of women face exclusion from social protections, employees toil longer hours than global peers, and productivity lags far behind, the new laws are a welcome reform.

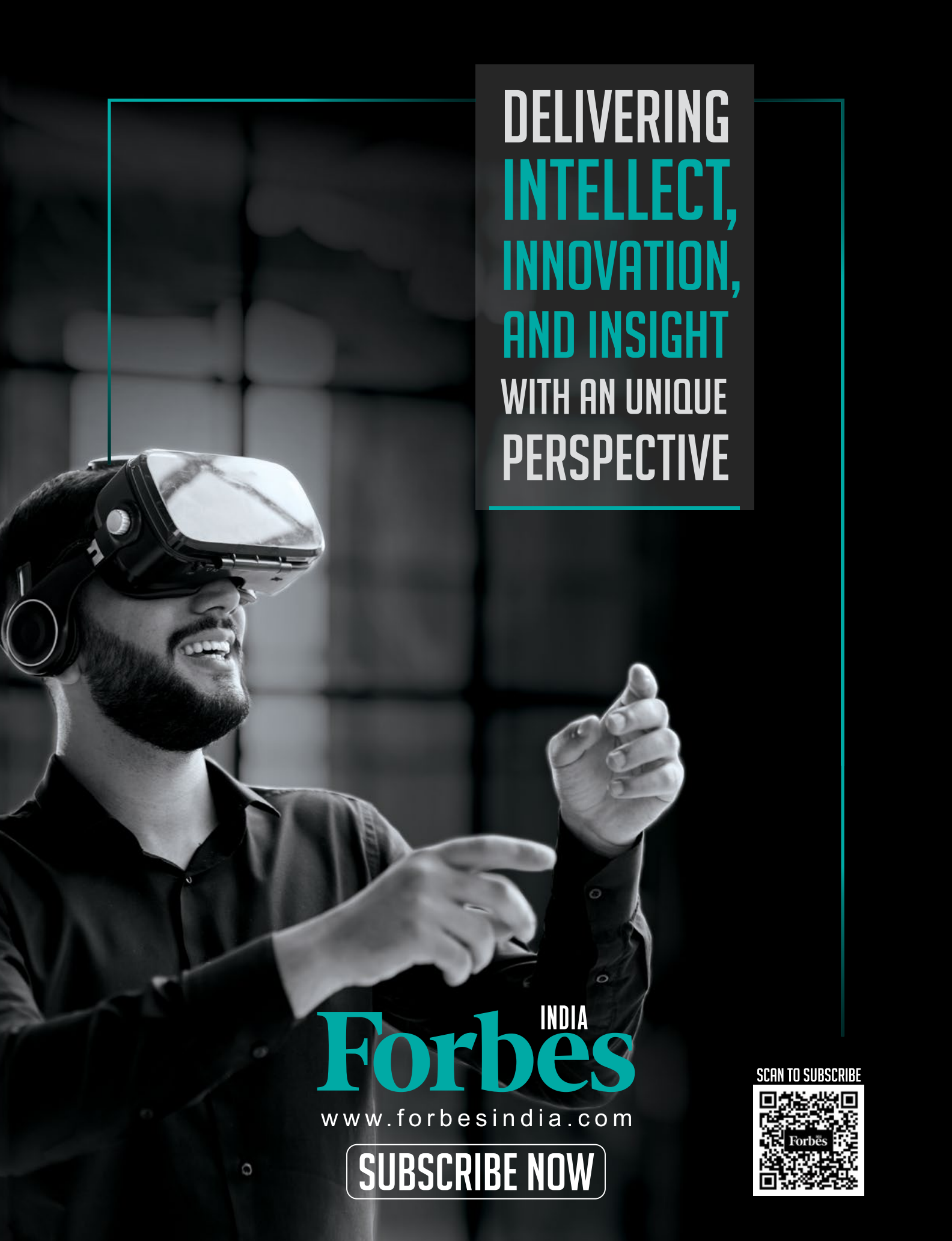
Government data shows that the share of women ineligible for specified social security climbed from 55.7 percent in 2021-22 to 58 percent in 2023-24—outpacing men (51.8 percent) and the overall average (53.4 percent). This trend bucks national gains, where coverage has improved.

The most striking contradiction lies in India's work ethic versus its economic output. International Labour Organisation (ILO) data show that average Indian employees work 46 hours a week on an average, longer compared to peers in advanced economies like the US (37.6 hours) or those in the Brazil, Russia, China and South Africa (BRICS) grouping (South Africa: 42.4).

However, long hours are not translating into high-value output as India's productivity remains lowest among all countries under consideration. Output per worker stands at about $25,400 (at constant 2021 PPP), less than half of the global average. In fact, government data reveals acute pressure points, with regular wage employees in states like Gujarat (53 hours) and Delhi (52.3 hours) averaging well over the 48-hour statutory weekly limit set by the new codes.

Long hours don't transalate into high-value output. India's productivity remains lowest among all countries under consideration

In India, between 2017 and 2024, while the weekly hours clocked by employees have dropped from 53 to 42, salaried employees still work over 48 hours a week. While those in casual labour work an average of 39.7 hours a week, self-employed work slightly lower at 39.6 hours.


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More Pressure on the Rupee

Till an India-US trade deal takes shape, the stress on the currency (against the dollar) will remain. The RBI has now lowered interest rates, tracking lower inflation

By SALIL PANCHAL



SHUTTERSTOCK

HAS THE LATEST GDP DATA FOR India—at a higher-than-expected 8.2 percent for Q2FY26, led by manufacturing growth announced on November 28—stalled the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) potential move to lower interest rates (to spur growth), for the rest of FY26?

The RBI further lowered interest rates by 25 basis points on December 5, keeping in view the extremely low retail inflation.

Governor Sanjay Malhotra had given a fair hint of what they we were thinking. In the minutes of the last October policy meeting, Malhotra had said: "The benign inflation outlook opens up policy space for monetary action." But he also added that the cumulative impact of fiscal and monetary measures was yet to be realised fully and tariff-related uncertainties were still evolving. This led the RBI to keep interest rates on hold at that time.

Economists had indicated that the RBI would cut rates in December—which it did—and then pause for the rest of FY26

Economists had, in recent weeks, indicated that the RBI would

90.43
Rupee hit an all-time low against the dollar on December 3


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cut rates in December—which it did—and then pause for the rest of FY26. Only a deepening fear of slowing growth will push the RBI for a further rate cut. The RBI has lowered rates by 125 basis points in 2025.

"This year, the story has been about growth overshooting and inflation undershooting," says Sakshi Gupta, principal economist at HDFC Bank. She had predicted the latest 25 bps rate cut, given the lingering risks on growth (in H2) and with inflation expected to remain well below 4 percent until Q3FY27.

India's retail inflation fell to a historic low of 0.25 percent in October, aided by low food prices and the base effect. The depreciating rupee—which hit an all-time low of 90.43 to the dollar on December 3—has been subdued due to foreign fund outflows and uncertainty over the proposed India-US trade deal.

THE CONCERN

There has been a murmur that the RBI may not lower interest rates due to the impact on the currency. A lower interest rate tends to be unattractive for foreign investment and decrease the currency's relative value.

But Gupta says the RBI is "more focussed towards the domestic economic levers". In February, the RBI had cut interest rates when the rupee was depreciating significantly—it fell around 1 percent in that month impacted by sharp foreign fund outflows. Yet, the RBI cut policy rates.

"This interest rate argument has not been a strong influencer of currency movement," Gupta explains. "This is a story about growth differential. We have a view that the rupee will be under pressure."

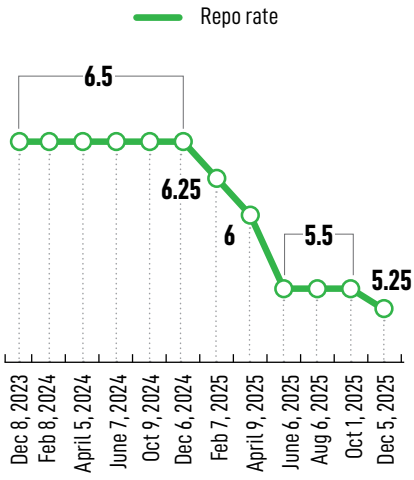
The RBI, on December 2, stepped in to defend the rupee and stem further slide. "If there is a tussle between the currency and interest rates, it is usually the currency that wins," R Sivakumar, head, strategy & products, Axis Asset Management, said in an interaction in October.

In the current scenario, there is also a possibility that the rupee will continue to be under pressure till the time India does not get a favourable trade deal with the US. Reports emerging from India's commerce ministry indicated that this is likely to be finalised by end-2025.

The expectation that the trade deal will materialise will bring positive sentiment and a rally for the rupee. But the longer it takes for the trade deal to materialise, the rupee will continue to depreciate, and the upward retracement will not be towards ₹86 (to the dollar) levels.

Gupta of HDFC Bank forecasts the rupee over the next eight to 12 months in a weak ₹88-90 trend.

RBI's Interest Rate Action Since 2023



SOURCE RBI

Repo rate in percentage

While consumer demand showed signs of pickup during the festive season, its durability over the coming months remains uncertain

NO MORE RATE CUTS?

Reiterating the observations of the Monetary Policy Committee at the minutes of the October meeting, Malhotra told Zee Business in a November 24 interaction that, after the last policy meeting, "there have been no signals through macroeconomic data to indicate a reduction in the possibility for an interest rate cut. The possibility for a rate cut in December exists, but it is for the committee to decide".

But is this the end of the road for no more rate cuts in FY26? Gupta said: "H2GDP growth could average close to 6.6 percent as the favourable base effect fades, government spending momentum moderates (after frontloading in H1), and drag from US tariffs (in the absence of an India-US trade deal) and slowdown in global growth—that is yet to play out fully—weighs on exports."

She said that while consumer demand showed signs of improvement during this festive season, the durability of this pick-up over the coming months remains uncertain. "In this regard, one would need to see a sustainable improvement in labour market conditions, especially on the urban side to spur a continued recovery in demand," Gupta tells *Forbes India*. All these factors will then determine whether the RBI needs to lower interest rates.

Latest data from the RBI shows that credit growth of scheduled commercial banks picked up in October to 11.3 percent (year-over-year), compared to 10.4 percent (year-over-year) as of September 19. But deposit growth was lower than credit growth.

Gravity vs Ageing

As Zomato founder Deepinder Goyal joins the billionaires' longevity bandwagon, his claims have faced quick and cautionary rebuttals

By NAINI THAKER



A 2019 report by Bank of America analysts had predicted that the global longevity economy would become worth $600 billion by 2025

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ON NOVEMBER 15, DEEPINDER Goyal, founder of Eternal (formerly Zomato) wrote a post on X and LinkedIn, saying: "I am saying gravity shortens lifespan."

His new longevity venture, Continue Research, backed by a $25 million fund, is investigating whether gravity—the force that keeps us grounded—could also be accelerating ageing by gradually reducing blood flow to the brain. He added: "It's open-source, backed by science, and shared with you as part of our common quest for scientific progress on human longevity."

The announcement has drawn scepticism and criticism from doctors and other entrepreneurs, with rebuttals being posted on social media. For instance, Jitendra Chouksey, CEO of fitness startup Fittr, posted on LinkedIn: "We live in dangerous times. When I forwarded Deepinder's "gravity theory of ageing" to Dr Lauren Colenso, a scientist who works in this field, she joked that she wanted to delete her social media." Yet Goyal's move is part of a trend in India: Entrepreneurs betting on radical ideas to extend human health span, including Accel's Prashanth Prakash, Biocon's Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw and former Infosys CEO Kris Gopalkrishnan.

A 2019 report by Bank of America analysts had predicted that the global longevity economy would become worth $600 billion by 2025. Subsequently, the sector started attracting tech founders and billionaires worldwide, who have invested in various startups. In 2021, Jeff Bezos invested an undisclosed amount into Altos Labs, which focuses on cellular reprogramming to reverse ageing; Sam Altman, CEO of OpenAI, invested $180 million in Retro Biosciences, which aims to add 10 years to human lifespan through cellular rejuvenation. Others like entrepreneur and investor Peter Thiel and Brian Armstrong (CEO of Coinbase) are backing ventures such as NewLimit and Unity Biotechnology, targeting epigenetic reprogramming and senescent cell clearance.

GOYAL'S BIG IDEA

In his social media posts and blog on Continue Research's website, Goyal writes about how evolution designed human bodies for survival and reproduction, not longevity. He writes that there is no selective pressure to counteract gravity's long-term effects, because our average lifespan of 30 to 40 years is sufficient for reproduction; what happens after that is nature's afterthought.

Goyal mentions three points: 1) An upright posture reduces blood flow to the brain by small amounts, compounding over decades; 2) Neurons in the hypothalamus and brainstem are highly metabolic and depend on tiny perforating blood vessels, which makes them very sensitive to even small drops in blood flow; 3) These regions control hormones, inflammation, metabolism, autonomic balance, repair and aging itself.

On November 15, he posted on X: "Nobody has put these three pieces together into a single, testable mechanism for ageing. A big part of human ageing might be brain-first and gravity driven, and not body-first [like we've always believed]. That's the breakthrough." This led Goyal to

ask: What if counteracting gravity and restoring blood flow to the brain could lead to a healthier brain and, as a consequence, a healthier body?

Cerebral blood flow (CBF) is the continuous delivery of blood that supplies oxygen and glucose to power nearly every system-regulating metabolism, hormones, and cellular repair. Continue's research found that sustained CBF is critical for both brain and body health, and its reductions—especially in regions like the hypothalamus and brainstem—may accelerate ageing. Its research says that low CBF nearly doubles all-cause mortality risk, independent of heart health. As these control regions degrade, the autonomic, hormonal and immune systems they govern spiral into dysfunction. In short, brain ageing becomes body ageing.

"Research shows CBF declines by 0.3 to 0.74 percent annually, resulting in a 20 to 40 percent loss between ages 20 and 80. Superagers and centenarians tend to have higher baseline CBF compared to average individuals," says Nitish Kumar, part of Continue Research Science Team. Continue has employed an experimental device—called Temple, Goyal has been seen wearing it—that indirectly measures CBF and provides a reading.

The company's research also claims that superagers experience slower brain shrinkage: 1.06 percent per year compared to the average 2.24 percent.


Deepinder Goyal

NOT EVERYONE'S CONVINCED

Kochi-based Dr Cyriac Abby Philips, a consultant hepatologist and liver transplant physician, who goes by the name 'The Liver Doc' on social media, calls the 'Gravitational Theory of Ageing', "a persuasive story rather than actual science". Speaking to *Forbes India*, he argues ageing is a complex biological process driven by multiple factors, and not a single cause like gravity.

One major flaw in the theory, he says, is the astronaut paradox: "If gravity caused ageing, astronauts in zero gravity should age slower. But the opposite happens—they experience rapid ageing-like changes in space. The theory tries to claim both gravity and lack of gravity are bad, which makes it impossible to prove wrong."

Pawan Goenka, chairman of the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre, tells *Forbes India*: "From what I've heard, ageing happens faster if gravity is less, because muscles deteriorate. And then there's a lot of recuperation you have to do after you come back from space."

Other claims made by Continue—such as bats living longer because they hang upside down, or shorter people living longer because their hearts have to pump less against gravity—are also being debunked. "Bats live long because of unique genetic adaptations like telomere maintenance and DNA repair. Shorter people benefit from lower IGF-1 levels, a proven longevity factor—not gravity," Philips says.

He stresses that real ageing science focuses on cellular damage: "As we age, DNA accumulates errors, telomeres wear down, gene regulation gets scrambled, and broken proteins pile up. Mitochondria fail, growth signals misfire, and damaged cells turn into 'zombie cells' that poison their neighbours. These interconnected processes drive ageing—not gravity."

Validating or invalidating the hypothesis that gravity accelerates ageing will require years of research across various scientific fields, says Kumar of Continue Research.

At this stage, Continue's work on interventions is focussed "purely on studying how altered gravitational loading affects human and animal physiology; we are not promoting or scaling any intervention for everyday use until the science is clear". Continue isn't planning to sell consumer wellness products or clinical therapies. Its vision, says Kumar, is "solely to support and fund scientific research into the fundamental drivers of ageing."

According to Continue, CBF can be improved through simple interventions that help maintain brain health and delay ageing. Regular exercise, especially aerobic and resistance training, supports brain blood vessels, while inversions temporarily boost blood flow. Foods that include nitrate-rich greens, berries, fatty fish, and supplements like Omega-3s, CoQ10, and resveratrol can help keep CBF high.

However, Phillips adds: "The gravity theory ignores decades of proven science and asks people to believe in a simple story instead of the complex biological reality," He continues: "In essence, Deepinder Goyal is wasting his time, money and resources on already-dead concepts and, in the process, wasting ours too."

PHOTO BY MADHU KAPPARATH

Elon Musk on Money And The Future of Work

In a podcast episode with entrepreneur Nikhil Kamath, business tycoon Elon Musk spoke about his outlook on business, wealth and politics. Here are some key takeaways



PHOTO BY GONZALO FUENTES/FILE PHOTO/ REUTERS

"It's very difficult to give money well."

Musk has a large foundation but doesn't put his name on it. He believes it is easy to give money away but to have a tangible impact on people's lives through philanthropy is the hard part



PHOTO BY EVELYN HOCKSTEIN/ REUTERS

"We'll move to universal high income."

Musk contrasted this with the concept of universal basic income and argued that with the advances in AI and robotics, soon everyone will have everything they need

"Prediction: US inflation goes to zero and it enters an era of deflation."

AI and robotics will cause a drastic increase in the output of goods and services leading to a fall in prices. Musk expects this to happen in three years



PHOTO BY CHIP SOMODEVILLA/GETTY IMAGES



PHOTO BY DANIEL COLE/ REUTERS

"In the future (less than 20 years), working will be optional."

In an era where everyone has what they could possibly want, Musk equates working with a hobby—something one does because one wants to and not because one has to. (He didn't see himself working less though—if you want to create a company that does great things you have to put in the hours)



PHOTO BY EVELYN HOCKSTEIN/ REUTERS

"Money is a system for labour allocation."

In the future, money could lose its relevance as people can have everything they want. "If I am on an island with a trillion dollars, it is not worth anything." Musk termed energy (solar, electricity etc) as the only true currency

20
The number of cities that Bharat Taxi plans to expand to by early next year



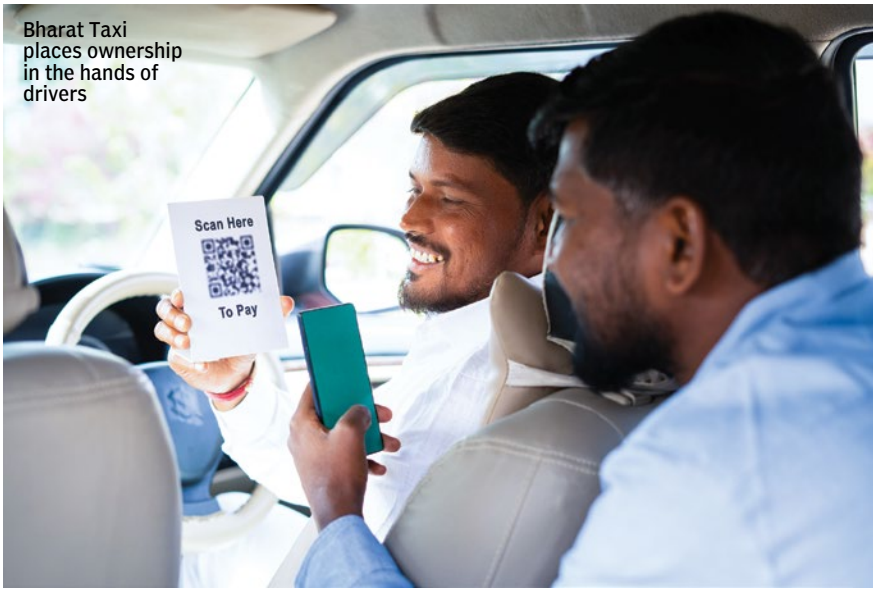
TRANSPORT

A New Journey

The central government is scheduled to launch its first cooperative cab service, Bharat Taxi, in December with a transparent and participative model

By SAMIDHA JAIN

SHUTTERSTOCK



Bharat Taxi places ownership in the hands of drivers

THE GOVERNMENT OF INDIA IS set to launch its first cooperative cab service, Bharat Taxi, in December. The initiative is being developed in collaboration with the Union Ministry of Cooperation and the National e-Governance Division, which will provide strategic advisory and technical support in platform integration, cybersecurity, data privacy, compliance and governance.

The service will be operated by Sahakar Taxi Cooperative Limited, a driver-owned cooperative supported by national cooperatives, including Amul, IFFCO, Nabard, and NCDC. On December 2, a pilot run began in Delhi. As per reports, in just 10 days before it, the cooperative onboarded over 51,000 drivers in Delhi and Saurashtra. The android version of the Bharat Taxi app is now available, on which riders and drivers can test real-time services.

Bharat Taxi is part of the government's broader 'Sahakar se Samriddhi' mission, which aims to empower workers and promote growth through cooperative models. By eliminating commission-based structures and ensuring drivers are stakeholders, the initiative seeks to create a fair, transparent and sustainable mobility ecosystem.

KEY FEATURES

Drivers as stakeholders: Bharat Taxi introduces a transparent, cooperative alternative to existing platforms by placing ownership with drivers. Unlike private aggregators where drivers are service providers, in this model they join with a pre-decided fee and become shareholders.

Transparency for passengers: The model ensures a more equitable ecosystem for users. It promises relief from issues such as unpredictable surge pricing, lack of transparency and inconsistent service quality.

Digital Integration: The platform is digitally integrated with key government services such as DigiLocker, UMANG and API Setu, ensuring secure identity verification and seamless access to services.

Expansion Plans: Bharat Taxi plans to expand to 20 cities by early next year, and onboard 1 lakh drivers by 2030.

OTHER GOVERNMENT-BACKED AND COLLABORATIVE TAXI SERVICES

To compete with large companies like Ola, Uber and Rapido, multiple local services are partnering with state governments to empower drivers and ensure fair pricing and transparency.

Namma Yatri (Bengaluru, Karnataka): Namma Yatri is a private, open-source ride-hailing app that takes zero commission and allows drivers to retain their full earnings. It has facilitated over 100 million rides and paid out more than ₹600 crore to drivers. The platform is supported by auto unions and works closely with the Karnataka government to integrate infrastructure and policy support. Namma Yatri declined to comment for this article on Bharat Taxi.

GoaMiles (Goa): Launched by the Goa Tourism Development Corporation, GoaMiles is a state-backed app aimed at streamlining tourist transport. Launched in 2018, it has completed over 2 crore rides. Initially it faced resistance from taxi unions and struggled with adoption due to pricing disputes and operational challenges.

Yatri Sathi (West Bengal): Initiated by the West Bengal government, it is offers affordable and transparent cab services. It collaborates with local transport bodies and has expanded beyond Kolkata to Siliguri, Asansol and Durgapur. It is a direct-to-driver app, with no commission or middlemen.

‘Higher Fines May Not Solve Dark Pattern Issue’

Nidhi Khare, consumer affairs secretary, says companies will be trusted to do right by consumers, but under watchful eyes

By HIMANI KOTHARI



PHOTO BY AMIT VERMA

INDIA IS A GROWING COUNTRY with a budding ecommerce market and the government would like to trust the companies to respect consumer rights on their own, says Nidhi Khare, secretary, Department of Consumer Affairs. That trust, though, has limits and action will be taken when it is violated. In an interview with *Forbes India*, Khare argues that fines for dark patterns are kept modest because higher penalties only push companies into long court battles, slowing down real action. Even so, she’s keeping an eye on how platforms behave. Her attention is also turning to influencers, especially those offering financial or health advice without the expertise to back it up. Excerpts:

Q It has been two months since GST 2.0 was implemented. Initially, there were some issues with GST cuts not being passed on. How is it going now?

When this transition happened, consumer complaints were high on the first day. But when we started analysing, we found out that a lot of these complaints were inquiries. A complaint that prominently figured was, why hasn’t milk become cheaper? But milk was never under GST. So, a lot of people were curious.

In collaboration with the Department of Revenue and CBIC, our call agents were able to satisfactorily answer many of these queries. In a week, the GST-related complaints started falling.

₹10-15 lakh

Fines imposed on companies, after investigation, for indulging in dark patterns



SHUTTERSTOCK

Q So, you're happy with the implementation?

Yes. Before September 22 [when the reduced GST rates were rolled out], we held at least two rounds of meetings with all the ecommerce entities, major retailers and FMCG companies. We told them: You have to announce the cuts and inform the consumers because that is one of the major consumer rights. The right to be informed is the first. It was a collaborative effort. There was an environment of trust. We trusted the companies to pass on the benefits to the consumers. And companies ensured the consumer right is respected.

Q The goal of the GST cuts was to ramp up consumption. Is that happening?

If you look at the auto sector, consumers looked at the GST cuts as a massive gain and sales have been blockbuster since. Cuts were also timed to roll out at the start of Navratri, which is a good time to buy things. Now the wedding season has started [so it should continue]. The cuts were timely.

Q Festive season tends to see a rise in dark pattern-related consumer complaints. What's being done to curb that? Companies were told to submit self-audits, what's the progress there?

We came out with the guidelines for prevention of dark patterns where we said it'll be treated as an unfair trade practice under the Consumer Protection Act because not only are you misinforming the consumer about the product or service, you are also trying to manipulate their choice.

In May, we called a meeting of all the prominent ecommerce platforms, since dark patterns are usually online. We told them we don't want to take the role of an inspector, so you audit yourself and submit reports. We gave the companies three months to self-audit their websites, apps and user interface, and they have complied. Almost all the big companies have submitted self-audits, about 26 to 29 of them. We have issued notices in, I think, 25 cases. Notices have gone out for false urgency, forced action, basket sneaking, nagging, confirm shaming, drip pricing and for the deceptive renewal of [Amazon] Prime membership. One order is out in the case of FirstCry.

Q Which period were these notices issued in? Since 2023?

We started issuing notices from last year, I believe. IndiGo is one example. It got notices for deploying dark patterns in the seat selection process. They changed their policy after that.

Q What happens after the submission of self-audits?

We will keep a watch on consumer complaints on dark patterns. If we find that some dark patterns are still being used even after the self-audits, we will take action as per law. We had given them a certain amount of time so that they could identify the dark patterns on their platforms. This was done so that they do not come to us later, saying they did not know something was a dark pattern.

"We are vigilant about the actions of companies. If consumers are impacted as a class, we will certainly take action."

Q If you find out that dark patterns still exist, when can we start seeing some crackdown?

As I said, we have already issued notices. Last year, we identified some cases. There was a big order on Rapido [it was fined ₹10 lakh for misleading ads]. If you claim that a consumer will get a refund and they book your service basis that claim, but later get to know that it is in the form of 'Rapido Coins' which anyway have to be redeemed within seven days... that's a clear dark pattern. It's another thing that Rapido has appealed against the order. But it hasn't challenged it on the merits of the case. So, what you're calling a 'crackdown' has already started.

Q There's an argument that the fines in India are not big enough to deter companies from deploying dark patterns. Globally, penalties have been much higher. Are there any such discussions in India to raise the fines?

We're a country which is still growing, and we would like to trust the companies that they would respect consumer rights and ensure they are protected. However, we are vigilant about their actions and if consumers are getting impacted as a class, we will certainly take action. And we have taken action. You're talking about fines—we have imposed the highest fine possible.

The quantum of fine is debatable. In my opinion, if the fines are too high, that also increases the chances of the order being challenged. Right now, our goal is to make the companies understand that they must respect consumer rights.

Q One encounters a lot of fake products online. Is anything being done to curb that?

If a brand has a trademark which is being abused, that is an issue taken care of by the commerce ministry or DPIIT. But if consumers write to us, we will take action.

Q What is your view on the lack of transparency by finfluencers and health influencers?

It's true that many influencers are doling out advice on topics where they are not experts. This issue is under examination. We will definitely take cognisance of things just like Sebi [Securities and Exchange Board of India] has done.

COLUMN



By HARJEET SINGH

COP30: A Widening Trust Deficit

For India, finance remains a problem, but a decision to develop a new just transition mechanism is a victory

AS BELÉM RETURNS TO ITS post-COP30 rhythm, the assessment of the summit's outcomes reveals a stark divergence between the geopolitical necessities of the Global South and the diplomatic offerings of the Global North. Billed as the "implementation COP", the negotiations in Brazil were expected to operationalise the ambitious promises of the past decade. Instead, on one hand, what emerged was a dynamic, solution-oriented push from the Global South outside the plenary, which contrasted with a gridlocked negotiation process inside, deeply constrained by vested interests.

For India and other developing economies, the results from Belém signal a troubling continuity: The multilateral system remains adept at setting targets but chronically unable to mobilise the finance required to meet them.

THE FINANCE GAP

The central metric of success, the 'New Collective Quantified Goal', failed to meet developing nations' evidence-based demand for $1.3 trillion in annual public grants. Instead, the 'Baku to Belém Roadmap' prioritises private finance and loans, exacerbating debt vulnerabilities rather than providing guaranteed funding.

Even the pledge to triple adaptation finance by 2035 rings hollow without a concrete delivery plan, effectively delaying urgent support. Crucially, India is unlikely to access a meaningful share of these



PABLO PORCIUNCULA / AFP

limited funds, which are prioritised for smaller, fragile nations. This leaves India to shoulder the immense cost of its catastrophic climate vulnerability almost entirely from its domestic budget.

Similarly, the $250 million pledged to the Fund for responding to Loss and Damage (FRLD), while a start, is analytically insignificant when compared to the estimated need of average $395 billion per year (according to the *Nature* magazine). To put this in perspective, the global oil and gas industry generates approximately $2.8 billion in daily profits (according to a July 2022 *Guardian* article). The disparity suggests a lack of proportionality in the global response, widening the trust deficit that plagues these negotiations.

CORPORATE INFLUENCE

A significant factor in the stagnation of ambition was the composition of the attendees. Analysis from the Kick Big Polluters Out coalition identified over 1,600 fossil fuel lobbyists at the summit—a figure representing one in every 25 participants. This bloc outnumbered the combined delegations of the 10 most climate-vulnerable nations.

The presence of such a concentrated interest group inevitably impacts policy output. It creates an environment where the "transition away from fossil fuels" agreed upon at COP28 is diluted by narratives that distract from the necessary rapid phase-out. Analytically, this capture explains why the text remains weak on 'supply-side' constraints despite the International Court of Justice, in its recent Advisory Opinion, affirming that phasing out fossil fuels is a legal obligation.

BEYOND RHETORIC

One of the most substantive policy debates at COP30 centred on the institutional architecture for a "Just Transition". The G77 and China successfully championed the "Belém Action Mechanism" (BAM), proposed by Climate Action Network International. This proposal is significant because it seeks to move beyond rhetoric to establish a funded, operational body designed to manage the socioeconomic impacts of the transition.

In contrast, the EU pushed for a framework lacking financial mandates. However, developing countries secured a strategic victory with a decision to develop the BAM by COP31 next November. This ensures that social protection and workforce displacement are finally treated as core governance challenges rather than mere externalities.

The missing variable remains the political will to disrupt incumbent economic and fossil fuel interests

IMPLICATIONS FOR INDIA

For India, the outcomes of COP30 present a complex strategic landscape.

First, the continued shortfall in public finance poses a tangible risk to India's renewable energy ambitions. Without grant-based and low-cost capital, the transition becomes significantly more expensive, potentially slowing the pace of deployment or forcing trade-offs with other developmental priorities.

Second, the debate over "Unilateral Trade Measures", such as the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism, remains a critical flashpoint. India, along with the BASIC group, has rightly identified these measures as protectionist instruments that shift the burden of decarbonisation onto developing economies. Belém failed to resolve the impasse but agreed to launch a series of annual dialogues in June over the next three years—involving key bodies like the WTO and UNCTAD—to scrutinise the barriers and opportunities for enhancing international trade cooperation.

GOVERNANCE OF FOSSIL FUELS

COP30 leaves us with a clear diagnosis. The technical solutions exist, and the legal mandates are clarifying. The missing variable remains the political will to disrupt incumbent economic and fossil fuel interests and deliver finance at the scale required. The stability of the global climate regime remained in question in Belém.

However, the most consequential development occurred outside the official UNFCCC plenary. Colombia's declaration on transitioning away from fossil fuels, with the support of over 80 countries, and the announcement of the First International Conference for the Phase Out of Fossil Fuels in April 2026, jointly hosted by the Netherlands, marks a potential turning point in climate governance. This nudged the COP president to announce a new roadmap on the transition away from fossil fuels under his leadership, drawing lessons from the upcoming April conference.

This move signals that many countries are increasingly willing to bypass the consensus-based paralysis of the UN process to forge "coalitions of the willing" and create a path towards a new Fossil Fuel Treaty to transition in a just and equitable manner. For the global climate regime, this fragmentation is a warning: If the multilateral process cannot deliver a credible plan to phase out fossil fuels and finance the transition, leadership will inevitably migrate elsewhere. The Paris Agreement remains valid, but it clearly requires 'retrofitting' from the outside to achieve its goals.

SINGH IS FOUNDING DIRECTOR OF SATAT SAMPADA CLIMATE FOUNDATION. HE IS THE GLOBAL CONVENOR OF THE FILL THE FUND CAMPAIGN AND STRATEGIC ADVISOR TO THE FOSSIL FUEL TREATY INITIATIVE

COLUMN



By LOUIS KUIJS

Growth Story

Robust domestic fundamentals and structural reforms are likely to keep India among the fastest-growing major economies in 2026

THE GLOBAL ECONOMY HAS held up despite US tariff hikes and related uncertainty, supported by artificial intelligence (AI)-driven investment, tech-related spending, lower inflation and accommodative financial conditions.

For the all-important US economy, we forecast real GDP growth of 2 percent in 2026—similar to 2025. Real consumer spending growth will hit a cycle low over the next two years, while AI-related infrastructure should sustain investment growth. We expect a 25-basis-point (bp) Fed rate cut in December, followed by 50 bps of easing over the second half of 2026, though timing may shift due to data delays.

Europe should again see modest growth in 2026, with Germany rebounding while others go slow. Disinflation potential appears limited, leaving little scope for additional rate cuts.

China's domestic demand will likely stay subdued, and exports should slow. But we have raised our 2026 growth forecast for China to 4.4 percent due to lower US tariffs. Across the rest of Asia-Pacific, reduced tariff uncertainty, strong tech exports and resilient demand have prompted us to lift our 2026 GDP forecast to 4.2 percent.

TARIFFS AND TRADE

The US trade policy continues to shape Asia-Pacific's external outlook. Higher effective tariffs on exports to the US are weighing on trade, prompting redirection to other markets and intensifying competition. The October US-China détente reduced global risk, but uncertainty persists, including from plans to curb 'transshipment', and the ongoing legal challenges.

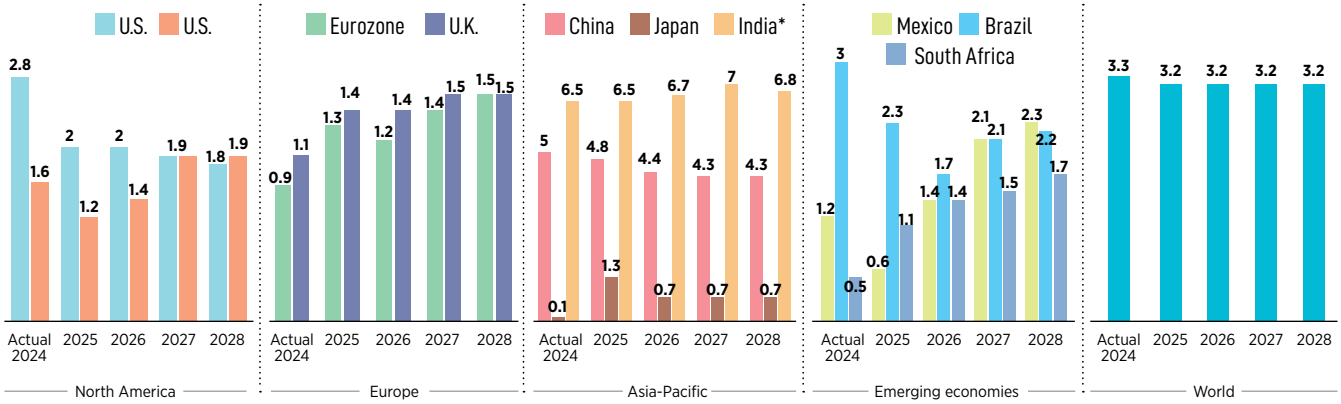
India faces the highest US tariffs in Asia, hurting exports and slowing



SHUTTERSTOCK

GDP Growth Forecasts Lifted Moderately For 2025 And 2026

In annual percentage change



SOURCE S&P Global Market Intelligence and S&P Global Ratings (Forecasts).

*Fiscal year, beginning April 1 in the reference calendar year.

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the expansion of export-oriented manufacturing.

A trade agreement with the US would reduce uncertainty and boost confidence, especially for labour-intensive sectors like textiles, gems and jewellery, and seafood, which account for nearly a quarter of India's exports to the US.

INDIA'S GROWTH DRIVERS

Despite external challenges, India should remain the fastest-growing major economy in 2026. We expect GDP growth of 7 percent in fiscal years 2026 and 2027, with risks evenly balanced. Within Asia, only Vietnam may achieve comparable growth. Robust domestic demand—both consumption and investment—will drive this performance.

Lower GST rates, income tax cuts and interest rate reductions will support middle-class consumption and help keep inflation contained. Consumption is likely to outpace investment as a growth driver this fiscal year and next.

Investment should remain solid, but the composition may shift. Infrastructure investment may moderate as government moves ahead on fiscal consolidation, while corporate investment—which has lagged in recent years—should gain momentum. Easier monetary and financial conditions, structural reforms like GST rationalisation and labour law overhaul, and healthy corporate balance sheets will support capex expansion. Rising manufacturing capacity utilisation could add further momentum.

The current US tariff situation limits the benefits India could reap from global supply chain shifts. But relief on the US tariff front would unlock investment in manufacturing by both foreign and domestic firms.

Sustained medium-term growth momentum will require ongoing reform efforts to adapt to the evolving world economic landscape. Efforts to improve infrastructure, with an emphasis on urban infrastructure, can increase productivity. India's female labour force participation rate remains low, and reforms supporting women's labour conditions could be key. Quick technology adoption—to remain at the forefront of the global technology frontier—will also be important.

INFLATION AND MONETARY POLICY

Like other Asian economies, India's short-term inflation outlook seems benign. We've reduced our CPI forecast to 2.5 percent for the current fiscal year because of low food and oil prices and GST rationalisation. Excess supply in China could exert downward pressure on import prices.

However, food inflation remains vulnerable to climate change. The rise of extreme weather events—such as excess rains affecting the autumn crop—may cause intermittent spikes. Low base effects mean food prices may rise in 2026-27.

Given these dynamics, the Reserve Bank of India has limited scope for further easing. The policy rate is already broadly at the "neutral" level, and the rupee weakness amid capital outflows and tariff uncertainty argues against significant further rate cuts. We expect one more 25 bps rate cut this cycle. With US rates expected to fall more, the increasing differential should provide some buffer against international shocks.

BOTTOM LINE

External headwinds—from tariffs to trade uncertainty—will persist. But India's strong domestic fundamentals, structural reforms and resilient consumption position it to remain the world's fastest-growing major economy in 2026.

(THE WRITER IS CHIEF ECONOMIST ASIA-PACIFIC, S&P GLOBAL RATINGS)

‘Business Education is More Meaningful Now Than Ever’

Francisco Veloso, dean of Insead, the business school ‘for the world’, on the shifting role of business education in times of geopolitical and economic uncertainty

By PANKTI MEHTA KADAKIA

WHEN INSEAD WAS BORN IN 1957 in Fontainebleau, France, Europe was emerging from the devastation of World War 2 and looking to rebuild. In 2000, it set up a campus in Singapore, and in 2007, in Abu Dhabi. In 2020, Insead launched its San Francisco hub for business innovation.

Envisioned as the ‘business school for the world’, its purpose is growing stronger in 2025, says its dean Francisco Veloso, as the world moves away from the paradigm of getting flatter, towards being more insular.

In Mumbai recently to celebrate 25 years of the Singapore campus, Veloso spoke with *Forbes India* about carefully watching the situation for foreign students in the US, why business education is key during tumultuous times, and the role India can play to dispel the US-versus-China narrative. Edited excerpts:


Francisco Veloso, dean, Insead

Q Insead celebrates 25 years of its Asia campus in Singapore. How has its presence in Asia evolved over the years?

This was a fundamental part of affirming the way we saw our role in the world—of creating this bridge between cultures, ideas and people. Students can start their MBA in Asia and move to Fontainebleau (France) or switch around. This opportunity will continue to strengthen because of the significant development trajectory that continues to exist in Asia.

The other part that is quite meaningful is to make sure that we use this presence in Asia to contribute

110
The number of nationalities that constitute MBA classes at Insead



to this better understanding in an environment where the world is becoming a little bit more polarised. We went from a paradigm where people were thinking that the world was going to become flatter. It is clear that that's not the direction we're going in. And so, we're going to have valleys and mountains, and the way to deal with them is through bridges.

We also want to develop an intellectual agenda that leverages our presence in Asia, and I'll give you two examples of that. One is considering what's happening with AI—the world often gets stuck between knowing what's happening in the US and in China, but there's a whole world beyond that. India is a big part of that story.

We're also committed to developing understanding around the growing relevance of private capital. Though we see that everywhere around the world, it has a distinct set of characteristics in Asia, with the rise of family offices, the importance of investment driven by the private sector. We want to make sure that we understand that and help shape the ecosystem through our intellectual leadership and executive education.



Q In an increasingly polarised world, what would you say the role of a global university like yours is?

It's precisely that ability to connect, as people become more insular. I'll take it back to our original identity. When Insead was created in 1957, the idea was we would bring cutting-edge management education to Europe, but also that Insead could contribute to strengthening the peace trajectory in Europe, following, of course, the devastating World War where Europe was the epicentre. That is through understanding and connection, because people were further apart, and there was a lot of rebuilding to be done.

In our student body, there is no one dominant culture. Diversity is a big part of the experience. An important part of our contribution to the world will be to bring people that have understanding of different cultures, understanding of nuance, and the toolkit to navigate in these times. We're training the next generation of leaders, and this is the specific skillset that the MBA programme brings.

Q You're looking to expand in the US. People in India are nervous about higher education in the US now, because of the government's changing policies towards foreign students. What does this mean for a school like yours?

We don't offer degree programmes in the US yet, but we have a hub in San Francisco and a long-standing partnership with Wharton. However, we are a business school for the world, and the US is, of course, a big part of that, as is Asia. We want to build a stronger presence there, and we have a few ideas, but we are paying attention to the latest developments.

At the moment, we have not seen any meaningful movement, in terms of student applications and enrollment. I had a meeting with deans of several other leading business schools in Europe during the summer, and the picture that emerged out of the first few months seemed to be relatively consistent—which is some movement on the undergraduates, which is in line with the points you made. With undergraduates, younger parents are worried, saying, 'I don't want my son or my daughter to be in a difficult situation in the US'. They are a little bit more concerned about graduate education there, which pertains to adults pursuing professional careers, who may consider that, you know, every place has trade-offs.

We're all curious about what's going to happen this year. When some of these challenging decisions and situations started to happen, a lot of the application processes were in their final stages last year. By January, when second rounds of applications are going to be closing across graduate business schools around the world, including ours, we will start to have a clearer picture of how it is playing out.

Q In an environment like this, what would you say is the role of business education?

Business education today, I would say, is more meaningful than it has

ever been. It is also shifting, changing in important ways. As I said, we're in the business of training leaders, and leaders need to be prepared to navigate these treacherous times, but also an environment with an amazing set of opportunities.

If we go back to previous rocky periods, that's when a lot of innovation took place. The financial crisis of 2008-2009—that's when WhatsApp was created. That's when Facebook, Uber took off. Periods of uncertainty and periods of change are also periods of fundamental transformation.

So, for us at Insead, it means making sure we are at the cutting edge of understanding how these transformations are taking place, be it on the supply chains, structures side because of trade barriers and other aspects, or on the technical side, understanding how AI is shaping processes, systems, teams. We need to make sure that we double down on having our academics at the forefront of understanding that, so that we can bring it to the classroom, and effectively contribute to preparing this new generation of leaders.

Q Has AI changed the university application process, which relies heavily on students' personal essays?

Essays for us are an important force. But I would say it's only one component. What we want through the essays is fundamental—a way for the person to be reflective about their journey, especially for the MBA.

The average student applies for the MBA when they're 27, 28 years old. So, what we ask of the essays is for them to reflect on their professional trajectory. And so, while your favourite LLM [large language model] may make sure that you have a good narrative, that you explain things well, it's still fundamentally about what you did and why you did it, what you felt and what you learnt. No LLM could tell me what I learnt. We also have

PHOTO COURTESY INSEAD



Insead set up its Singapore campus in 2000

standardised test scores, which take place in controlled environments, and interviews conducted by our faculty and alumni. It's a robust process that goes beyond the essays.

I can see how this is a larger problem for undergraduate education, where many high school students with good grades have similar trajectories. Schools might decide to go back to more time and resource-intensive methods, such as interviews in person.

Q Where does India stand in Insead's global strategy? What trends have you observed among Indian students?

India is an absolutely central market. Not only is it the most represented population in our community no matter what slice you take, whether students or faculty, it's also one of the top five countries globally for our custom programmes. These are programmes that we work with individual companies to design, tailored to their needs. This is an important aspect for us.

That's from the point of our activity. But in my view, and in that of the school, India is also a very important actor globally. Not only because of its amazing economic trajectory; it's also probably, together with Europe, one of the only countries that can help the world not be dominated by the polarisation of China versus the US. We need strong actors that show the world that it goes beyond that.

We want to be part of the India story today and in the future, because the strength of India is good for the world. It's also interesting, as a lot of successful families in India are creating family offices. These family offices are very well connected to both the Middle East and Singapore, where our campuses are, because those are important routes by which both deploy and mobilise capital.

India is important for the world, and it's important for us. That's why we are and will continue to be engaged here, hopefully both learning from and contributing to this trajectory.

There's amazing innovation... that India is at the forefront of the digital side, in so many different dimensions, and this is an important story to be amplified to the world. We can be one of the vehicles of that amplification. I'm happy to do so, because that's how we learn, and how we are able to relay a multi-dimensional view of the world that's not just dominated by two or three narratives, because we know that's not the way the world works. F

₹3.2 cr

The price tag for Deepti Sharma at the recent WPL auction, up from ₹2.6 crore in the inaugural edition



REUTERS

NEWSMAKER

A Square Cut Above

Her all-round masterclass in the ODI World Cup and skyrocketing valuation in the Women's Premier League has moved Deepti Sharma from the fringes to the spotlight

By KATHAKALI CHANDA

DEEPTI SHARMA'S ENTRY INTO cricket was fortuitous. The Agra girl was spotted by former player Hemlata Kala when one of her throws, fired from the sidelines of a match she had gone to watch as a kid, uprooted the stumps a good 40-odd metres away.

As far as accidents go, women's cricket in India couldn't have asked for a happier one. For, years after that chance discovery, the 28-year-old would go on to become key to India's historic first ODI World Cup triumph. In a tournament that had a slew of stellar Indian performers—Smriti Mandhana, Pratika Rawal, Jemimah Rodrigues, Shafali Verma and the likes—Sharma stood out as the most definitive. She walked away with the Player of the Tournament award after scoring 200-plus runs and taking 20-plus wickets, becoming the first cricketer ever to achieve the double in a single edition of the World Cup. But that's not all.

A month later, Sharma continues to make headlines as the most expensive cricketer in this year's Women's Premier League (WPL) auction, ahead of the likes of Amelia Kerr, the Player of the Tournament in the women's T20I World Cup in 2024. Picked up by the UP Warriorz (UPW) for ₹3.2 crore, up from ₹2.6 crore in the inaugural auction, the allrounder's price tag is also the second-highest ever in the league—after Mandhana's ₹3.4 crore (for Royal Challengers Bengaluru in 2023).

"In my first year in the WPL, I had told Deepti that while everyone is talking about other players, she was the only premium Indian all-rounder around, and that she should be the face of the WPL," says Lisa Sthalekar, former Australia captain, commentator and now the mentor of UPW, Sharma's WPL team in the first three seasons. Her words were vindicated in 2024 when Sharma emerged as the Most Valuable Player (MVP) of the second season that included the league's first hat-trick by an Indian.

But, for most of her career, Sharma remained a cricketer whose impact was felt more than being spoken about. Public memory is too fickle to remember that while Harmanpreet Kaur had gone on her genre-defining rampage of 171 in the 2017 ODI World Cup semifinal against Australia, it was Sharma who held the other end down to stitch a partnership of 137 runs over nearly 14 overs. Or that, in 2023, she single-handedly defeated England in a Test match in Mumbai, taking nine wickets across two innings and scoring a half-century in the first.

India's World Cup victory followed by her record-breaking valuation at the WPL has finally made Sharma a household name, enabling her to step out of the shadows of her more recognised and flamboyant colleagues. And that's no mean feat.

Asked in a previous interview with *Forbes India* which she enjoys more, batting or bowling, Sharma had shot back: "Why just these? I enjoy fielding too." It betrayed Sharma's obsession with the sport, and, at this moment, it is cricket that's richer for it.



PHOTO BY MATT ROBERTS-ICC/ICC VIA GETTY IMAGES

Deepti Sharma
Cricketer

Double Impact

- Player of the tournament in India's victorious World Cup campaign
- Becomes first cricketer ever to score 200-plus and take 20-plus wickets in a single World Cup
- At ₹3.2 crore, becomes the most expensive WPL pick this year and the second-most expensive ever



PHOTOGRAPHS BY MADHU KAPPARATH



Team ChrysCapital: Kunal Shroff (seated, left), managing partner; Sanjay Kukreja (seated, right), partner & CIO; (standing, from left) Sanjiv Kaul, partner; Ashley Menezes, partner & COO; Gaurav Ahuja, partner

Home Team

In a landscape dotted with the biggest global names, ChrysCap has held its own. Now, having raised the largest India-focussed fund ever, it must break fresh ground

By **HIMANI KOTHARI & PAYAL GANGULY**

In 2007, the year ChrysCapital first wrote a cheque to Mankind Pharma, the drugmaker was in the public eye for its Manforce brand of condoms. It had become a full-fledged pharma company by the time the private equity (PE) firm exited in 2015.

Along the way, Mankind, nudged by ChrysCapital, got into chronic therapies and stepped out of its small-town comfort zone. Today, nearly a third of Mankind's business comes from chronic therapies and metros bring in two-thirds of its revenues. The company also acquired Bollywood icon Amitabh Bachchan as its corporate brand ambassador, while actor Sunny Leone came on board as the face of its condom brand.

"Truly transformative," says Mankind's global CFO, Ashutosh Dhawan, describing the repositioning, "especially in shaping product strategy and sharpening our thinking on how to build big, profitable brands".

Mankind was not the only party in this relationship to reap the benefits. ChrysCapital's initial ₹100 crore investment yielded 11 times more in returns when it exited Mankind in 2015, selling its stake to Capital International.

"That growth did not happen by accident," adds Dhawan. "ChrysCapital had strong domain knowledge in pharma, so it was able to guide and mentor us effectively."

The PE firm returned to Mankind in 2018, picking up a 10 percent stake, trimmed its position in the company's public float in 2023, and exited entirely by 2024. But it is ChrysCapital's first stint with Mankind that presents a peek into the playbook the homegrown firm has followed—and helped write—as India's PE sector took its first baby steps at the turn of the century, buoyed by the dotcom boom, rattled along through the global financial crisis of 2008, rode the

waves of telecom and technology, and has now reached a place where deal sizes are larger, buyouts are burgeoning, and interest in India-focussed funds is at an all-time high.

A report by Equirus Capital says PE and venture capital (VC) investments in the country touched a three-year high of $26 billion in the first nine months of this calendar year, surpassing the combined figure for 2023 and 2024. This despite the high valuations commanded by the public markets, which tend to channel funds from PE to listed stocks.

ChrysCapital, for its part, raised its 10th and largest fund of $2.2 billion—the largest India-focussed fund anyone has raised—in November. What's more, this fund has become its first to attract money from Indian investors, in addition to the usual sovereign and endowment funds from abroad, enhancing the Indianness of its appeal, which it has leveraged during its rise to becoming the largest homegrown PE firm. With $8.5 billion raised across its 10 PE funds, a continuation vehicle, and a public markets fund, ChrysCapital holds its own among the biggest global names in the fray, such as Blackstone, KKR, Warburg Pincus, Carlyle and Temasek.



"Institutional capital is 50 percent of our domestic fund. It has the potential to be a lot more. Family offices (and their contribution to future funds) will grow as well."

ASHLEY MENEZES,
partner and COO; also leads the finance and legal functions

CHRYSALIS TO CHRYSCAPITAL

The year was 1999, the dotcom boom was in full swing, and New York's financial district hummed with the promise of easy money. Ashish Dhawan was 29 and on a lucrative ascent at Goldman Sachs, the Wall Street giant. He chose to walk away and boarded a plane to India with the audacious idea of importing Silicon Valley's VC playbook into a market still seen as untested terrain.

Together with his Harvard batchmate Raj Kondur, Dhawan co-founded ChrysCapital (then called Chrysalis Capital). After the

A 25-Year Journey



1999
ChrysCapital starts with a **$64 million** debut fund. India barely has a **PE industry** at the time. **ChrysCapital** bets early on IT and financial services

2001
Fund II raised at **$127 million**. Firm expands focus into infra and manufacturing services

2002
Spectramind exit returns the entire **first fund**. The firm instantly becomes India's breakout **PE story**

2004-05
Raises Fund III ($258 million) and **IV ($556 million)**. Pharma and financial services bets would eventually deliver **blockbuster** returns



2007-09
Fund V hits **$1.25 billion**, India's first billion-dollar PE fund. **Global crisis** forces a reset; **ChrysCapital** returns unused capital and refocuses its strategy

2008-10
Buys into **HCL Tech** and **Infosys** during the market crash; exits Infosys with a **129 percent** gain



2011-12
Founder **Ashish Dhawan** steps back **Next-gen** partnership takes over in **'Version 2.0'**—the post-Dhawan era. **Fund VI** shrinks to a disciplined **$510 million**

dotcom bubble burst, it did not take the duo long to realise the VC model did not work for them. They quickly transitioned to PE and began a journey of growth that has continued despite Dhawan's exit from the company in 2012. Kondur had left in 2002 to start a business process outsourcing firm called Nirvana Business Solutions.

Through its PE funds, the firm has deployed $5.5 billion in more than 110 companies. It has already returned $7.8 billion—a three-fold return on investment—to its investors through 80-odd exits.

But the last 25 years were not a breeze. When ChrysCapital started, it was an unknown name in an industry that itself was unknown in India.

"Twenty years ago, you had to really fight with the entrepreneur to get them to dilute stake. It was mostly, 'Oh I only want to give 5 percent', and us on the other hand going, 'No, we want 10 percent'," says Kunal Shroff, the firm's managing partner.

So, what changed?

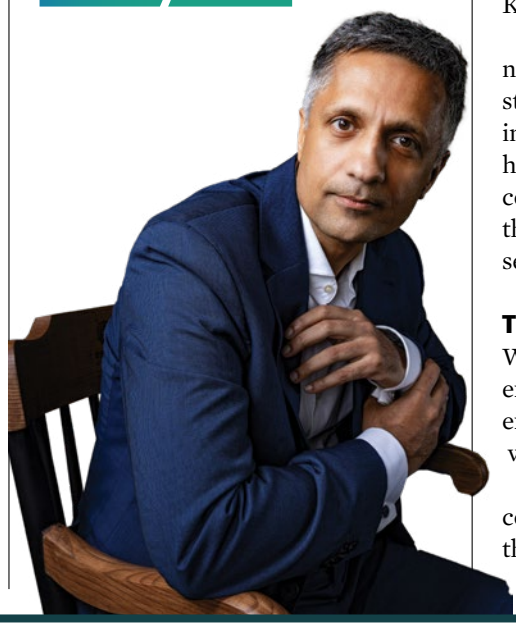
For one, the ChrysCapital brass believes, the firm's track record of transforming companies and enhancing value began to resonate with entrepreneurs. Second, succession happened at family businesses. The new generation does not automatically want to take over the business and run it, especially where the group's best days may be behind it. Third, ChrysCapital got better at it.

"When we started, there were a lot of things we were learning on the go," says Sanjay Kukreja, partner and CIO.

More entrepreneurs are now willing to give up larger stakes. Almost half of the deals in ChrysCapital's ninth fund have resulted either in giving it control or joint control. Along the way, ChrysCapital developed sector-specific expertise.

"There will always be missed opportunities. But you have to accept you won't get everything right—the key is learning and adjusting."

KUNAL SHROFF, managing partner



THE CHRYSCAPITAL PLAYBOOK

Working with PE is a challenging, exciting and stimulating experience, says an executive who has worked with PE firms.

When a PE firm invests in a company, it usually focuses on three areas: One is profitable growth. Second is governance,

2015-17

A run of **mega stake sales**—Intas, Mankind, tech deals—cements **ChrysCapital** as India's most **consistent** returns machine

2016-19

Funds VII ($600 million) and **VIII ($867 million)** scale up the mid-market strategy. Adds a prized stake in the **National Stock Exchange**



2018

LiquidHub exit **(about $500 million)** becomes one of the largest by an **India-focussed PE firm**

2020

A rare write-off: **Mandhana Retail** stake goes to zero

MRVL
MANDHANA RETAIL VENTURES LTD.

2021

Infogain exit **(about $900 million)** surpasses **LiquidHub** as its biggest; proves the **firm's tech investing** chops

2022-24

Launches Clarus **(public markets vehicle).** Creates a **$700 million** continuation fund to hold **NSE longer**

2025



Closes **Fund X** at **$2.2 billion**, the largest India-focussed **PE fund** ever

which enhances valuation, raising the value of the PE firm's holding above the price it paid. The third thing, says the executive, is a sense of accountability for the promoter, which is important because in family businesses, it is sometimes difficult for the professionals to question the promoter. "But PE brings in best practices, mainly by benchmarking your actions against what rivals are doing," says the executive.

When ChrysCapital works with a company, a big focus area is inorganic growth. "We have done more than 50 M&A (mergers and acquisitions) transactions in our portfolio companies with a very high degree of success," says Kukreja.

In 2016, ChrysCapital wanted Intas, the pharma company, to acquire Actavis to strengthen its play in the retail markets of the UK and Ireland. "They told us: *Aap log dekh lo* (you guys evaluate it and decide)," says Shroff, highlighting the trust entrepreneurs place in the PE firm.

ChrysCapital also got Intas to invest in newer areas like biopharma. These interventions change companies. When ChrysCapital entered Hero Fincorp, it was a strong NBFC (non-banking financial company). The firm suggested a move into housing finance; today, that business is the same size as Hero Fincorp's entire operation at the time of ChrysCapital's investment.

"Our goal is to ensure the company we exit five years later is a very different one from the company we enter," says Kukreja.

Awfis provides a more recent example. Amit Ramani, chairman and MD at Awfis Space Solutions, says: "Chrys came in around 2019, at a time when we were moving from a classic startup phase to a more scaled, growth-stage company. That transition is tricky for any founder—you are still building, but the expectations on structure, governance and predictability go up sharply."

ChrysCapital's biggest contribution, he says, was helping Awfis think from first principles, which is a set of the most fundamental and important reasons for doing or believing something. Corporate strategists use this technique to break down complicated problems and generate original solutions.

"They pushed us to be very clear on unit economics, returns on every rupee deployed, and what levers really matter for sustainable growth. That led to sharper choices—diversifying the business thoughtfully, building multiple lines like managed offices and design and build, and being more disciplined in how and where we expanded," says Ramani.

ChrysCapital encouraged the flexible workspace operator to upgrade leadership, tighten governance and put in place incentives for the team to align with long-term value creation, not just

Key Numbers

- **1999** Year it was founded
- **$8.5 bln*** **Approximate** amount raised
- **110+** **Portfolio** companies invested in
- **$5.5 bln+** Amount **deployed**
- **80+** Exits
- **$7.8 bln** Returned to investors, at **3x RoI**

*Across 10 PE funds, one continuation vehicle, and a public markets fund



"Our goal is to ensure that the company we exit five years later is a very different one from the company we enter. And it's our job to create that."

SANJAY KUKREJA,
partner and chief investment officer

short-term targets. In many ways, says Ramani, ChrysCapital helped Awfis shift from a "fast-growing startup" to an "enduring platform". That was critical in getting Awfis ready for the public markets.

ENHANCIN PORTFOLIO VALUE

ChrysCapital began as a generalist VC investor, but by 2015 realised specialisation was essential, says Rishi Sahai, managing director at Cogence Advisors, a mid-market investment bank. "Their biggest successes—Mankind, Eris Lifesciences, Intas and other pharma-health care bets—came after they developed deep domain expertise in those areas, which have now become their defining edge," he says.

Success also comes from knowing what to avoid. The focus remains on three things: Return on capital employed, alignment with the entrepreneur and sector expertise, and avoiding anything that does not meet these criteria.

ChrysCapital has a portfolio value creation team called Enhancin, which is a bunch of people who sit with companies where the firm has invested once or twice a week to help them work through issues. Sanjiv Kaul, a partner at the firm, says ChrysCapital realised seven to eight years ago that merely working with the entrepreneur at the board level was not going to bring in the changes required to drive profitability, which was critical to bump up valuation and allow ChrysCapital a successful exit. That led to the birth of Enhancin.

This team does cost optimisation, supply chain management, board governance, M&A activities and even helps recruit CXOs—not only at the companies ChrysCapital controls but also where it is an investor without having control.

"In every sector we have almost about 200 folks whom we know and who we can bring to the table," says Kaul.

Fifteen companies in ChrysCapital's portfolio have floated initial public offers and more are in the pipeline.

"One of the biggest differentiators for ChrysCapital is our portfolio value creation team, Enhancin."

SANJIV KAUL,
partner, Enhancin team, operating advisors as well as HR report to him



EVOLVING EQUITY

During this prolonged exuberance in the stock markets, when limited partners (LPs)—people and entities who park their money with PEs, VCs and other funds—can invest directly and profitably in listed stocks, what is ChrysCapital's appeal?

Shroff's answer—met with chuckles all around the table—was disarmingly simple: "It is Gaurav Ahuja."

Ahuja, one of the partners at the firm, is all seriousness. "Our flagship is the PE practice, but we also have a public market fund for people who are looking for more liquid strategies." They can choose either based on their risk appetite.

The public markets fund—Clarus—was launched in March 2023 and has consistently outperformed the benchmark indices. "We have delivered four to five percentage points of alpha, which is actually quite good, given how good the market has been over the past two-and-a-half-years," says Shroff.

Ahuja says investors come to ChrysCapital for three things: Longevity of the fund, stability of the team and consistency. "And we have delivered that even though we went through a founder transition."

THE HANDOVER

That founder transition—Dhawan's departure 13 years ago—could have rattled the firm. Instead, it became an unlikely proof of strength.

"The firm has built institutional rigour and operated with open communication and transparent disclosures on a par with many global firms from the very beginning," says Sunil Mishra, partner, Primary Investments Asia, Adams Street Partners, a Chicago-

headquartered private markets investment manager which invests as an LP with ChrysCap. Adams Street has $65 billion in assets and has invested more than $1 billion in India over the last 20 years across a dozen PE and VC firms.

It was one of the first global fund of funds to invest in ChrysCap, in 2004. "This was Adams Street's first investment in Asia and in India. We actually got to know the team when they were raising their first fund in 1999," adds Mishra.

COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

For global PEs, the minimum ticket size for investing in India is $500 million and above. Smaller domestic PEs, which have raised $300-500 million funds, can do deals worth $25-50 million. ChrysCapital sits somewhere in the middle, with an average ticket size of $150 million.

But there are challenges.

Pharma and health care, one of the areas where ChrysCapital has a high degree of expertise, is getting better with an infusion of PE money. It is also an area that touches lives directly and yet health care infrastructure is woefully inadequate in the country. PEs are accelerating the formalisation of the sector and scaling it up.

However, India does not have infinite pharma companies or hospitals worth investing in. "Also, the global mega-funds—Blackstone, Carlyle—have deeper pockets and can afford to take bigger bites. So ChrysCapital sometimes ends up sharing good deals, instead of owning them entirely," says Sahai of Cogence. "That is why you increasingly see them explore adjacencies—education financing, selective consumer bets like Lenskart, and digital-enabled businesses."

These are opportunistic moves, not core to the long-term strategy. But ChrysCapital has a tailwind in regulation. "Regulations (around raising capital) have changed, and are still changing," says Ashley Menezes, partner and COO at the firm. He goes on to list the positives: "Institutional capital is 50 percent of our domestic fund. It has potential to be a lot more. Family offices will grow as well, but there are still some bottlenecks. But it is changing. The good thing is, the regulator recognises PE as a big contributor and is having those conversations with the large PE groups on what can be done to enable raising of capital."

"Competition from global PE is an opportunity. Their large capital pools bring greater visibility to Indian PE; they're also an exit avenue for us."

GAURAV AHUJA, partner; leads fundraising efforts and investor relations



NEXT LEG OF GROWTH

Growth comes from scaling up Clarus, the public markets fund, from continuing to do well in PE, and from scaling that over time in a measured way, says Shroff. "And then potentially thinking of areas where we have a right to win within the broader alternative space. That is the longer-term journey for us."

ChrysCapital has built its reputation on deep domain expertise. But it needs to evolve from being a pure-play PE fund into a broader asset manager, says Sahai. "The natural next step for them is private credit. They should also look at hybrid return profiles, more control and buyouts. They also must diversify geographically."

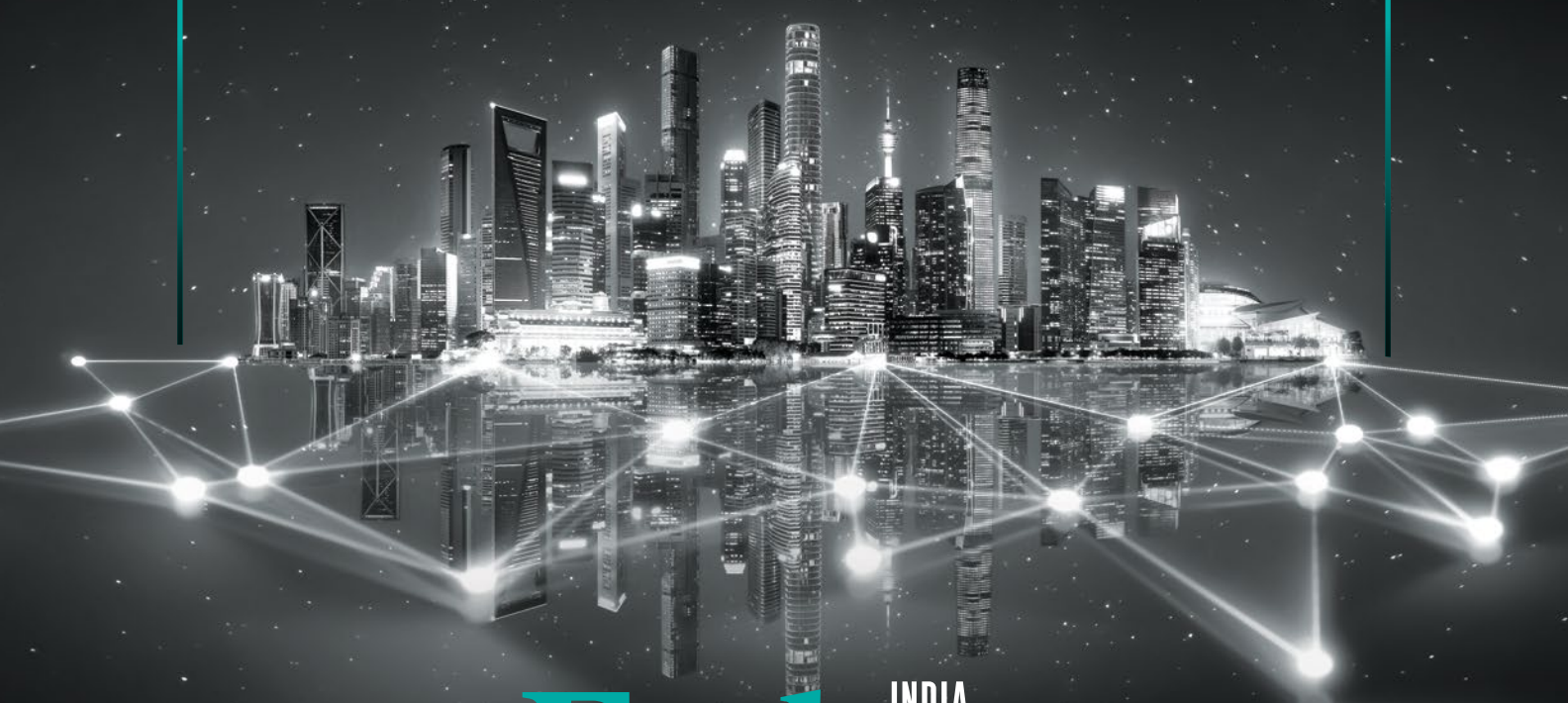
Within ChrysCapital, the partners agree evolution is necessary, though abrupt shifts are unlikely. "We will keep learning from our mistakes and other people's successes, and evolve," says Shroff.

Manufacturing, once an occasional bet, is back on the table as India gains global tailwinds. "We are working along those lines," says Shroff. He, however, adds: "It won't be any major shift between one fund and the other, but changes based on our learnings."

Kukreja strikes a more ebullient note. "I hope over the next 10 years, India and Indian institutions discover PE, just the way they did equity in the previous 10," he says.

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Ready for Battle

FY26 has seen a flurry of private equity investors pumping money into some of India's promising mid-sized banks, which are now ready to scale up and compete with the larger banks

By **SALIL PANCHAL**

It would be fair to assume that there is a pattern to the exuberance of investments flowing towards some of India's banks and non-banking financial companies (NBFCs), considering that seven deals were announced in 2025, five of these in the first seven months of FY26. One of these—the UAE-based Emirates NBD Bank investing approximately $3 billion (₹26,850 crore) into RBL Bank (see table)—when completed, will be the largest ever foreign direct investment (FDI) in the domestic financial services sector and the largest ever equity fund raise in the Indian banking sector.

In all, nearly ₹50,000 crore will be invested in four banks and Sumitomo Mitsui Banking Corporation (SMBC) will buy out the stake of State Bank of India and other banks in Yes Bank to become its largest shareholder with a 24.99 percent stake. Add to this, in March 2025, private equity giant Bain Capital announced a move to get joint control in Kerala's gold financier Manappuram Finance, and Bajaj Group bought back stakes in existing insurance joint ventures with Allianz.

So is India's financial sector the most sought-after amongst global economies for capital providers?

MORE REGULATORY COMFORT

Capital providers have always been willing to look at India favourably. Between 2002 and 2008, there were several deals, though smaller in size. Amsterdam-headquartered ING had hiked its stake in ING Vysya Bank to near 43 percent in 2002 before ING Vysya Bank was acquired by Kotak Mahindra Bank in 2015. Temasek Holdings acquired a stake in ICICI Bank in 2003, before nearly selling the entire stake by 2012 and Rabobank acquired a near-20 percent stake in Yes Bank in 2004, before paring it down and finally exiting India in 2021.

But somehow, "the regulatory comfort was not present at that time", a banking research analyst tells *Forbes India*, on condition of anonymity, speaking about the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) approach to foreign capital into India's banks. Earlier it seemed policy makers were not ready to welcome more players or they were not able to ring fence and monitor them better. The RBI, has, since 2017, flexed its muscles not just as a regulator but also as a supervisor. It has been unforgiving



The Post-deal Strategies For Growth

Yes Bank

Yes Bank will benefit from SMBC's long-term presence and promise of permanent capital. Yes Bank can provide additional financial services to SMBC's overseas clients through digital banking. Yes Bank will continue to build its wealth management business, wholesale banking, SME and retail banking verticals.

Sammaan Capital

This might emerge as a tranformational deal for Sammaan Capital. The aim for the management will be to build a credible liability franchise and help lower the cost of funds.



Under R Subramaniakumar, managing director and CEO, RBL Bank has seen positives. In February 2025, the RBI extended his term by three years, to June 22, 2028

RBL Bank

The huge capital infusion from Emirates NBD Bank will over-capitalise RBL Bank, boosting capabilities and balance sheet strength. It is expected to become an important player in payments-to trade between UAE and India, NRI business, wealth management, cross-border trade and forex management.

Federal Bank

Under KVS Manian's leadership, the bank will continue on its strategy to drive faster CASA growth, enhance yields and boost fee income. Blackstone's synergies will help Federal Bank access investee companies and strengthen corporate credibility.

SOURCE Forbes India

in extending the tenures of some of India's most prominent bankers, including Rana Kapoor (Yes Bank) and Shikha Sharma (Axis Bank).

In other cases, it took independent disciplinary action against HDFC Bank, Kotak Mahindra Bank and card issuer Visa, which were later lifted once the issues were resolved.

Over the past decade, there has also been a change in the countries and foreign investors keen to bring capital into India. Singapore, the UAE, Japan and Canada have been seen as acceptable friends with India and feature high on the list of countries providing FDI. It is no coincidence then that these four countries have been capital providers to India's financial services sector in 2025.

It must be noted here that RBI, in 2020, announced and later approved a scheme for the ailing Lakshmi Vilas Bank to be merged with Singapore-based DBS Bank. The latter got an approval from the RBI to become a wholly-owned-subsidiary (WOS) in 2017.

Ashish Jhaveri, managing director and head of India Investment Banking at Jefferies India, tells *Forbes India*: "These deals provide confidence to the public markets in a massive way that bigger institutions are investing into India's banks. It has triggered more incremental people to look at India now."

There is data that makes banks and financial institutions worthy winners. Private banks did show resilience across tough cycles (Covid-19 and the global financial crisis) and grew 15 percent annually over the past 20 years, supported by India's 10 percent nominal GDP growth, low credit penetration (58 percent versus 170 percent in China and 200 percent in the UK), and steady market share gains from state-owned banks.

Jhaveri says investor interest was always strong and is now stronger: "India is a different market in terms of scale, growth and quality: The balance sheets of banks are much stronger and their metrices are good, making them attractively priced. There is a strong value creation thesis for private equity, given the depth of the industry. For strategic investors, India was always an attractive destination."

Jefferies India has been among the most active investment banks in lending deals: These have included Yes Bank, Aavaas Financiers, HDB Financial Services, Sammaan Capital (formerly Indiabulls Housing Finance) and Credila Financial Services. In the case of Sammaan Capital, Abu Dhabi-based International Holding Company (IHC) said it will acquire a 43.4 percent stake.

"The advantage that India brings is that these investors are entering when banks are of scale, opportunities are huge, economic growth stable and balance sheets of banks are clean, besides being regulated," Jhaveri says. Also, at this scale, in other economies one would not find long-term credit growth of 12-13 percent and a return on assets (RoA) and return on equity (RoE) expansion story that will play out more.



PHOTO BY MADHU KAPPARATH

BUILDING SCALE, FAST

The fresh capital infusion or strategic investment now indicates the

Under KVS Manian, Federal Bank has delivered 13 percent ROE in FY25 versus around 5 percent for its mid-sized peers, driven by disciplined lending and a good quality book

commentary for most of these private sector banks, which is to climb to that No 5 position, behind the Big 4 private lenders: HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, Axis Bank and Kotak Mahindra Bank.

Rajeev Ahuja, executive director with RBL Bank is a happy man, now that the bank will be armed with $3 billion that Emirates NBD will invest into RBL, making it the largest FDI into India's banking sector. On November 12, the RBL Bank top management got the approval of legacy shareholders for the capital infusion from Emirates NBD Bank.

On October 18, the boards of RBL Bank and Emirates NBD Bank had approved the agreements, through which the latter will make a primary infusion of near $3 billion into RBL Bank to gain a controlling stake.

Emirates NBD Bank operates in India as a foreign bank under the branch mode, offering trade finance, treasury services, bilateral and syndicated loans, and assisting the needs of non-resident Indians (NRIs). Once the entire deal is complete, RBL Bank will become a subsidiary of the foreign bank.

"This deal allows us to change the trajectory of our journey, which will help boost our capability and also balance sheet strength. Whatever plans we had over the next five to seven years can be brought a little ahead and we can add new lines of business," Ahuja told *Forbes India* on November 17. "This gives us opportunity to accelerate our growth in both retail and wholesale banking," he said.

Under R Subramaniakumar, current managing director and CEO, RBL Bank has seen positives: A granularisation of deposits, a diversified lending portfolio, particularly moving towards secured lending and entering FY26 with zero NPA in the troubled microfinance sector. In February 2025, the RBI extended Subramaniakumar's term by three years, to June 22, 2028.

For any bank, scaling up is important, whether it be investment in technology, cyber security, risk management or infrastructure. Scaling up brings the ability to unlock operating leverage more efficiently.

"There are benefits with Emirates NBD Bank that we could build, such as enhance capabilities and provide new product lines for growth, becoming an important 'payments-to-trade' player in the corridor between UAE and India; the NRI business, wealth management, cross-border trade and forex management [see table]. UAE is an important landing ground for Indian businesses for operations in North Africa, Middle East, Central Asia. There are also points of convergence between customers in the UAE and India, who will benefit from seamless cross-border banking between the two banks," Ahuja said.

The RBL Bank stock has risen surged 98 percent in 2025 to ₹312 at the BSE by November 29.



PHOTO BY MEXY XAVIER

Prior to Prashant Kumar becoming CEO of Yes Bank in March 2020, the bank had struggled with weakening asset quality due to indiscriminate lending

In October 2025, Blackstone announced that it will invest about ₹6,197 crore ($705 million) into India's Federal Bank, through a preferential issue of warrants for a 9.9 percent stake to Blackstone affiliate firm Asia II Topco XIII Pte (see table). This deal will make the affiliate the largest single shareholder in the bank.

Federal Bank shareholders approved the contours of the deal on November 20. Blackstone will pay 25 percent of the warrant price upfront, when subscribing to the warrants; 75 percent will be payable upon conversion into equity shares, within 18 months, which is the tenor of the warrant. The deal will make the private equity firm the largest shareholder in the bank.

Federal Bank, under KVS Manian's leadership, has delivered 13 percent ROE in FY25 versus around 5 percent for its mid-sized peers, driven by disciplined lending and a good quality book. Federal Bank is a leader in gold loans among private banks and ranks third in NRI deposits and inward remittances. The bank has been shifting its asset portfolio to medium yielding, secured retail, granular SME and mid-corporate segments.

Manian, a veteran from Kotak Mahindra Bank, has often highlighted that Federal Bank's liabilities franchise is strong, with a low-cost granular deposit base and sticky customers, and is not completely interest rate-driven.



PHOTO BY MEXY XAVIER

"We are coming here with the horizon of building, staying as permanent capital."

RAJEEV KANNAN,
Head of India division & managing executive officer, SMBC Group

"Federal Bank has gone through its own process of stabilisation. The former managing director Shyam Srinivasan did a great job, Manian is there to take the franchise to the next level. To do that you need to make investments, getting into newer areas as well," an investment banker tells *Forbes India*, declining to be named.

Blackstone declined to talk about the specific strategies being outlined for Federal Bank, but Mukesh Mehta, Blackstone's senior managing director in Mumbai, tells *Forbes India*: "This partnership underscores our strong conviction in Federal Bank's robust franchise and the growth potential of the Indian banking system."

Japan's Sumitomo Mitsui Banking Corporation's (SMBC) deal with Yes Bank is slightly different from other banks. There is no direct capital infusion but SMBC has bought out stakes that State Bank of India (SBI) and other banks had acquired in Yes Bank in 2020, when it needed to be recapitalised, post a moratorium.

In an exclusive interview with *Forbes India*, during an India visit in October, SMBC Group's head of India division and managing executive officer Rajeev Veeravalli Kannan said that they "felt there is a pathway for us to contribute meaningfully for its next phase of growth".

SBI, which still holds a 10.8 percent stake in Yes Bank, will continue to have one representative on its board. SMBC initially paid about ₹13,480 crore to acquire a 20 percent stake in Yes Bank, followed by another about ₹2,900 crore for a 4.2 percent stake sale from an affiliate of Carlyle Group in Yes Bank. In terms of capitalisation, Yes Bank has a Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1) ratio of 13.9 percent, as of the September-ended quarter.

Prior to the appointment of Prashant Kumar as CEO of Yes Bank in March 2020, the bank had struggled with weakening asset quality, which rose to 16.8 percent as a portion of its total advances

Spotlight on Banks: The Big Deals of 2025

Bank/ NBFC	Buyer	Seller	Deal Size	Type of Deal	Valuation (pre-money)	P/B pre-money	Price per share	Valuation (Post-money)	P/B post-money	Primary Amount	Secondary Amount	Stake
Federal Bank	Blackstone	-	**6,197**	Preferential Issue	**55,769**	1.6x	**227**	**61,966**	1.5x	**6,197**	**-**	10.00%
RBL Bank	Emirates NBD	-	**26,850**	Preferential Issue	**17,165**	1.1x	**280**	**44,018**	1.0x	**26,850**	**-**	60.00%
Sammaan Capital	IHC	-	**8,850**	Preferential Issue	**12,615**	0.6x	**139**	**21,465**	0.7x	**8,850**	**-**	41.20%
Yes Bank	SMBC	SBI and other banks	**13,480**	Secondary	**67,420**	1.4x	**21.5**	**67,420**	1.4x	**-**	**13,480**	20 percent + 4.2 percent
IDFC First	Warburg and ADIA	-	**7,499**	Preferential Issue	**43,933**	1.2x	**60**	**51,432**	1.1x	**7,499**	**-**	

Primary / secondary amount in ₹crore SOURCE Jefferies India



BHIVE disrupts the Coworking Industry with Its New Work Life Harmony Model

Most founders equate culture with perks. BHIVE Workspace takes a different route by redesigning the modern workplace around how people truly want to live and work. Led by Founder & CEO Shesh Rao Paplikar, the company champions a vision that is transformational and aligned with the future of work.

At the heart of his vision is Work Life Harmony, a philosophy that reflects the belief that professionals thrive in a productive work environment that offers them premium office spaces with lifestyle infrastructure.

Shesh elaborates on the philosophy, "Work–life balance has become a defining priority for the new-age workforce. At BHIVE, we believe that for today's ambitious professionals, true balance is best achieved through sports and endurance activities that build both physical and mental resilience. This is why we're investing significantly in world-class fitness infrastructure and nurturing a strong, active community. The response from our members has been phenomenal, reaffirming that wellness and performance go hand in hand."

Work Life Harmony as a Strategy

Shesh's idea behind Work Life Harmony is to offer an ecosystem that blends premium workspaces, thoughtfully crafted sports zones, flexible access models, and curated community experiences.

BHIVE put this approach into practice in 2025, when six employees trained for and completed Ironman Goa 70.3 led by Shesh, who became the first flex workspace founder in the world to reach this milestone. Building on this momentum, BHIVE plans to open the program to its 15,000+ members in 2026 through structured endurance and wellness coaching led by experts.

The Ironman challenge became living proof of BHIVE's belief that the right infrastructure & environment can inspire discipline, performance, and balance simultaneously.

Sridhar Venkatraman (69 yrs), a seasoned Ironman Coach and finisher of 16 Half Ironman and 2 Full Ironman races, with 6 podium finishes, highlights, "During my years in Singapore, the quality of infrastructure made it effortless to train as an endurance athlete. When I visited BHIVE, I felt a similar ease. The pickleball court, the shower zones, and the campus setup add convenience and remove friction from a busy professional's day."

Infrastructure That Drives Productivity

BHIVE makes infrastructure its core promise. The company has 28+ premium centres across Bengaluru and Mumbai including 8 Campuses which together make up over 70% of BHIVE's total workspace footprint.

The Campus model provides a complete ecosystem and features amenities like rooftop pickleball courts, shower zones, football and cricket turfs, lounges, and cafés, apart from premium and flexible workspaces.

In doing so, BHIVE offers a clear edge over traditional offices by providing the infrastructure needed to elevate an individual's lifestyle at work.

Pioneering the Coworking Campus Revolution

BHIVE's expansive coworking network with its Work From Anywhere (WFA) model, gives members the freedom to work from any centre with the same premium, high-performance experience and full suite of work and sports amenities, making work feel like a natural part of life.

Anchoring this ecosystem is the world's largest coworking campus, BHIVE Premium HSR Campus, with sports zones, social events, workshops, community meetups, and leadership sessions, creating a community-driven environment that accelerates learning and connection.

Geetansh Bamania, Founder & CEO of RentoMojo, shares his experience, "At Rentomojo, flexibility is at the core of how we work, and BHIVE mirrors that perfectly. Their Work From Anywhere model lets our teams walk into any centre, get productive instantly, and stay connected through community experiences like the BHIVE Premier League. BHIVE has set a strong benchmark for what future-ready workspaces should feel like."

BHIVE's Next Leap: The Road to an IPO

BHIVE is approaching a key milestone - its IPO. Over the years, BHIVE has expanded strategically, raised capital at the right moments, strengthened leadership, and built scalable systems.

With the flex workspace sector emerging as a strong IPO market, BHIVE's steady growth and long-term vision, BHIVE is well-positioned for the next chapter in its IPO journey.

by FY20, due to indiscriminate lending, including to shadow lenders and real estate developers.

The governance and leadership of Yes Bank's then promoter Rana Kapoor was under scrutiny and the RBI declined to offer Kapoor an extension to his term. He exited his post in early 2019. Yes Bank later restructured its bad loans book by transferring ₹48,000 crore of its stressed assets loan portfolio to an asset reconstruction company (ARC) set up by Yes Bank and JC Flowers.

Yes Bank's gross NPA is down to 1.6 percent of gross advances and net NPAs are at 0.3 percent, as of Q2FY26. It reported an 18.3 percent rise in net profit to ₹654.47 crore, while net interest income rose 4.6 percent year-on-year to ₹2,300 crore and net interest margin rose to 2.5 percent, 10 basis points up year-on-year.

Kannan said they are not in India with a horizon to exit: "We are coming here with the horizon of building, staying as permanent capital."

NBFC Sammaan Capital is witnessing mixed news. In early October, Abu Dhabi's IHC said it would acquire Sammaan Capital for $1 billion, to become the new promoter.

Aman Puri, managing director, Jefferies India, called the deal a "transformational" one, with IHC being larger than any listed Indian company in terms of market cap.

The deal was seen as a lifeline for Sammaan Capital, which faced allegations of financial irregularities, with some cases being filed with the Supreme Court (SC).

A few weeks after the deal was announced, the SC instructed the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to meet the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) and the Enforcement Directorate (ED), to look into charges against Sammaan, which were brought to the notice of the Delhi High Court, through a public interest litigation filed by NGO Citizens Whistle Blower Forum.

Seeking Large, World-Class Public-Sector Banks

Whenever economic growth has turned weak, the government has resorted to pressing the panic button by looking towards credit to fuel economic growth. Minister of Finance Nirmala Sitharaman has done one round in 2018-19, with mega mergers, bringing the public sector banks down to 12 from 27.

She has once again started discussing in the public domain, India's need to have large, world-class banks, particularly in the public sector. But there is scepticism towards a second round of mergers. "It is too early. There is still significant ground to be covered by existing public sector banks [PSBs]. Wanting big banks cannot be the end or a purpose," a banking analyst says, on condition of anonymity.

PSBs have fared well in 2025, with improved asset quality, cleaned up balance sheets and improved profitability. The Nifty PSU Bank index has risen 35.7 percent in the past 12 months to 8,576.4 levels. Experts say that while India does need large, global banks and room for consolidation exists, one needs the intent to make it happen.

Sammaan Capital has argued that the alleged irregularities are "unsubstantiated". All this uncertainty has hit the stock's price, which was down 12.5 percent between November 14 and 20, 2025. It had edged up just 0.86 percent in the entire calendar year to close at ₹154.29 at the BSE, as of November 29.

Sammaan's managing director and CEO Gagan Banga was unavailable to speak to *Forbes India*, despite repeated attempts. But earlier, Banga told CNBC TV18 that post the deal the company will aim to build a credible liability franchise, which would be able to optimise on the cost of funds.

The legal cases will need to be watched closely for the company to emerge clean, banking analysts say.

In the case of another lender, IDFC First Bank, the total capital raise from Warburg Pincus, including a parallel investment from the Abu Dhabi Investment Authority (ADIA), was ₹7,500 crore. Jefferies India, in a report on April 17, 2025, when the deal was announced, said it was "larger than expected and can lift Tier1 capital adequacy ratio to 14 percent (from 13.1 percent in FY25)". The report added that access to capital will "enable growth of around 20 percent".

IDFC First continues to do well on loans (20 percent growth) and deposits (24 percent growth), year-on-year, while the slippages from microfinance have nearly halved quarter-on-quarter in Q2FY26.

CHALLENGES AND TARGETS AHEAD

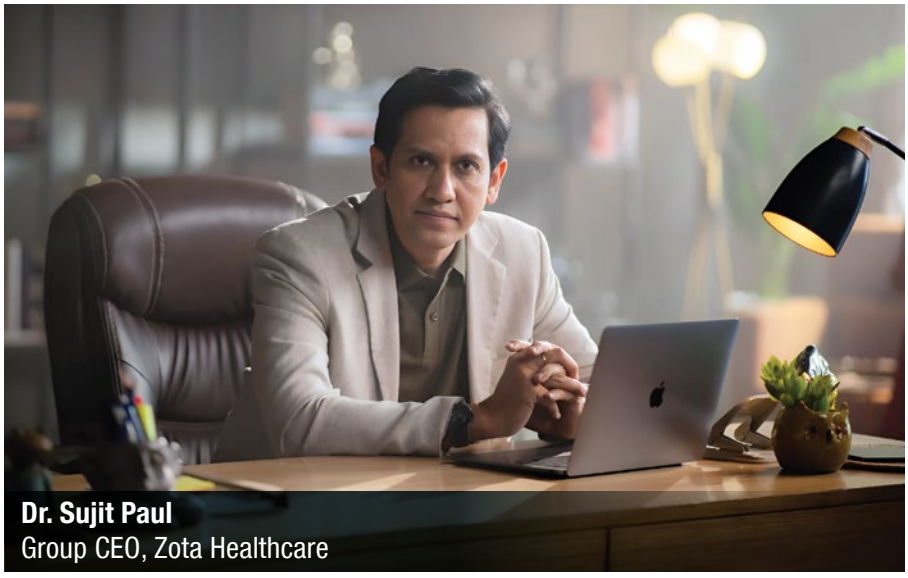
Krishnan ASV, analyst (institutional equities), HDFC Securities, says India still has a long tail of private lenders, which has found it difficult to stay relevant. "A lot of these longtail banks need surgeries and their wounds cannot be fixed by applying a band-aid strip," he says. He declined to name specific banks which could be acquisition targets in the near future.

Though there is no direct information, it is possible that mid-sized banks such as City Union Bank, DCB Bank or Dhanlaxmi Bank could benefit from investors, who might want to pump in capital and leverage on India's economic growth story.

But Puri says: "There will be little interest to turn around something which is sub-scale and which needs a lot of work. The attractiveness of these deals [which took place] is that investors are picking up sizeable positions in listed companies and are getting rights through shareholder votes."

Krishnan had also observed that a change of ownership would not alter the future of a bank. "There is a lot of grind and hard work involved in reforming and improving these franchises. The DNA and mindset has to change," he said.

Innovating for Impact: Zota's Journey Toward Inclusive Healthcare



Dr. Sujit Paul
Group CEO, Zota Healthcare

Dr. Sujit Paul is one of India's most influential healthcare leaders, known for transforming accessibility, affordability, and trust in the healthcare system. His journey from the vibrant yet challenging streets of Kolkata to becoming the Group CEO of Zota Healthcare Ltd. is a story of purpose, innovation, and profound human empathy. Growing up witnessing families struggle for basic medical support, he developed an early conviction that healthcare access should never be a privilege. This belief shaped his life's mission.

From his school days at Don Bosco, he stood out for academic excellence and curiosity, constantly questioning how systems could be improved. His time at Calcutta University expanded his understanding of healthcare beyond medical science, exposing him to the economics, policy gaps, and infrastructural limitations that shaped public health in India. Realizing that solving these issues required more than scientific knowledge, he joined IMT Ghaziabad to study healthcare administration and management. There, he learned to merge strategy with compassion, innovation with practicality, and systems thinking with human-centric leadership.

His professional journey took him through renowned organizations such as Reliance Pharma Retail, Apollo Pharmacy, Asian Paints, Bata, Kodak, Columbia Asia Hospitals, and Trust Pharmacy. He has scaled up Davaindia from regional player to National player. These roles provided him with unmatched expertise in operations, retail expansion, supply chain systems, customer behavior, and healthcare delivery. Everywhere he worked, he made a lasting impact by improving processes, empowering teams, and designing solutions focused on customer needs.

> *Dr. Sujit's commitment to innovation extended beyond internal development. Sustainability became another core pillar of his leadership, leading to the adoption of green manufacturing technologies and environmentally responsible operational practices across the organization.*

When he joined Zota Healthcare, he brought a mission-driven approach rooted in accessibility, affordability, and quality. Under his leadership, Zota grew into one of India's most responsible and innovative pharmaceutical companies. His work included developing advanced drug delivery systems that enhanced treatment efficacy and patient comfort. He also integrated artificial intelligence and machine learning into Zota's supply chain, enabling better forecasting, reducing wastage, and expanding access across rural India. His efforts to diversify the company's portfolio into nutraceuticals, OTC essentials, medical devices, and digital health solutions further strengthened Zota's contributions to national healthcare.

His commitment to innovation extended beyond internal development. Sustainability became another core pillar of his leadership, leading to the adoption of green manufacturing technologies and environmentally responsible operational practices across the organization.

Dr. Paul's leadership excellence has earned him some of the most prestigious global recognitions, including Asia One's 100 Top Global Leaders, CEO Insights' Top 10 CEOs in Healthcare, Times Now's India's Impactful CEO, Elets Technomedia's Innovative Visionary & Leading Healthcare CEO, BARC Asia's Industry No. 1 CEO in Pharma Retail, and Moneycontrol's Top 15 Promising Indian Leaders. He has delivered keynote speeches at leading platforms such as the Economic Times Healthcare Leaders Summit, Retail Technology Conclave, ELETS India CX Summit, multiple TEDx and JOSH Talks. His perspectives have also been featured in in-flight magazines of Indigo, Air India, Vistara, SpiceJet etc.

Beyond professional accolades, he is deeply admired for his human-centric leadership. He mentors young professionals, fosters a culture of innovation, and encourages creative thinking across his organizations. His CSR initiatives—including community health camps, women hygiene awareness programs, community wellness activities, and sustainable manufacturing practices—reflect his unwavering dedication to serving communities and uplifting lives.

SAMIRA™
HABITATS

The Man Who Saw Tomorrow in Alibag – Samir Nerurkar

How one visionary turned a quiet coastline into India's next luxury real-estate frontier

In the 1990s—when most developers were racing to stake claims in Mumbai's booming suburbs—one entrepreneur quietly looked the other way. Across the Arabian Sea, past the city's frenetic skyline, his eyes settled on a sleepy coastal town that few believed had any future in real estate.

That man was **Samir Nerurkar**, **Founder and Managing Director of Samira Habitats (India) Ltd**. The town was Alibag.

Three decades later, Alibag has become India's newest luxury real-estate phenomenon— powered by rapid connectivity upgrades, rising lifestyle aspirations, and the explosive growth of second homes. And standing at the centre of this transformation is the visionary who placed his bet long before the market caught on.

This is the story of how one entrepreneur's conviction reshaped a coastline—and helped build one of India's most attractive lifestyle-led real- estate corridors.

A Vision Before Its Time

Well into the early 2000s, Alibag remained a quiet weekend escape for a handful of Mumbai families. But where most saw a sleepy getaway, Nerurkar saw a world-class coastal destination in waiting.

"Alibag had all the fundamentals of a global coastal lifestyle destination— scale, natural beauty, culture, clean air—yet its long-term value was overlooked. I was clear even then that it would ultimately grow into an extension of South Mumbai."
— Samir Nerurkar

While analysts pointed to logistical challenges and investors hesitated, he took the contrarian path. His early thesis rested on three insights:

1. **Mumbai's urban sprawl** would inevitably push lifestyle seekers outward.
2. **Second homes** would emerge as a powerful alternative asset class.
3. **Coastal towns globally** were evolving into hybrid live-work destinations.



These insights became the foundation on which Samira Habitats built its long-term land-banking and development strategy.

The Rise of Alibag: A Market That Redefined Itself

Alibag's evolution—from fishing villages and virgin beaches to one of India's most aspirational real-estate markets—has been dramatic and data-driven.

For nearly two decades, land prices here have appreciated at a striking 40– 50% annually, reflecting deep and sustained investor confidence.

Nowhere is this more visible than in Zirad. Land that once sold for ₹65 per sq ft today commands close to ₹3,000 per sq ft—a transformation few markets in India can match.

Across the region:

- **Agricultural land** now trades at ₹3–5 crore per acre.
- **Non-agricultural land** in prime pockets has climbed to ₹8–10 crore per acre.
- **Premium plotted developments and villas** have delivered 20– 30% YoY appreciation over the last decade.

Post-Covid demand accelerated this trajectory further, fuelled by families and high-net-worth individuals seeking privacy, space, and nature-driven living.

Infrastructure upgrades strengthened the shift. The Ro-Ro ferry made weekend hops effortless, while the Mumbai Trans Harbour Link (MTHL) now positions Alibag as a natural extension of the Mumbai Metropolitan Region.

"Alibag has reached an inflection point where lifestyle, investment, and long-term appreciation converge," says **Sonali Rajput,** Group CEO & Executive Director, Samira Habitats (I) Ltd. *"We are not just witnessing growth—we are witnessing a structural*

shift in how India perceives and prioritises coastal living."

Affluent South Mumbai residents increasingly view Alibag as a primary-home destination, validating Nerurkar's long-held vision.

"The shift is no longer aspirational—it's behavioural," Rajput adds. "Families want space, wellness, and proximity. Alibag delivers all three at a fraction of Mumbai's cost."

"Alibag's locational edge has now evolved into a powerful investment catalyst. With new waterways from South Mumbai, the MTHL, the upcoming Rewas–Karanja bridge, and the Navi Mumbai airport converging, the region is entering a phase of connectivity-led appreciation that few coastal markets in India—or even globally—can match." — opines ***Brijesh Lohana, Executive Director, Samira Habitats***

Building Before the Boom

Samira Habitats' growth did not rely on speculation—it relied on discipline, relationship capital, and long-term stewardship.

The company's strategy rested on three pillars:

1. **Carefully Curated Land Parcels**
   Acquired during a period of minimal competition, ensuring scale, continuity, and future developability.
2. **Deep Community Partnerships**
   Village communities, landowners, and early investors became long-term collaborators—ensuring inclusive, trust-led development.
3. **Infrastructure Advocacy**
   Few developers pushed harder for better roads, utilities, and coastal access—laying the groundwork for future growth.

Crucially, the company became known for clean titles, due diligence, and transparent development practices—a rarity in complex coastal markets.

"Alibag's complex land situation and regulatory framework demand advanced technical capability. Our competency lies in thorough due diligence, transparent title consolidation using superior law firms to acquire clean lands" — says ***Nadim Shaikh, Executive Director, Samira Habitats***

A New Alibag Takes Shape

Today, Alibag is in the midst of a full-scale lifestyle renaissance—featuring:

- boutique resorts,
- chef-driven restaurants,
- wellness retreats,



Sonali Rajput, Group CEO & Executive Director, Samira Habitats (I) Ltd.

> ***"Alibag has reached an inflection point where lifestyle, investment, and long-term appreciation converge. We are not just witnessing growth—we are witnessing a structural shift in how India perceives and prioritises coastal living.***

- premium villa estates, and
- organised luxury enclaves.

Global hospitality brands and Mumbai-based developers are entering the market—but Samira Habitats retains a first-mover advantage, backed by one of the largest organised land banks in the region.

"We did not set out to follow trends. We set out to shape the region with intention, responsibility, and enduring impact."
— Samir Nerurkar

With hybrid work becoming mainstream, Alibag now appeals as both a holiday destination and a primary residence—offering space, wellness, clean air, and long-term appreciation.



Brijesh Lohana, Executive Director, Samira Habitats

The Next Five Years: A Billion-Rupee Horizon

Industry projections show Alibag's mid-to-premium real-estate segment appreciating 20–25% by 2030, driven by:

- NRI demand,
- institutional capital,
- connectivity upgrades, and
- rising lifestyle-led investment.

Samira Habitats is positioned to lead the next phase with integrated townships, wellness-focused communities, and asset-backed lifestyle investments.

"Land has transformed into a lifestyle-driven asset class—appreciating through both market value and experiential return."
— Brijesh Lohana

Yet, the company remains clear-eyed about the future.

"Alibag must grow without losing its soul," Nerurkar emphasises. Sustainability, community participation, and environmental sensitivity remain our non-negotiable principles.

The Legacy of a Visionary

Thirty years ago, Samir Nerurkar saw in Alibag a future invisible to most. He followed that conviction with discipline and unwavering resolve. Today, the region's ascent underscores a fundamental truth: real-estate success belongs to those with the foresight to envision what others cannot—and the courage to act before anyone else.

As Alibag embraces a new era, a simple truth defines its journey:

As Alibag enters a new era, one truth stands out: its transformation did not begin with infrastructure or capital. It began with imagination—and that imagination was Samir Nerurkar's.



Nadim Shaikh, Executive Director, Samira Habitats

Sweet Makeover

Chitale Bandhu Mithaiwale—now in its 75th year—is eyeing the lucrative snacks market with its focus on automation and exports. Can it compete with the bigger rivals?

By KUNAL PURANDARE



PHOTOGRAPHS BY BAJIRAO PAWAR FOR FORBES INDIA

Kedar Chitale, partner, and Indraneel Chitale (right), managing partner, Chitale Bandhu Mithaiwale, at the company's Ranje Unit in Pune

An assortment of modaks moves seamlessly on an automated machine before they are neatly packed in modified atmosphere packaging boxes. On another floor, on other equipment that needs minimal manual intervention,



a special mix of spicy and tangy masala is layered onto dough that eventually becomes a roll, is deep fried and cut into bite-sized slices. Once ready, the bakarwadi spirals are sealed in packets of various sizes and dispatched to multiple outlets.

It is the run-up to the festive season and the sprawling Chitale Bandhu Mithaiwale factory in Ranje, about an hour from Pune, is abuzz with activity, churning out everything from kaju katli and modaks to gulab jamun and mango barfi.

Spread across 1.5 lakh square feet—with an adjacent building totalling 2 lakh square feet—the manufacturing unit, first set up as an export unit in 2006 and then rebuilt as a mega project from 2017, was a step towards automation that has helped the regional company, known for its sweets and bakarwadi, scale.

Now in its 75th year, Chitale Bandhu, which has been a household name in Maharashtra, mainly Mumbai and Pune, is trying to make its presence felt nationally and expand its range of offerings, especially in the snacks space. Leading this effort are fourth-generation second cousins Indraneel Chitale and Kedar Chitale.

AUTOMATION AND SCALE

Kedar, partner at the enterprise, and Indraneel, who is managing partner, joined the business in 2000 and 2011, respectively, but lessons in entrepreneurship were ingrained in them during their growing up years by their fathers and uncles, who ran the show at the business started by their great-grandfather Bhaskar Chitale in 1939.

"A Chitale customer has always come to us for quality. They have never come to us because we are very cheap or expensive."

INDRANEEL CHITALE
MANAGING PARTNER,
CHITALE BANDHU MITHAIWALE

After losing all his cattle to famine and disease, Bhaskar had migrated from Limbgaon village to Bhilawadi, both in Satara district, Maharashtra, to pursue his passion for dairy and farming. He started by sending fresh milk, curd and *chakka* (strained yogurt) to Pune and Mumbai via a channel partner. The BG Chitale dairy, as it was called, however, had to press the brakes on the business as it was not feasible to send perishable products to far-off locations. Bhaskar asked his son Raghunathrao, who worked in a mill in Surat, Gujarat, to set up base in Mumbai.

His other son, Rajabhau, joined the business later. In 1950, they opened the first Chitale Bandhu store at Kunte Chowk, Pune—later shifted to Baji Road—followed by another at Deccan Gymkhana in 1954. The spirit of innovation and pivoting continued with the company introducing bakarwadi in 1976. The Gujarati-origin snack, which has gone on to become its star attraction, was adapted to Maharashtrian taste after a lot of trial and error. It has become so popular that it is now almost synonymous with the Chitale brand. The company claims to make 2,000 kg of bakarwadi per hour on one machine now compared to 200 kg per day with the help of 40 people in the initial days.

"I focussed on automation. It was happening in some way since 2014, however, it was a chicken-and-egg situation... one needed scale to push it. We addressed the issues that were resulting in restrictions on scale—in terms of volume, shelf-life preservation and hygiene," says Indraneel, 36, who has a BTech in electronics and telecommunications, and has used his engineering expertise and technology application knowledge to build scale at the family-run enterprise.

Automation began with ladoos

and pedhas followed by kaju katli. The company also scaled up bakarwadi production as it began eliminating human involvement in the production process or keeping it to a bare minimum.

Mithai packaging was another area the brothers worked hard on. In India, people usually bought fresh sweets across the counter. "So, when it came to packing and selling those, it took time. We had to standardise a lot of things. We introduced the modified atmosphere packaging concept in India for mithais," he says, as he takes *Forbes India* on a factory visit.

Before the pandemic, adds Kedar, 48, a commerce graduate, buying packaged sweets was an alien thought for consumers. "It was not acceptable. But people's idea of hygiene has changed since then," he says.



"As production capacity improved and we shifted to a franchisee model, we got a lot of time for expansion."

KEDAR CHITALE
PARTNER, CHITALE BANDHU MITHAIWALE

Kedar's early focus was on retail and his initial on-the-job training meant that he knew the intricacies of running a store. "As production capacity improved and we shifted to a franchisee model, we got a lot of time for expansion. As a consequence, we improved our capacity to meet demand and also strengthened our supply chain to take our products outside Pune," he says.

The Ranje unit is Chitale Bandhu Mithaiwale's third renovated factory—the other two are in Pune's Gultekdi and Parvati Industries, both spread across 3,000 to 4,000 square feet plots.

Chitale Bandhu Mithaiwale: A 75-year Legacy





1950
First Chitale Bandhu store opens at Kunte Chowk, Pune, offering milk and milk products like curd and chakka

1953
Sweets like karanji, rawa ladoo, dink ladoo and anarse added to the catalogue



1954
Second outlet at Deccan Gymkhana, Pune

1962
Another store comes up at Bajirao Road, in the heart of the city

1976
Company introduces bakarwadi, a product the brand is synonymous with even today

1979
Chakli, chivda and more namkeens added to the product range

1995
Pedha automation machine deployed to cater to the growing demand



1996
Adopted the first ever automated system in India to bring uniformity to the colour, crispness and taste of the hero product—bakarwadi

2000
Products became available not only across India, but internationally too



2000
Lays foundation for franchising and retail expansion

2014
Leads efforts in automation, R&D and omnichannel presence

2015
Manufacturing unit at Ranje fully automated to standardise and maximise the production capability

2019
Opens first Xpress store outside Pune, in Kolhapur

2020
Enhances online presence and implements safe delivery practices

2022
Introduces M Square and Bingebar, two innovative offerings

2024
Starts first Chitale subsidiary in the US—Chitale Americas



2025
In its 75th year, ropes in cricketing great Sachin Tendulkar as brand ambassador

INFOGRAPHICS BY MUKESH SINGH

MORE THAN MITHAI

The fourth-generation entrepreneurs know they have their hands full as they deal with growing competition, try out innovations and explore newer territories.

From a products point of view, salty and packaged snacks are crucial to the company's growth aspirations. "In India, the salty snacks market is huge—around ₹60,000 crore—and it will go up to ₹135,000 crore in the next 10 years. So, our focus is to get a good double-digit share in that market," says Indraneel. To this end, they have not just scaled the snacks they are known for, including bakarwadi, but also expanded their offerings to include other namkeens and healthy snacks, while keeping their focus on their strengths like Maharashtrian savouries.

"The snacks business is extremely regional and has a lot of players. Chitale focuses on Maharashtrian snacks compared to generic popular products which have a lot of competition," says Samir Kuckreja, founder and CEO, Tasanaya Hospitality, one of India's leading hospitality consultancies.

Though getting into the snacks category puts the Chitales in direct competition with the likes of Bikaji and Haldiram's, their strategy will hold them in good stead, say experts. "It's difficult to compete with a Haldiram's and Bikanervala because of the territories they operate in, their salience and brand recall," says Kuckreja, adding that Chitale also has a relatively limited footprint when it comes to retail stores compared to a Haldiram's or Bikanervala considering it hasn't expanded as aggressively as the two brands.

"Haldiram's and Bikanervala have mastered the art of combining their snacks retail business with a restaurant. They have also penetrated various cities. There is no grocery store or supermarket where you will not see their products," says Kuckreja. But, he adds, "Chitale is a household name in Pune and there is no reason why it can't achieve that kind of stature or reach. It has a healthy topline, is privately held and snacks is a high-margin business."



Modaks: One of Chitale's best-selling items

The cousins' trajectory has steadily focussed on expansion and scale—Chitale has about 125 stores in the country today as opposed to eight retail points in 2015. They are also moving to Xpress outlets—small, packaged food retail outlets designed for urban and high mobility-driven areas—with 35 such outlets outside Pune.

Most Popular

BAKARWADI

The company produces 2,000 kg an hour on one machine. It used to make 200 kg a day in the initial days, with the help of 40 people

KAJU KATLI

Production of 750 to 1,000 kg a day

MANGO BARFI

700 kg of the local favourite are produced daily



There are other ways in which they are increasing visibility for their snacks—Chitale was a snacking partner for the Mumbai Indians team in the Indian Premier League in 2025. It has also started a loyalty programme and will open stores at 10 metro stations of the newly inaugurated Aqua metro line in Mumbai.

While nowhere close to the scale of Haldiram's, which had a $10 billion market valuation as of March 2025 and sold nearly 10 percent of its stake to Singapore sovereign fund Temasek for $1 billion, Indraneel says Bikaji is their closest competitor. Bikaji is also vying for a national play and has Bollywood superstar Amitabh Bachchan as its brand ambassador.

"One of the biggest challenges for the longest time for our industry was that we did not have industry recognition. Mithai-namkeen operators were never looked at with an industry lens because most were single-shop owners. We were never taken seriously," he says. "The valuation of Haldiram's, in fact, is a great validation for the industry."

More players entering the space also augurs well for the industry and everyone stands to benefit as the size of the

pie has increased, the cousins say. Ankur Bisen, senior partner, The Knowledge Company, a management consulting firm, too believes the more the merrier, as it means more innovation and snacks for consumers. He compares the fight for top honours in the segment to what's happening in carbonated drinks where there are established players like Cola and Fanta, but now also Lahori Zeera and Red Bull which are playing the numbers game too.

He adds that the path for Chitale is pretty well laid out. "You can ask why Chitale hasn't become a Haldiram's... and that is a question Chitale has to answer. It has to chalk out its future trajectory. How can it make bakarwadi or chivda a national product like Haldiram's has done to chola bhatura," he says, adding that Chitale as a brand stands out in India's western region but should do more of what it is doing. "It is underplaying its strengths. It is punching beneath its weight. There are people in India who punch above their weight. That is the norm," he says.

FROM REGIONAL TO GLOBAL

Kedar says staying regional was a limitation, not a strategy. "We also wanted to grow," he says, adding that when the company came out of its retail focus, it realised "there were other avenues they hadn't explored". The demand for its offerings was such that they had no choice but to automate. "Once we adopted this technology, we realised the sky is the limit," says Kedar.

The modak market for Chitale Bandhu, for instance, has grown more than 10 times in the past four to five years since the focus on automation, research and development, backward integration and marketing, according to Indraneel. He claims the company got an order for a crore modaks during the Ganpati festival this year, but they had to decline the request as they were not prepared for such huge numbers.

It has chosen to be slow and steady, but those decisions have yielded results. Bisen of The Knowledge Company says Chitale has always been a strong regional brand whose products cater to the sensibilities of a certain demography with a formidable connect around those, but adds that the company has made the right decisions in its journey. "How one scales up business is important, and those decisions have to be taken at the right inflection points. And the Chitales have succeeded in that," he says.

Chitale, he continues, recognised the profile of a changing India. "It was a brand at the right place at the right time, particularly around western Maharashtra where Pune was emerging as an IT hub and India was undergoing a transition," he says. "In food, scaling up the business does not mean you just open shops. It is also about supply chains, product, consistency, quality assurance, hygiene, promise of standardisation, taste. The consumers of a changing India became demanding on this front. And Chitale incorporated these in its offerings," adds Bisen, who leads The Knowledge Company's work in retail, consumer products, food and ecommerce.

While retail still contributes 60 percent to the business, the Chitale siblings were conscious of the fact that they cannot achieve scale with a single avenue. "So, not just stores, but also distribution. Not just distribution, but also exports. Then, post Covid, came ecommerce and quick commerce. Now, it's an omnichannel business where brand play has become more important than the channel of sale. That is the play we are establishing over the past few years," says Indraneel.

In Numbers

125
Chitale outlets in India

60
Countries it has a presence in

60%
Of business comes from retail—the company's profit centre

10
Metro stations on Mumbai's Aqua Line will have a Chitale store

35
Xpress stores outside Pune



The bakarwadi is synonymous with the Chitale brand

Kedar adds: "Quick commerce will keep getting strong. If, for example, its contribution in our turnover was 2 percent earlier, it has now doubled to 4 percent."

Besides hyper local, the focus has also been on expanding internationally. "We also took small efforts to go pan-India or international from 2016," says Indraneel. Chitale is present in 60-odd countries with partnerships with the likes of Shri Krishna Vada Pav and Annapurna. As part of its global outreach, the company is opening kiosks/shop-in-shop experiences for customers, partnering with restaurant chains abroad. As of today, 25 such exist in the US, over 30 in the UK and more than five in Australia and the UAE.

"The focus is on making our products available. Getting real estate abroad is a problem and then there is a price war to justify that. So, we have employed a distribution strategy and that is paying dividends for us," he adds.

Kuckreja, who is working with a couple of partners on potentially taking leading Indian brands to Australia, feels there is tremendous demand for Indian snacks from the subcontinent diaspora and the locals. "Focusing on exports helps in various ways. It opens up new markets and adds another territory where your products are available. But one has to make products that cater to the tastebuds there," he says.



"Chitale is underplaying its strengths. It is punching beneath its weight. There are people in India who punch above their weight."

ANKUR BISEN
SENIOR PARTNER, THE KNOWLEDGE COMPANY

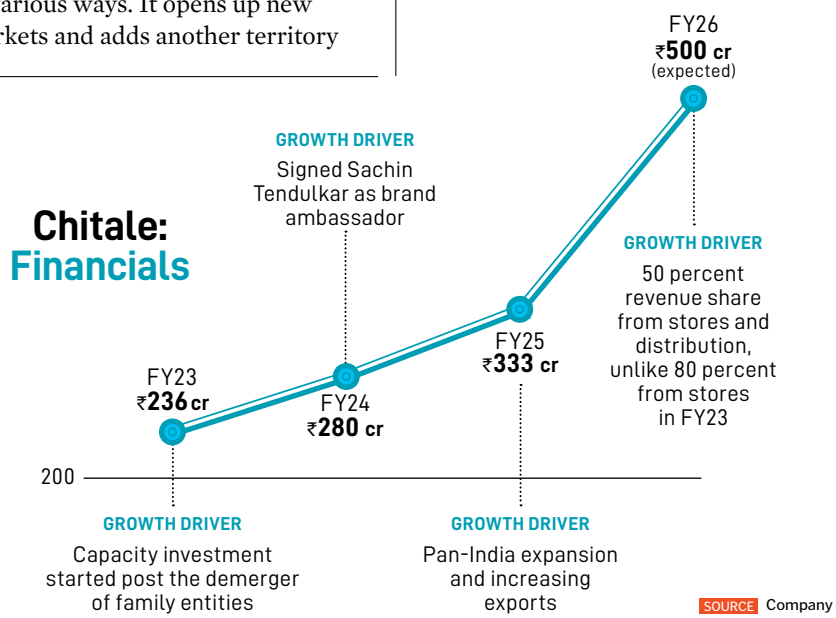
Bisen adds that the right exports strategy can lead to an even bigger play. For example, he says, if bakarwadi is exported to the US, chances are that nine out of 10 times, it will be bought by Maharashtrians living there, not by Punjabis or Bengalis. "You are chasing your customer wherever he is, you are making your product available to him. If that is the definition of expansion, it's fine, there's nothing wrong in that," says Bisen. "But if you want to take the appeal of your product beyond your core customers, you need to make a concentrated effort to make those recipes and products stick to a larger audience."

Keeping an eye on the overseas market, Chitale Bandhu Mithaiwale is currently doing research on frozen technology with Maharashtrian snacks and sweets like modaks, vada and kothimbir vadi, which can be consumed either fried or steamed.

It is also banking on the healthy snacks segment with its brand M Square—which stands for mindful mouthful—with products that don't have added sugar, and are gluten- and lactose-free. They also include baked cookies, millet products and ready-to-cook items. Binge bars is another snacking item the company is focusing on. "The ₹10 snacking bar is important. It's a nice product-market fit," says Indraneel.

Brand play has also become an important part of their strategy. Till about 2015, Chitale Bandhu Mithaiwale relied heavily on word of mouth. Later, it roped in a professional agency and began making short emotional films to focus on branding. "Creating brand films for Chitale was a chance to relive childhood memories. Chitale is more than just a brand; it's a part of Marathi culture. I wanted to tell stories that were organic, entertaining and memorable," says filmmaker Varun Narvekar, who recently also directed a Chitale commercial featuring cricketing legend Sachin Tendulkar.

The company roped in Tendulkar as brand ambassador in its 75th year of operations. "As someone who values tradition and excellence, I am pleased to partner with a brand that has been a cherished part of so many



lives, including mine, for generations," Tendulkar said in a statement.

Kedar adds that in terms of a cultural change, "we changed the Chitale Bandhu Marathi logo to English. Our ads are also in English and Hindi."

Rugwed Deshpande, director, Setu Advertising, who collaborated with the company in its milestone year, is also excited with Chitale's vision to take the 'made in Pune' brand to the world stage. "The clarity, ambition and commitment they bring to this new chapter are truly inspiring," he says.

CHANGE AND CONSTANTS

Though much has changed at Chitale Bandhu, there are some things that remain the same. One of these is Chitale Bandhu's resolve to avoid external involvement in the running of the business or getting funded. It claims to have a compounded annual growth rate (CAGR) of 20 percent for the past few years and ploughs back profits back into the enterprise. "As of now, we are not looking at getting private investors," says Indraneel. "Because our business is high on inventory turnaround, our capital is not stuck for a long time. If you are prudent in terms of deploying capital, then a good CAGR can be acquired by being wise."

Indraneel points out that it makes sense to raise capital if one wants to grow exponentially in the next decade or get into lots of mergers and acquisitions. "That is not the plan now... we are focusing on leveraging the brand's strengths. Once we are able to do that, we can think of other things," adds Indraneel.

The other is keeping people and the customer at the core of everything that Chitale Bandhu does. Arvind More, one of Chitale Bandhu's oldest sales team members who joined the company in 2003, calls it an organisation that deeply respects people. "Even during Covid, when people were losing jobs, the company stood by us. It's more than a workplace, it's a family," he says.



"It's difficult to compete with a Haldiram's and Bikanervala because of the territories they operate in, their salience and brand recall."

SAMIR KUCKREJA
FOUNDER AND CEO, TASANAYA HOSPITALITY

Giving an example of how people's emotions are attached to the brand, Indraneel reveals that when they thought of mechanising the production in 1994-95, they partnered with a company that made spring rolls in Amsterdam. After trials, the Chitales bought the machine to India and made bakarwadi on it. Everything was fine till they hadn't revealed that fact to the customers. Once they publicised how they had made the snack on the machine, customers complained it did not taste like before. They continued their focus on automation and went on to get their own machines.

"A Chitale customer has always come to us for quality. They have never come to us because we are very cheap or very expensive. They are assured of certain things and how to keep delivering that is our focus," says Indraneel.



Modified atmosphere packaging boxes

He adds that though they have changed with time, they have ensured that the family values and cultural DNA are intact. "We are fairly professionalised now. Chasing growth is much more institutionalised than what it was 10 years ago," he says. "Revenue is an important part of our business, but we don't chase it obsessively. We are looking at maintaining healthy ratios and a good balance sheet."

It's what they have grown up doing and plan to continue doing, though it's too early to be speaking about what the next generation will do. From the time he was in school, Kedar says he would sit at the family store, devouring pedhas and barfis from the manufacturing unit that was below their house. "We grew up in that environment, so there is no question of doing anything else," he says.

It helps that it has also been an environment where they have had the freedom and authority to innovate and take decisions. "Freedom has been the best part of running the business. We have a progressive mindset and the ability to experiment. The earlier generations had the vision to take a quantum leap. Not everyone gets freedom... what you do with it is the question," says Indraneel. F

The Quiet Rise of H&H Healthcare: Inside the CDMO Transforming India's Nutraceutical Development and Manufacturing Landscape



Harshul Rai,
Managing Director, H&H Healthcare

The nutraceutical sector in India is under structural change, in consumer demand and scalable, large-volume production facilities. The Indian nutraceutical market, estimated between USD 6.1–30.3 billion in 2024, is expected to grow 11–14% annually. It's shifting from small, fragmented units to consistent, audit-ready, pharma-rigorous manufacturing. H&H Healthcare, founded in 2021 in Indore, has quickly built one of the most infrastructure-intensive nutraceutical plants, focusing on ability, compliance, and scale before marketing.

Building Capacity Before Commerce

The vast majority of nutraceutical companies grow through brand extension; however, in the case of H&H, the situation was the opposite. Since its founding, the company has spent close to ₹500 crore (USD 60+ million) to construct a 15-acre, 2.5 lakh sq. ft. manufacturing campus capable of competing with global audit and compliance standards.

Key facility includes:

- Fully GMP-compliant production lines
- 11 automated high-speed packaging systems
- Granulation, blending, tableting and encapsulation suites
- NABL-accredited laboratories
- In-house formulation and R&D centers
- End-to-end digital traceability and batch monitoring
- Sustainability-led waste and energy systems

Between 2022 and 2024, H&H's R&D team developed and tested 1,000+ formulations, placing it among India's more active CDMO-driven nutraceutical innovators.

The company's philosophy stems from Managing Director Harshul Rai, a next-generation industrial operator whose focus has always been on foundational strength.

"The next decade of nutraceuticals will be shaped by companies that treat compliance as strategy, not obligation."
— Harshul Rai

A Market Entering a New Phase

India's nutraceutical market is benefiting from multiple converging drivers:

- 12–14% projected annual growth
- 25% increase in preventive health adoption post-pandemic
- 17%+ annual rise in functional foods and beverages
- Double-digit growth in gummies, ready-to-drink (RTD) beverages, and clean-label supplements
- Tighter regulation around label accuracy, dosage compliance, and audit documentation

As the sector expands, companies are being evaluated on:

- Scaled production capability
- Consistency across large batches
- Clean-room standards and traceability
- NABL accreditation and global audit alignment
- Ability to deliver emerging dosage formats

H&H's early infrastructure investments place it directly in line with these requirements.

Expanding Into Next-Generation Categories

H&H's 2025–2026 roadmap includes:

- Ready-to-drink (RTD) science-based beverages
- Nutraceutical gummies and confectionary-style formats
- Spray-dried functional blends
- Advanced liquid-fill and blending systems

Phase 1 of its expansion was completed in October 2025, and more lines are planned for July–November 2026. These additions allow the Indore plant to cater to growing markets in the United States, Europe, and Southeast Asia that are seeking options beyond China to diversify their supply chains.

A Milestone Partnership With a Global Player

A defining milestone for H&H came in November 2025, when it became the first and only branded Herbalife manufacturing facility in India. H&H is the sole branded facility allied with Herbalife, one of the world's largest nutrition companies with a turnover of about USD 5.6 billion (₹50,000 crore).

The acquisition reflects a broader shift as global wellness giants look to outsource to Indian manufacturing capacities that can rival global scale and standards.

A Company Positioned for Long-Term Influence

The success of H&H Healthcare has not been based on fast brand development and aggressive advertising, but on engineering discipline, systems thinking and patient capital, prioritizing foundations over fanfare.

Its infrastructure-first strategy reflects a wider trend in Indian manufacturing toward rigorous, export-ready facilities.

As India positions itself as a quality wellness center, H&H shows where size, science and compliance mix.

"Infrastructure comes before visibility. If the foundation is built to global standards, the market always follows."
— Harshul Rai, Managing Director, H&H Healthcare

‘The Innings After The World Cup Final Starts From Zero’

Shafali Verma, Player of the Final in India’s World Cup win, on the sleepless nights before the game, evolving beyond hitting sixes, and batting lessons from Smriti Mandhana

By KATHAKALI CHANDA

The fickle Mumbai weather has done to Shafali Verma what bowlers across the world haven’t—laid her low. When *Forbes India* catches up with the 21-year-old at the tail end of a visit chock-full of engagements, exhaustion and the winter chill have taken their toll. But she insists it’s nothing compared to the grind of the World Cup, which India won, and where she was named Player of the Final for her all-round masterclass. “That was tougher. That win was important for us,” she says.

Reams have been written about how India’s maiden World Cup win will reinvigorate women’s cricket, much like the 1983 victory did for the men. But, for Verma, its significance is far more personal. Not only was she left out of the original 15-member squad, but her last appearance in the ODIs was exactly a year ago—after which she was dropped due to a prolonged slump in form. Even her return to the team was lacklustre: Drafted in as a last-minute replacement for injured batter Pratika Rawal ahead of the semi-final, she scored just 10 in her first outing against Australia. Yet few redemption arcs in recent times have been as dramatic as Verma’s. Opening the batting in the final against South Africa, she scored 87 to propel India to a formidable total, and then stepped up as a strike bowler, picking up two crucial wickets.

Verma’s life has been a whirlwind since then, packed with felicitations, appearances, commercial engagements and media interviews. Her brand value, too, is expected to soar—rising from ₹40 lakh per endorsement before the World Cup to ₹1 crore-plus now, says JSW Sports, which manages her. But Verma wears her fame and success lightly. “*Agli* innings *toh* zero *se hi shuru hogi* (the next innings will start from zero),” she says. In a freewheeling chat with *Forbes India*, she talks about stepping up in clutch moments, how she has toned down her aggressive play, and why her comebacks are stronger than her setbacks. Edited excerpts:

Q You weren’t part of the initial World Cup team. When you were called upon to play, how did you prepare for it?

I remember when the call for my selection came, I was sitting with my childhood friend—both of us were playing domestic cricket for Haryana and we were chilling. I was thrilled to have received the call, because I had been out of the team for one year, but the first thought that came to my mind was how to make the mental switch. The good thing was that I was playing domestic cricket, so I was in touch with the game. But it’s also true that mental switches don’t happen so quickly. When I joined the national team, I got two net sessions before the semi-final—I spent long hours in the nets then. Through practice, I tried



to force myself to make the switch.

Q Did the last-minute call add extra pressure?

I don't know about pressure from others, but I had put immense pressure on myself. I hadn't been selected in the team for a year, and I wanted to show everyone that I could play well. And it's a good pressure, it helps you perform—I had told myself I had two matches, aur *apne dum pe* at least *ek* match *mujhe jitana hai* (I had to win at least one match for the team).

Q But you had a tepid start against Australia, always a difficult opponent...

When I entered the ground during the semi-final, I felt good. I was hitting the ball well. I know I scored only 10, but the way I was batting gave me a lot of confidence. Of course, I was sad when I got out, and I hoped we would make it to the final so I could get another chance. Once I returned to the room, I spent two sleepless nights because I was constantly playing out various scenarios of the final in my head. It was a difficult two days for me after the semis.

Q How did you turn around from this?

Through practice sessions. I had two



Shafali Verma during her knock of 87 in the World Cup final against South Africa

PHOTO BY NIKHIL PATIL/GETTY IMAGES





Shafali: The All-Rounder



2019 Sept
Makes international debut in T20I series against South Africa

2019 Nov
Becomes youngest Indian batter to score a half century

2020
Ranks World No 1 T20 batter

2020 March
Highest scorer for India in T20I World Cup

2021
Youngest player to represent India in all three formats



more practice sessions before the final, and I spent even longer hours in the nets. I made Plan As, Plan Bs, Plan Cs and even more plans if they failed, and executed all of them in the nets. All these plans were crowding my thoughts even when I was supposed to sleep at night. But when I stepped on the field on the day of the final, I told myself that for two days I had run all the scenarios in my head—now it was time to stay calm and act.

Q The innings that you played in the final was a bit uncharacteristic of you. It wasn't your usual aggressive game...
This is an approach I picked up over the last year, when I was out of the team. I have trained myself to play along the ground in the beginning, instead of hitting in the air, because I now know that's a key skill for an opener. I have told myself that it's not a bad thing to take singles in ODIs—you don't have to hit everything out of the park. I have worked on myself during the last year, and the results showed during the World Cup.

Q You bowl regularly in domestic cricket, but not so much in international cricket. The final was only the sixth time you bowled in ODIs.
When I joined the team before the semis, the management told me they had seen me bowl in the domestics and that I may be required to bowl in the World Cup. I told them I was ready. So, during the final, when Harry *di* [captain Harmanpreet Kaur] asked, "Ball *dalegi*? (will you bowl?)" I didn't have second thoughts. Because I had been bowling in domestic cricket and I was confident of my bowling.

Q What was the point during the final when you realised you could win?
When Laura Wolvaardt was dismissed after her century. But, mind you, we didn't give up even then. Nadine de Klerk was batting and we knew she was a match-winner. We didn't loosen the grip till Harry *di* took the last catch. *Jab tak likha na jaaye* board *pe ki* 'India won the game', *tab tak nahi chhodna tha* (we weren't going to ease up till we saw 'India won the game' displayed on the scoreboard).

Q How did it feel when Amanjot [Kaur] fumbled before taking Laura Wolvaardt's catch?
Samjho dil bahar aane wala tha (my heart was about to pop out).

Q Your father inspired you to take up cricket. But how did you learn to play so aggressively?
When I started, my father told me that the Indian team didn't have an aggressive opener and I could fill that slot. But it didn't happen overnight—I practised hard for it. I played with boys, but my shots wouldn't go far then. So I played with wet leather balls that are heavier and harder to hit. Since I learnt how to hit with those balls, when I play with normal leather balls, they go far quite easily.

Q When you were dropped from the team last year, you hid the news from your father because he was hospitalised with a heart attack.

PHOTOS: GETTY IMAGES; AFP



Captains India to victory in U-19 T20 World Cup

2023



2024

Scores the fastest Test double hundred among women

Player of the final in women's ODI World Cup

2025



I am a great believer in karma. I believe that when the going gets tough, *gardan neeche karke chupchap kaam karte jao* (put your head down and keep working quietly). When I finally told my father about being dropped, he was quiet for a few seconds and then said, "*Koi baat nahi, abhi aur bhi mehnat karenge*" (don't worry, we'll work harder). That's what I have done. I come back stronger because I work hard during difficult times.

My father still keeps an eye on my game and every time I get out playing a bad shot, *aaj bhi mujhe daant padti hai* (I still get scolded).

Q You open the batting with Smriti Mandhana, who is now probably the world's best batter. What have you learnt from her?

Such a lot, but I'd like to mention two key things. When you are off colour, when you aren't able to connect bat to ball well enough, take a single, go to the other end and wait your time. Sometimes you get back in the flow when you watch the other batter play fluently. And second, how to stay calm while batting, especially when I mishit. By now, we have played together long enough and understand each other very well, so we don't need to talk much. But when she says something, I accept it without a word, because sometimes things are clearer from the non-striker's end.

Q The next season of the Women's Premier League (WPL) is coming up in January, where for the first three seasons, you've opened with Australian legend Meg Lanning.

Meg has taught me what it takes to build an innings, instead of just focusing on power-hitting. Earlier, I would think you learnt to bat only through practice. But from her, I've learnt batting is a mental game. There will be many innings where you are out for zero, but when you go out to bat the next time, you can't let that faze you. The tougher you are mentally, the better you bat.

Talking about the WPL, the tournament has given young players enormous belief to perform on the big stage and the strength to handle pressure. Think about players like Shree Charani, who came through the WPL and played brilliantly in her first World Cup, navigating key matches and large crowds.

Q You are just 21, and you've already played international cricket for seven years. How have you evolved?

Earlier, I wouldn't pay much attention to what I ate, how I trained, or to fielding. But now I know the benefits of a protein-based diet, and I focus on fitness training and especially fielding, which is such an important aspect of the modern game. That apart, I have realised power-hitting isn't the only way to bat. So during nets, especially during the off-season, I set aside an hour or so just to hit along the ground. I know power-hitting is my strength, but one needs to set aside their ego and work on their weaknesses.

Q Few 21-year-olds are as successful as you. How do you stay grounded?

I never forget that whatever I am is because of cricket. And every time I play well, the next innings starts from zero. I also remind myself that fame and success aren't my aim; my aim is to lead the Indian team some day, to make many records, to win many more World Cups. What I've achieved so far is just the starting point.

Q What are the goals you have set your sights on next?

As an individual, to own more records. And as a team, to win more World Cups. The T20 World Cup is about six months away, and it's a format I enjoy playing. I'm very excited for that. All the players have shifted gears mentally and have started preparing. F

Game Changers

As India rejoices its maiden women's cricket World Cup win, we revisit people who fought battles and biases over the years to give the sport financial muscle and its moment in the sun

By KUNAL PURANDARE



PHOTO BY PUNIT PARANJPE / AFP

After attending an event at the Cricket Club of India (CCI) in Mumbai, Mandira Bedi walked into the dressing room of the Indian women's cricket team at the venue and introduced herself in what she describes as a 'cold call'. It was 2003 and the actor had become a popular face among the cricketing fraternity and fans after a successful run as anchor-broadcaster at the men's World Cup in South Africa the same year.



India beat South Africa in the final in November to win its first women's World Cup

India was playing New Zealand in a bilateral series and Bedi inquired about the games to the first person she met—former India cricketer Shubhangi Kulkarni, who was secretary of the Women's Cricket Association of India (WCAI)—inside the players' enclosure. "We have such a wonderful team. What can I do for women's cricket? How can I help?" she asked during the course of watching the match. Fully aware of the minutest of challenges involving women's cricket, Kulkarni retorted: "Oh, my gosh! How much time do you have and where can you start?"

Their conversation touched upon issues such as lack of funds, minimal visibility for the players and the absence of spectators. The most pressing concern, though, was that the West Indies team was scheduled to tour India immediately after and there was no money to host them. "Imagine the shame... there's a series supposed to take place, but there's no guarantee if it will happen due to financial reasons," Bedi tells *Forbes India*.

It was a time when brands were chasing her because of her newfound acceptance—beyond her onscreen characters—within the cricketing community. One of them, ASMI, a diamond jewellery

The win resulted from the efforts of former players, Good Samaritans, corporates and administrators who had faith in the team when people didn't know women's cricket existed



Mandira Bedi

Actor, anchor-broadcaster

- ASMI, a diamond jewellery brand, wanted to sign her as brand ambassador. **She asked the company to give the entire sum of ₹15 lakh to the Women's Cricket Association of India so that it could host the India-West Indies series in 2003-04**
- **Got another sponsorship deal which helped the Indian team travel** for an overseas tour in 2005
- She would slip in women's cricket to every brand and company she was working with.
- Also **spoke about the game at corporate events that she hosted and tried to raise whatever money she could for the game**

PHOTO BY SWAPNIL SAKHARE FOR FORBES INDIA

The euphoria surrounding India's victory in the women's World Cup this year is justified, as a dream of nearly 50 years—the Indian women's team first played a one-day international in 1978—finally came true

brand, wanted to sign Bedi as its brand ambassador. "I told them I am keen to do this, but whatever money they plan to pay me should entirely go to the women's cricket association because I wanted the tournament to happen," she recalls.

Thanks to Bedi's contribution of ₹15 lakh, the five-match, one-day international series was played as the ASMI Cup. Since then, the celebrity began batting for women's cricket in whatever way she could. "I would slip in women's cricket with whichever brand I was associated with, whichever company I could work with. I tried my best [to get sponsors on board], but people were not forthcoming that time," she laments. "Today, there will be 100 sponsors. It's easy when you have a World Cup win behind you and have stars in the making. In those days, nobody cared."

FINALLY, A WORLD CUP

This November, India won its first World Cup by beating South Africa in the final, making it a watershed moment for women's cricket. The final, which streamed on JioHotstar, saw a record 185 million tuning in, matching the figure for the 2024 International Cricket Council's (ICC) men's T20 World Cup final. The euphoria that ensued was justified, as a dream of nearly 50 years—the Indian women's team first played a one-day international in 1978—finally came true.

The result is an effort of several people who worked tirelessly behind the scenes. An army of former cricketers, administrators, corporates and Good Samaritans showed faith in the players at a time when women's cricket wasn't taken seriously, or people did not know it existed. They not only contributed money but also fought battles and biases in what remains a male-dominated sport.

Prior to Bedi's benevolence, Arvind Prabhoo—now president of the All India Pickleball Association—had



PHOTO BY SWAPNIL SAKHARE FOR FORBES INDIA

Arvind Prabhoo

President, All India Pickleball Association

- **The Women's Cricket Association of India approached him in 2001, asking if he could help raise ₹6 lakh so that the India-New Zealand series could take place. He paid it out of his own pockets**
- **Contributed ₹12 lakh to send the Indian team to South Africa 10 days before the 2005 World Cup** so that they could acclimitise to the conditions there. Paid another ₹10 lakh for their air travel—the money was returned by the association later
- The 'patron' of women's cricket also **arranged for the team's stay in South Africa by renting a house and hired a caterer to provide them with Indian food**

stepped in to ensure that a three-match one-day international series between India and New Zealand took place in 2000-01. Former India pacer and the then-WCAI secretary Surekha Bhandare approached Prabhoo's father, Ramesh Prabhoo—a member of the legislative assembly from Shiv Sena and former mayor of Mumbai—asking if he could arrange sponsors for the matches. He directed her to his son, an ardent cricket fanatic.

In 1999, Prabhoo had organised three one-day matches in New York, San Francisco and Canada between an Asian XI and a World XI to "promote men's cricket and as a commercial venture". A couple of years later, shortly after returning from the US, an opportunity to contribute to the women's game came walking.

"They wanted to raise ₹6 lakh for the three matches and the players' accommodation. I paid it out of my pockets," Prabhoo tells *Forbes India*. On seeing the team play, he was impressed. "I saw Jhulan Goswami comfortably bowling at 120 to 130 kmph, and Mithali Raj hitting boundaries with ease. I felt they were as good as the men's team—not physically, but in terms of their technique and skills."

From that day, Prabhoo began pitching in. He became a patron for women's cricket and would travel with the team—from Aurangabad and Guwahati to Sri Lanka, Australia and New Zealand. In 2005, he was instrumental in sending the Indian team to South Africa 10 days before the World Cup so that they could acclimatise to overseas conditions.



Shubhangi Kulkarni

Former India captain, secretary, Women's Cricket Association of India

- The association was in the red when she took over as secretary. **She repeatedly sought sponsorship deals to host tournaments and clear the debts**
- Spoke with people like Mandira Bedi for assistance, and **sought help from friends in media and marketing to bail them out financially**
- **Fought continuously to get the association under the BCCI fold.** The BCCI refused initially, and relented only in 2006

He shelled out ₹12 lakh for their stay, rented a house for them and hired a caterer to provide Indian food. In addition, he provided ₹10 lakh for their air tickets, an amount that the association later returned.

"It was always a fight to get sponsors for women's cricket," says Prabhoo. "Mandira brought a lot of backers, including a three-year apparel deal for ₹1 crore."

BUILDING FOUNDATIONS

From an administrative point of view, Kulkarni—an Arjuna Award recipient—was at the forefront of bringing about a desperately needed revival. The association was not in a healthy state and was in dire need of money. "We were in the red when I took over as secretary in 2003. It meant finding sponsors not just for tournaments but also to clear off some earlier debts," she explains.

For the first couple of series after she took charge, she sought help from friends in the media and marketing. In fact, throughout the WCAI days, they relied heavily on families and acquaintances to bail them out financially. "We would have sponsors here and there, but never a continuous flow. Mandira helped us a lot. Except for men's sport, every other sport was struggling to get sponsors," says Kulkarni, who represented India from 1976 to 1991.

Her chat with Bedi at CCI and the subsequent involvement of a few brands provided partial relief. But there were other monumental challenges to overcome. Bringing women's cricket under the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) was one of them.

The International Women's Cricket Council and the ICC were in the process of merging when Kulkarni became WCAI secretary. They mandated that women's cricket must come under one board. "The BCCI refused... I don't know why. Right from the beginning, it wasn't keen on such an arrangement till Sharad Pawar became president," she lets on. Eventually, women's cricket came under the BCCI in 2006.

On the field, the big prize was the 2005 World Cup and Kulkarni, along with Prabhoo, was determined to ensure the team was ready to take on formidable opponents. Although the Indian players were competitive, they lagged in terms of fielding and fitness.

Working on these aspects required infrastructure: Grounds where players could dive without getting

Women's cricket has turned over a new leaf since it came under the BCCI almost two decades ago. Finance issues are a thing of the past. The BCCI's clout on the international stage means there is both money and muscle power

hurt, and facilities like a proper gymnasium. "It wasn't possible for us to give them those," Kulkarni rues.

Infosys had such amenities in Mysuru. The women's team had played matches there previously, and the WCAI sought permission from the IT services company to use the facilities. After getting the nod, the Indian team trained there for two years. "It was a world-class training centre with a gym, swimming pool and a cricket ground. We also had a dietician who provided the girls with the nutritious food they required," says Kulkarni. "N Narayana Murthy [Infosys founder] and Mohandas Pai [former board member at the IT company] were extremely supportive. Infosys did not charge us anything. Their human resources team helped the girls with personality development and team building too, so all the soft skills were honed there."

India lost the 2005 World Cup final to Australia by 98 runs. However, Pai had announced prizes for players—such as for someone who takes five wickets or scores a century. Some of them received these amounts personally from him after the tournament.

Sudha Shah, who took over as coach of the Indian team in 2003, says it was a blessing that the team could go to South Africa 10 days before the event. She had insisted on a month-long fielding and fitness camp, with an eye on the coveted trophy. "Those sorts of things were unheard of in those days because there was lack of finance. The WCAI did not have funds and we had to depend on sponsors from series to series," she says. "Women's cricket did not get publicity."



Sudha Shah

Former India player and coach

- **Along with the association, reached out to Infosys to avail the IT services company's facilities in Mysuru.** She insisted on having a month-long camp for fitness and fielding with an eye on the 2005 World Cup
- **The Indian team used the ground, gymnasium and swimming pool for two years prior to the World Cup,** and also had access to a dietician and etiquette sessions
- As player, stayed in dormitories during tours, travelled unreserved on trains and stood in queues to book train tickets

SUPPORT THAT SPARKED CHANGE

It was also in 2005 that Bedi arranged air travel tickets for the Indian team for an overseas tour via a sponsorship deal with a travel company. She had started hosting corporate events a couple of years earlier, and used her platform to raise whatever amount she could for women's cricket. "Wherever I could get a corporate to come on board, even with ₹5 lakh, I would... it meant something because it was zero versus ₹5 lakh. We would take whatever we would get," she says.

Bedi, though, does not want credit for championing the cause of women's cricket. "I just felt it was the right thing to do. I wanted to give back something to the sport," she says, adding that people like Kulkarni and Prabhoo are the "true warriors".

Shah and Kulkarni are glad that today, women cricketers who play for India travel business class (the domestic teams also travel by air), stay in five-star hotels, have contracts, get match fees and access to some of the best training facilities. In their time, there was none of this. They played purely out of passion and love for the game.

"We travelled unreserved everywhere—from Varanasi to Chennai—and sometimes in luggage compartments. If we lost a match, we had to travel back the same day, so invariably there were no reservations. We didn't have the best of accommodation—we have stayed in classrooms and dormitories, and slept on bunk beds. But even when we sat next to the toilets or the doors on the trains, we had a lot of fun," says Shah, who played for India from 1976 to 1991, including the country's inaugural Test match.

Kulkarni agrees. "We didn't get allowances at that time. We stayed in dormitories with common toilets and bathrooms. We carried our own food from home that would last us for a few days," she reminisces.

There was no future in the game, and most players had to fight with their families to let them take up the sport. "A lot of parents did not allow their girls to play cricket. We would have to meet them and coax them into sending the girls for tournaments," says Kulkarni. "Many had to give up the game because they had to start working," explains Shah.

In the absence of match fees, women cricketers in the earlier era had to pay from their own pockets to play for their state or country. For one of the international tours, the players approached the Maharashtra chief minister for funds

SPECTRUM OF TALENT: SIX TRAILBLAZERS REDEFINING THEIR FIELDS

Santhosh Kumar Gopal,



Santhosh Kumar Gopal is redefining the future of digital performance engineering across healthcare, finance, and cloud-native enterprises. With more than two decades of expertise, he has led high-impact initiatives that optimize the speed, reliability, and scalability of mission-critical systems used by millions. His work integrates advanced performance architecture, AI-driven optimization, and cloud engineering to enhance customer experience and accelerate business innovation. Gopal has contributed to major technology transformations at CVS Health, JP Mogan Chase, and ESIC, and continues to influence industry standards through thought leadership, technical excellence, and groundbreaking approaches to system performance.



Dhruv Shah: Expert in Net-Zero Energy Systems, Building Automation & Energy Efficiency

Dhruv Shah, a seasoned professional in energy management and sustainability, is recognized for his expertise in net-zero buildings, HVAC optimization, smart lighting control systems, and AI-driven commissioning for Building Automation Systems (BAS). With extensive experience across commercial, industrial, and institutional projects, Dhruv has successfully delivered advanced energy-efficiency solutions that reduce operational costs and carbon footprints. As a peer reviewer for leading journals including IEEE, Elsevier, World Scientific, and Springer Nature, Dhruv contributes to strengthening the global research community. His work spans grid-interactive efficient buildings, battery storage integration.

Abhinav Kasliwal: Technical Product Leader Advancing AI and Enterprise Systems



Abhinav, an accomplished Product and Technology leader with over 16 years of professional experience, is widely recognized for his expertise in technical product management across AI-driven enterprise platforms, high-reliability B2B procurement systems, and large-scale API ecosystems. His impact spans technology, finance, and retail, where he has led full-cycle initiatives involving third-party integrations, onsite experiences, multi-service orchestration, and complex data workflows. Renowned for his leadership in generative AI productization, product strategy and vision, and cross-functional technical execution, Abhinav has delivered innovations generating multi-billion-dollar value.



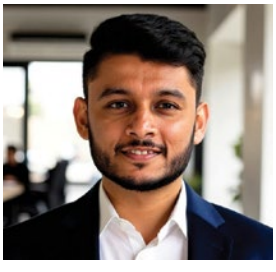
Anokh Kishor,

Anokh is a distinguished technologist shaping ultra-low-latency platforms, systems-level architectures, and performance-critical distributed computing. His work spans real-time data pipelines, scalable orchestration frameworks, and infrastructure engineered for deterministic behavior under extreme load. With a track record of accelerating execution speed and enhancing reliability, he brings deep expertise in concurrency, resilience engineering, and algorithmic optimization—turning telemetry into strategic insight. Operating at the intersection of performance engineering and distributed systems, Anokh consistently delivers high-throughput, fault-tolerant platforms that power mission-critical workflows.

Dr. Ravi Chandra Gutta, MD



Dr. Ravi Chandra Gutta, is an internationally recognised distinguished Allergist and Immunologist who completed his MD, Internal Medicine Residency, and Allergy & Immunology Fellowship at the prestigious Cleveland Clinic. At the University of California, Irvine, he served as the youngest Allergy & Immunology Fellowship Program Director in the United States, was Director of Research and Clinical trials and Co Director of Jeffery Model Immunodeficiency center, served as President of the Orange County Allergy & Immunology Society. Dr. Ravi now in Dubai leads the Department of Allergy & Immunology at Clemenceau Medical Center and is Adjunct Clinical Associate Professor at Mohammed Bin Rashid University.



Shahebaz Pathan:

Driving Efficiency in the Fuel Industry: Modernized Wholesale & Retail Operations

Shahebaz Pathan, a Project Manager and technology innovator with more than eight years of experience transforming operations across the wholesale and retail fuel industry. He is best known for developing and deploying a patented, cloud-connected CRM/ERP system that became the operational backbone of Engineer's Associates Inc. dba National Petroleum, streamlining dispatch, accounting, sales commissions, tax reporting, AP/AR workflows, and multi-team collaboration. His work with this platform delivered more than $350K in annual savings and significantly improved efficiency across the company's fuel operations.

During her playing days, continues Kulkarni, of the 15 players in the squad, at least 10 were working with the Indian Railways and three others in Canara Bank, which was trying to set up its own team. Later, it was Air India and Railways. "Today, they are able to sustain themselves and make a bit out of the game itself. Earlier, they had to do a job as well. That doesn't happen now. You can see the mindset changing," she adds.

In the absence of match fees, women cricketers in the earlier era had to pay from their own pockets to play for their state or country. For one of the international tours, the players approached the Maharashtra chief minister and requested funds so that part of the expenses could be covered. "From arranging the nets to booking train tickets or playing without a coach or manager, we have done it all," says Kulkarni, a former India captain.

While playing domestic cricket, Shah would often visit the railway office to get a concession and then stand in queues to buy train tickets.

A NEW ERA, AND MORE WORK

Women's cricket has, of course, turned over a new leaf since it came under the BCCI almost two decades ago. Finance issues are a thing of the past. The BCCI's clout on the international stage means there is both money and muscle power. Visibility has also improved: The ICC has stepped up marketing efforts, and tournaments like the Women's Premier League (WPL), launched in 2023, have attracted greater brand participation. Social media has amplified player profiles further.

"Earlier women cricketers were not even earning in hundreds. By the time I left, they were getting in tens of thousands. Now they are dealing in crores. It has become an aspirational sport now," says Prabhoo.

The glitz and glamour are important, but Bedi sounds a word of caution despite the hype around the WPL. The opening ceremony saw a huge turnout with actors like Kiara Advani and Kriti Sanon performing along with Canadian rapper AP Dhillon. "But as the tournament progressed, there wasn't much crowd. A lot of spectators came for the final again because there was no entry fee," she points out.

Bedi, who was also at the 2020 T20 World Cup final in Brisbane, recalls the stadium being packed to capacity because American singer Katy Perry performed before and after the match. "There is always a lure of some big name, some attraction... that's what gets people to the stadium. The tournament itself was not really written about," she says. India lost that final to the hosts.

The turning point is the 2025 World Cup win, which is certain to open the floodgates for more benefits and bonanza for women's cricket. "Something that we started 50-odd years back has finally borne fruit. Frankly, at that time, I didn't expect it to get to such heights. I am over the moon. From this point, it's just going to move forward," says Shah.

The men's game has become too predictable, feels Prabhoo, with almost every ball in the Indian Premier League, for instance, going for a boundary or six. Women's cricket, in contrast, still has some excitement and reinvention. "The World Cup win will see a lot of women participation in sport. It's a landmark win. It will give them the self-belief that one must possess to compete at the highest level and win. There's a big difference between being a runner-up and being a winner," says the president of the Prabodhankar Thackeray Krida Sankul. The sports complex in Vile Parle, Mumbai, is already seeing a rise in girls enrolling for cricket practice.

Kulkarni, who owns a cricket goods shop in Pune, is also witnessing a surge in girls taking interest in the game and parents encouraging them to consider cricket as a career. She highlights that all officials during the 2025 World Cup were women—a powerful signal that the ecosystem now supports opportunities beyond playing on the ground.

"There was a time when we used to say that if women's cricket has to grow, India has to win the World Cup. This is just the beginning," she says.

Yet much still needs to be done, especially at the grassroots. Fitness culture, for instance, must be strengthened at the state level, according to the stakeholders. Kulkarni believes match fees must also go up in domestic cricket. "This will help the girls invest in their game," she says.

Much still needs to be done, especially at the grassroots. Fitness culture, for instance, must be strengthened at the state level. Match fees must also go up in domestic cricket as it will help the girls invest in their game

Shah reiterates that expectations will be higher after the World Cup victory, and the women cricketers will have to match them. "Getting to the top is good, but staying there is even tougher. The girls will have to work much harder."

For now, though, it is time to celebrate and look forward to sunny days. "Things happen when you are at the top... you will see the entire landscape of women's cricket changing. It's going to be an upward string from here," says Kulkarni. F

India's New Age of Trailblazers, Thinkers & Industry Architects

Anjaneyulu Pillalamarri, Co-founder and CEO of Giosun Healthcare Pvt. Ltd.



Anjaneyulu Pillalamarri, popularly known as Anjan, is the Co-founder and CEO of Giosun Healthcare Pvt. Ltd., a fast-growing leader in Ayurveda, Nutraceuticals, and Herbal Cosmetics. An MBA in Finance and Marketing, he began his career in corporate banking before shifting his focus to wellness entrepreneurship, driven by a vision to blend traditional Indian healing with modern innovation. Under his dynamic leadership, Giosun has evolved into a debt-free, globally trusted brand and is now setting up a state-of-the-art WHO-GMP certified facility. Recognised with an Honorary Doctorate from Chicago University, Anjan is also a mentor to emerging startups, advocating ethical leadership, sustainable growth, and value-driven impact in India's wellness and healthcare ecosystem.

Dr. Prashant Singh, MD and critical-care physician



Dr. Prashant Singh, an MD and critical-care physician, has dedicated his career to bringing metro-grade healthcare to Eastern Uttar Pradesh through sustainable, region-focused hospital development. Since 2008, he has transformed a small clinic into a 300-bed tertiary-care institution offering services like cardiac surgery, neurosurgery, IVF, angioplasty, and advanced diagnostics — all at affordable regional prices. His award-winning, self-financed model prioritizes clinical quality, access, and financial discipline, proving that high-end care in Tier-2 cities is both possible and scalable. Dr. Singh's vision is to replicate this protocol-driven, locally controlled approach across underserved Indian cities while strengthening preventive and diagnostic care. His advice: focus on outcomes, avoid overleveraging, and build the services your community travels elsewhere to receive.

Mr. Alpesh Jain, Founder of "Alpesh Jain – Your One-Stop Solution for All Mutual Fund Needs"



Mr. Alpesh Jain, Founder of One Stop Solution for All Your Mutual Fund Needs, is driven by a deep passion for financial markets that began with tracking mutual fund NAVs at a young age. Coming from a Marwadi background known for strong money management values, he built his practice on discipline, ethics, and long-term investing. He caters exclusively to corporates and family accounts, offering focused, personalised portfolio management services, and currently manages an impressive ₹310 crore AUM. Alpesh believes mutual funds work best for a 3-5 year horizon and guides clients through market ups and downs. His approach prioritises honesty, zero mis-selling, client safety - especially for senior citizens - and his core principle remains: If the client grows, we grow.

Rajiv Lamba, Founder & CEO, Neurosensum & SurveySensum



Rajiv Lamba is the Founder and CEO of SurveySensum, an AI-powered customer feedback platform that helps enterprises transform customer experience and market research. With over 20 years of experience in consumer insights at Nielsen, Mindshare, and Kadence, Rajiv combines technology, data, and empathy to drive innovation. Under his leadership, SurveySensum enables 300+ enterprises across 20+ countries to capture, analyze, and act on real-time customer insights - boosting retention and growth across industries like Automotive, BFSI, Telecom, FMCG, and Retail. Recognized among The Silicon Review's Top 30 Entrepreneurs and awarded IT Entrepreneur of the Year in Indonesia, Rajiv continues to pioneer how AI turns feedback into foresight, empowering organizations to build stronger connections and deliver meaningful, measurable customer experiences. His vision is to make every business truly customer-centric through the power of actionable intelligence.



‘I Didn’t do it for Attention. I Wanted to Give Back to Cricket’

Actor and anchor-broadcaster Mandira Bedi on championing women’s cricket and why she used the money from her brand endorsements to promote the sport

By **KUNAL PURANDARE**

PHOTO BY SWAPNIL SAKHARE FOR FORBES INDIA

More than two decades before India's historic win at the 2025 Women's ODI World Cup, actor Mandira Bedi quietly batted for the sport. Making optimum use of her newfound popularity as an anchor-broadcaster after the 2003 Men's World Cup, she persuaded corporates and brands to sponsor tournaments and encourage women's cricket. At times, she even diverted her earnings to promote the game.

In a candid chat with Forbes India, Bedi speaks about why she felt it was the right thing to do, her decision not to speak about her contribution to the game all these years, and how she battled tags like 'eye candy' and sexist behaviour while she was a presenter during cricket tournaments. Edited excerpts:

Q At a time when there wasn't much awareness about women's cricket, you stepped in and contributed in your own way. How did it begin?

The 2003 World Cup was a turning point in my career. Cricket is still a male-dominated sport and there was no room for women in broadcasting in those days. But I got acceptance by the end of the tournament. When I came back to India after the World Cup, everybody knew me by my name. Until then, I was the characters that I played on screen. Cricket gave me so much... it made me an anchor, a master of ceremonies, and it made me host events. I wanted to give something back; I wanted to do something for the game.

More than two decades ago, I had gone to the Cricket Club of India [in South Mumbai] for an event. The Indian women's cricket team was playing a match. And I just went into the pavilion—like you go in for a cold call—and said, 'Hi, I am Mandira... what tournament is this?' And the first person I met—Shubhangi Kulkarni, former India player and the secretary of the Women's Cricket Association of India—explained that India was playing against New Zealand. I continued, 'How can I help and what can I do for women's cricket?' Shubhangi shot back: 'Oh my gosh, how much time do you have and where can you start?' That's how it began.

Q What were some of the issues ailing women's cricket?

There were no funds, no visibility and no attention from spectators; there was nothing coming towards women's cricket. The men's sport was set—it is cash-rich, visible, seen, loved—and people have been crazily passionate about it for years. I knew the women's game existed and I knew the team. But where could one read about it or know about it? There was nothing anywhere. In fact, even if there was a World Cup or a big tournament, there wouldn't even be a two-by-two-inch space in a newspaper.

During our chat, Shubhangi told me the West Indies were scheduled to tour India and the association didn't even know if it had the money to host the team. Imagine the shame! There's an upcoming series, but we don't know whether the tournament will happen because we don't have the money.

Q What did you do? How did you help?

"I remember going for one of the matches to Eden Gardens in Kolkata and fewer than 100 people turned up. That too because they opened some of the stands for free for schoolchildren."

It was after the 2003 World Cup and a lot of brands were approaching me. A lot of work was coming my way. ASMI, a diamond jewellery brand, wanted to sign me as their brand ambassador. I told them: 'I'm keen to do this, but I want all my funds to go to the Women's Cricket Association because I want the series against the West Indies to take place'. It eventually did, and it was called the ASMI Cup.

Q What was the amount?

It was ₹15 lakh.

Q Did you watch the series? How was the experience?

Yeah, and how much attention did it get? Nothing. I remember going for one of the matches to Eden Gardens in Kolkata, and fewer than 100 people turned up. That too because I think they opened some stands for free for schoolchildren. It was sad. There was so much ignorance about women's cricket. Even if I told my friends that I was travelling with the team to Sri Lanka, they would ask, 'Oh, there's a women's cricket team? Can we play?' People had no clue, no idea.

Q How did you go about promoting the game?

I would slip in women's cricket with whichever brand I was associated with, whichever company I could work with. However, people were not forthcoming at that time. Now if you say women's cricket, there will be 100 sponsors. It is easier when you have a World Cup win behind you, and you have got stars in the making. At that time, nobody cared.

Q You also helped sponsor air tickets for the Indian team for an international tour in 2005.

Yes, that was through another sponsorship deal. When attention came my way recently that I did this for the game, I didn't know what to say. At that point, I just felt it was the right thing to do. Of course, there

were people who have done so much more—Shubhangi and Arvind Prabhoo [he contributed huge sums from his own pocket], for instance. They are the true warriors. I was an outsider in that sense. But whatever I could do, I did. From 2003, I began hosting corporate events. So wherever I could get a corporate to come on board, even with `5 lakh, it would mean something, because it was zero versus `5 lakh. We took whatever we got.

PHOTO BY SEBASTIAN D'SOUZA / AFP



Mandira Bedi with then-India captain Mithali Raj (left) in 2005

Q After the 2025 World Cup win, people have suddenly discovered what you did two decades ago. Why didn't you speak up then?

I find it very embarrassing, that's why. If you see my social media, I haven't posted or reposted even one message about this. I just feel I didn't do it for attention. I didn't do it to be seen as doing the right thing. It was the right thing to do at that time. Even now, when people ask me about my charity work, I tell them I don't speak about it because I don't call it charity. I do it wherever I feel that my voice can help in any way.

Q Isn't it ironic, because when you became anchor-broadcaster for cricket matches, you were dismissed as 'eye candy'? You also had to deal with sexism.

Of course, people are going to say these things when they're seeing something they've never seen before—in terms of a woman being on a panel. One newspaper wrote about what I wore during the tournament... and then it moved from my clothes to what I said. When you are the first to do something, you will always have it the hardest because you are under the greatest amount of scrutiny. People will hear every word of what you say and catch every mistake that you make. There are a billion people watching cricket, so there is a little bit of stress, baggage and nervousness in your head. And I was not getting much acceptance from my left and right [on the panel], who also felt that I shouldn't be there either. There were times when I would ask questions and I wouldn't get replies. People would just stare at me and say whatever they wanted to... as if I was just a spare part on the show.

"I was not getting much acceptance from my left and right [on the presenters' panel during the 2003 World Cup]. There were times when I would ask questions and I wouldn't get replies."

It took a lot of resilience and hanging in there. At the end of every pre-, mid- and post-match show, I would put my head down and cry. I would wonder, 'What am I even doing here?' But Sony [the broadcaster] really supported me. They told me you are not an expert, analyst or commentator... you are just a presenter, go out there and have fun. And it was a switch in my head—from one week of feeling unaccepted by people around me to saying, you know what, 'I'm here to stay'. They need to accept me. After that, if I asked a question and they wouldn't answer it, I would say, 'Sir, I asked you this question', and they would have to answer it. The cameras were on. I learnt a lot on the job.

Q What is the significance of this World Cup win?

It is the turning point for the sport. It is the one thing that is going to make all the difference. The players have become household names. To see the players performing the way they did, the attention was inevitable, but I hope it sustains. I don't know whether they will ever get the same kind of attention as men's cricket does, but I hope we're halfway there or three-quarters of the way. F

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Post their triumphant ODI World Cup campaign, Indian women cricketers raked in the moolah at the Women's Premier League auction

By **KATHAKALI CHANDA**



At a price tag of ₹3.2 crore, Deepti Sharma (centre) became the second-most expensive player in the history of the Women's Premier League

PHOTO BY ISHARA S. KODIKARA / AFP

From the ODI World Cup to the Women's Premier League (WPL) auction, Deepti Sharma is on a roll. Within a month of winning the Player of the Tournament trophy in India's victorious ODI World Cup campaign, the spunky all-rounder produced fireworks off the field, emerging as the most expensive player at this year's WPL auction.

At a price tag of `3.2 crore, the Agra-born player became the second-most expensive player in the history of the league—next only to her national colleague Smriti Mandhana, who was lapped up by Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) for `3.4 crore in 2023. Sharma now shares the No 2 spot with Australian all-rounder Ash Gardner and English captain Nat Sciver-Brunt.

Sharma's maiden bid, at her base price of `50 lakh, came from Delhi Capitals (DC)—it stayed uncontested for a few heartstopping minutes before UP Warriorz (UPW), her team for the first three seasons, played the RTM (Right To Match) card to bring her back. (An RTM card allows a player's former franchise to match the highest bid and reclaim her.)

Power-packed performances are nothing new for Sharma. The 28-year-old is the first Indian woman to cross both 1,000 runs and 100 wickets in T20Is, and was named the Most Valuable Player (MVP) in WPL 2024. Yet she has always remained at the fringes of public conversation. The recent World Cup—where Sharma became the first ever cricketer to score

200+ runs and take 20+ wickets in a single edition—has changed that.

One of the biggest takeaways from India's victory in the World Cup is the way it has broadened the narrative beyond established stars like Harmanpreet Kaur, Mandhana, Jemimah Rodrigues and Shafali Verma (all of whom were retained by their respective franchises and weren't part of the auction pool), and brought players like Sharma firmly into the spotlight, giving them better bargaining power at the auction table. "Deepti's story will tell you how the World Cup win has impacted the auction," says Kshemal Waingankar, the COO of Capri Sports that owns UPW. "Aside from Deepti, look at someone like Pratika Rawal, who was picked by us despite her injury. That's because the World Cup showed the potential she possesses."

Rawal, who was signed on for ₹50 lakh in an accelerated auction (an express round for targeted unsold players), was a standout batter in the World Cup, ending up fourth on the runs tally despite sitting out of both the semifinal and the final due to an injury.

"This WPL auction marks the definitive commercial graduation of women's cricket. We are witnessing the 'victory dividend'," says Hemant Dua, CEO of the Seattle Orcas in the US's Major League Cricket and the former CEO of Delhi Capitals. "The World Cup win has rewired franchise logic, creating a new economy where high demand for a limited number of Indian players dictates the price and value of international stars." Sharma's heroics, for example, have put her ahead of Kiwi Amelia Kerr (₹3 crore), the Player of the Tournament in the 2024 T20 World Cup, Sophie Devine (₹2 crore), who led New Zealand to the 2024 T20 World Cup, and Aussie Meg Lanning (₹1.9 crore), a seven-time World Cup winner. "This auction has shown that a proven Indian core is now more precious than international celebrity," adds Dua.

TOP 5
Most Expensive Picks
(2025 AUCTION)



DEEPTI SHARMA
₹3.2 cr



AMELIA KERR
₹3 cr



SHIKHA PANDEY
₹2.4 cr



SOPHIE DEVINE
₹2 cr



MEG LANNING
₹1.9 cr

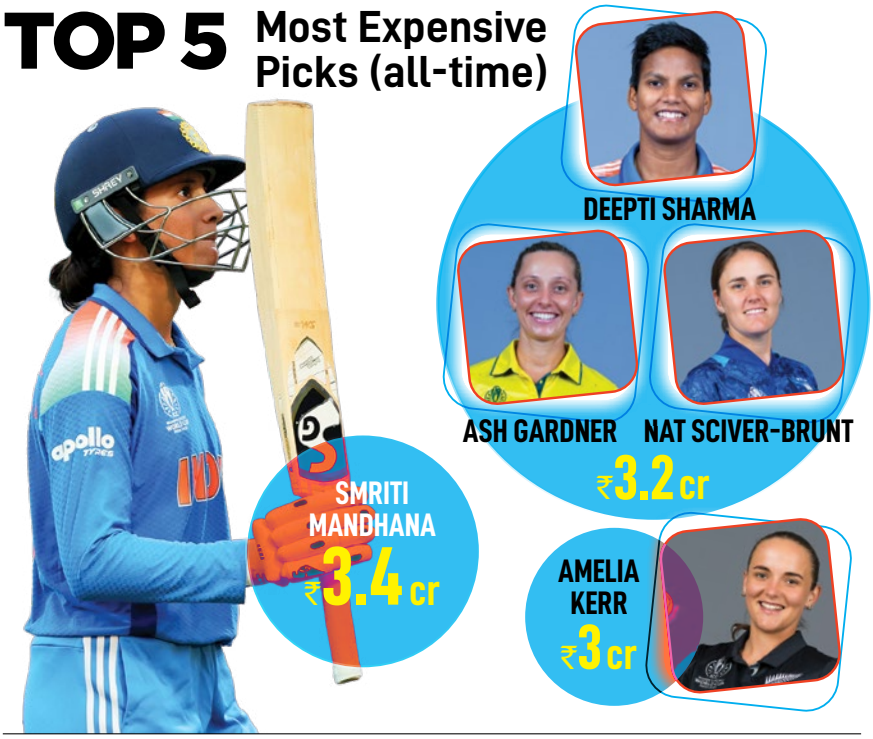
PHOTOS BY GETTY IMAGES

The changing dynamics also explain why N Shree Charani, who made her international debut in April and finished the World Cup with 14 wickets from nine matches, raked in a whopping ₹1.3 crore despite playing only two matches in her debut season in WPL 2025. DC, her previous franchise, forked out more than double of the ₹55 lakh they had in the last auction. "I expect a fair bit of bidding for someone like Charani, who's done exceptionally well during the World Cup. And we know how successful left-arm finger spinners are in the shortest format," Lisa Sthalekar, former Australia captain and a mentor with UPW, had told Forbes India before the auction. With her hefty payday, the 21-year-old spinner from Andhra Pradesh outshone her more established compatriots like West Indian Chinelle Henry (₹1.3 crore) and Australian Phoebe Litchfield (₹1.2 crore).

As the WPL's fourth season kicks off, women's cricket in India seems poised to keep rewriting records, both on and off the field

Aside from the headline acts of Sharma and Charani, members of the World Cup-winning squad like Harleen Deol (₹50 lakh), Radha Yadav (₹65 lakh), Sneh Rana (₹50 lakh), Kranti Gaud (₹50 lakh) and Arundhati Reddy (₹75 lakh), too, were picked up from an auction that saw the likes of six-time World Cup-winning Australia skipper Alyssa Healy going unsold.

Renuka Singh Thakur, though, might be disappointed with her value of ₹60 lakh despite her impressively tight spells throughout the tournament and an economy rate of 3.5 in the final against South Africa. The number is less than half of the ₹1.5 crore-deal she landed from RCB for the first three seasons. "The World Cup effect is seen in the fact that all the squad members were picked up,"



PHOTOS BY GETTY IMAGES

says Bhairav Shanth, co-founder, ITW Universe, a sports marketing and consulting agency. "Alongside, one key trend that has emerged is that the teams are focusing on acquiring all-rounders among Indian players, which shows how T20 strategy is evolving. That's where Renuka might have lost out, being an out-and-out bowler."

Adds Waingankar, who sat in on the auction with the UPW franchise: "The way the auction works is that teams look at different slots they have to fill, and perhaps they didn't need a pace bowler early on. Second, Renuka came up for bidding in the very first lot as part of the marquee set of eight players. It's possible that, at that time, the teams were looking to save money for later sets, where, as you would have seen, many players have fetched a premium."

How timing and strategy play a key role is evident from the way the purses were generously thrown open for all-rounder Shikha Pandey in the first round of the accelerated auction. Pandey, who hasn't played for the national team since 2023, was the showstopper of this round going for `2.4 crore, a price that's 4x of what DC had bought her for in the inaugural auction. With this, the bowling all-rounder leapfrogged the pool as the third most expensive player this year, at a time World Cup winners like Gaud and Singh Thakur pocketed a cheque of `50 lakh and `60 lakh, respectively. "The biggest surprise for me was Shikha. She had a good WPL last season, but, more importantly, I feel she was a strategic fit," says Shanth of ITW. "She gave UPW a frontline pacer, which was missing from their arsenal." Add to that the fact that Pandey was the most recognised domestic pacer left in the pool at that point in the auction would also explain why she commanded the price.

The Board of Control for Cricket in India has onboarded three new commercial partners for WPL at a combined value of ₹48 crore

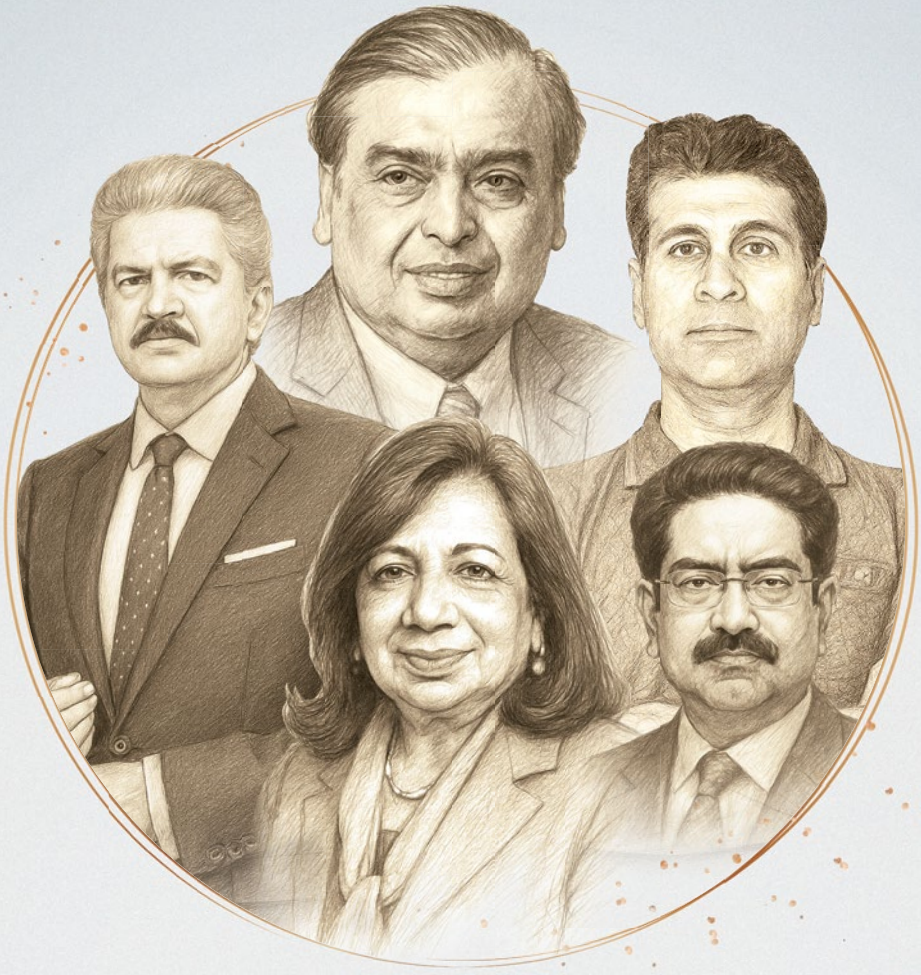
"The second part of why someone gets chosen is that teams also look for players with experience, players who've been there," says Waingankar of UPW. "So someone like a Meg Lanning, a Shikha Pandey or an Asha Sobhana get picked up at a premium for what they have done in the past." Sobhana, who went for `1.10 crore in the auction from a base price of `30 lakh despite missing the last season with an injury, was the second-highest wicket-taker of the tournament in 2024 and was the first Indian player to take a five-wicket haul in WPL.

Alongside, the World Cup victory has also had a knock-on effect on the entire WPL ecosystem as the Board of Control for Cricket in India has onboarded three new commercial partners—ChatGPT, Kingfisher and Bisleri—at a combined value of `48 crore. The trio has signed up for the next two seasons.

That the WPL will kickstart the commercial engine for women's cricket in India was evident from its inaugural season, when it bagged `951 crore and `4,670 crore for the media rights and franchise sales, respectively. The momentum only grew with record TV viewership: The first 15 matches of the second season in 2024 clocked a viewership of 103 million, up from 67.8 million for the first 14 matches of the previous season.

The ODI World Cup has pushed the ceiling even higher, with the reach of the tournament growing 5x compared to the previous edition. With 185 million logging in, the India versus South Africa final became the most-watched women's cricket match ever, and equalled the viewership numbers for the men's T20 World Cup final in 2024.

As the WPL's fourth season kicks off on January 9, women's cricket in India seems poised to keep rewriting records, both on and off the field. F



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PHOTO BY SHAWN HUBBARD FOR FORBES

Chicken Scratch

Todd Graves's Raising Cane's is one of America's hottest fast-food chains, and its founder is America's richest restaurateur, worth $22 billion

By CHASE PETERSON-WITHORN

Todd Graves is in tour-guide mode.

He begins at a small restaurant a block from Louisiana State University (LSU). The summer sun is baking the blacktop as Graves marches through the drive-thru, heading for the menu board he personally erected 29 years ago. "I built this structure," he says, naming the local lumberyard that sold him the wood. He points out the 20-foot mural he had painted on the side of the building. He showcases the neon "chicken fingers" light he designed at a Baton Rouge sign shop.

Inside the cramped eatery, we make stops at the portrait of his dog he hung on the wall, the disco ball he installed and the spot he carved his name into a table. "Let me show you the back," he says, speeding through the kitchen to a closet-sized office where he built himself a small desk to keep the books. "I spent so much time in here counting the tills."

Near the front door, a 20-something customer pulls Graves aside to pitch an idea for a drive-thru dog treat chain. Graves suggests the man start smaller, with a trailer or maybe an event booth—exactly the sort of wise, cautious advice he would have flatly ignored at that age.

At 22, Todd Graves was 100 percent certain a spot serving only chicken fingers would be a hit with LSU students, even if the banks thought he was a dumb kid with a bad idea. He had a childish menu, no management experience, no money. "When you're an entrepreneur and you believe in something to your core, you use every no and every 'it's not going to work' as fuel," he says, now a youthful 53 with a head of greying dark brown hair and a Louisiana bayou drawl. "It's the best thing that can happen to you."

Three decades after scraping together the cash to open his first restaurant, Graves has put up more than 900 Raising Cane's Chicken Fingers locations in 42 states. It's one of America's biggest chains—and one of the quickest growing, currently adding around 125 stores a year. Graves can't open them fast enough. Sales hit $5.1 billion last year, or a staggering $6.6 million per store, second only to Chick-fil-A ($7.5 million) and more than double that of all but six major chains. A typical fast-food joint is lucky to break $2 million. "It's just effing incredible," says restaurant consultant John Gordon.

No one runs a fast-food business

quite like Graves. While most chains offer expansive menus to cater to every taste and shuffle in movie tie-ins or limited-time combos to drive interest, Graves's menu hasn't grown up one bit. Raising Cane's serves just five food items: Chicken fingers, crinkle fries, coleslaw, Texas toast and a single dipping sauce. No dessert. Forget about a salad. He hasn't allowed a new item since 2007 (lemonade). Friends, family, bankers and customers have often suggested Graves add more to the mix. He's heard it a hundred thousand times, maybe more. "I'll look into that," he politely tells them, but he knows he won't. "We do one thing—chicken fingers—and we do it better than anybody else," he says, laying out his core philosophy: "If you try to be all things to all people, you won't be special."

Those around him tend to use terms like detail oriented. Passionate. Control freak. "I'm extremely into the details," says Graves, carefully styled this sweltering afternoon in a jet-black polo, light-wash jeans and crisp white sneakers. Many of his competitors are selling out to Wall Street firms, including the billionaires behind Subway (sold to Roark Capital for $9 billion-plus), Jersey Mike's Subs (Blackstone, a $8 billion valuation, including debt) and Cane's competitor Zaxby's (Goldman Sachs, a nearly $2 billion valuation). Graves can't imagine ever selling. He still writes many of Raising Cane's marketing campaigns. He personally reviews the kids' meal toys. He oversees every decoration nailed to every restaurant wall.

His obsession has paid off. Graves is now America's richest restaurateur, worth $22 billion, thanks to his 92 percent stake in the business. That places him at No 46 on this year's Forbes 400 list—in the financial league of Jerry Jones and Rupert Murdoch. "I'm living a dream," he says, extending the tour to his nearby 5,000-square-foot guesthouse that he lends to his NFL-star buddies and the $400,000 treehouse where he hangs out with celebrity superfans like Shaquille O'Neal and Snoop Dogg. "I'm living an absolute dream."



Pictured on Graves's lap, Raising Cane (died 1998) was the chain's unofficial mascot

The unassuming two-storey building around the corner from the first Cane's store is a journey back in time. Inside a second-floor apartment, a Panasonic VHS player flanks an old TV set; boxy beige computers and floppy disks sit atop cheap desks; a case of Dixie beer is displayed on the counter. The scene has been faithfully re-created by Graves to look just as it did in the late 1990s, when he moved into the apartment and, as he expanded, turned it into a makeshift headquarters, pushing his bed into a corner (where it remains) to make way for more desks. Graves bought the building in 2016 and now brings restaurant managers and corporate staff through for a lesson in brand history and staying scrappy. "History is important to keep in your company," he says. "This is where we started... our roots."

Graves is a natural storyteller. The son of an extended auto warranty salesman who spent a couple seasons in the NFL as a New Orleans Saints tackle long before it paid any real money, Graves was the kid running a lemonade stand, hiring friends to join his lawn service and painting house numbers on curbs, one-upping the competition by adding a small pineapple. He wrote a puppet TV show called *The Adventures of Doozy Haha and His Brothers* and studied telecommunications at the University of Georgia, daydreaming of moving to Hollywood and pushing a broom to get his foot in the door at a movie studio. But the urge to start his own business—"it seemed more tangible"—won out.

Fast food was the obvious choice.

Graves has put up more than 900 Raising Cane's Chicken Fingers locations in 42 states. It's one of US's biggest chains

Graves had worked restaurant jobs since high school and regularly spent hours making gumbo with his mother. "Food just symbolised love for me," he recalls.

By the 1990s, chicken was overtaking beef in the American diet and boneless strips were becoming popular at national chains like TGI Fridays and Applebee's. Then there was Guthrie's, a small Alabama-based chain that had been expanding across college campuses, including the University of Georgia, where Graves dished out chicken fingers and crinkle fries to fellow college kids. He told Craig Silvey, a childhood buddy studying at LSU, that they should open their own version.

Silvey had to write a business plan for a class, so the duo submitted their chicken finger concept, mapping out everything from the cost of aprons to the brand of toilet paper they'd buy. The professor gave them a B-minus. "He said the plan was good but the concept is flawed," Graves recalls. The major chains were expanding their menus and going healthier—they'd need to offer more options. Graves wasn't convinced. "I knew well enough to know that at my favourite restaurants I order the same thing every time."

So he and Silvey made a blood pact that they'd go through with it, solemnising their vow by scratching their wrists with an old chicken claw they had found. They hit Office Depot, bought two cheap briefcases they thought would look professional, then hit the banks. One after another declined, either not believing in the restaurant, the pair's ability to run it or both. "It was not a pleasant experience," Silvey says.

To stack cash fast, Graves found work as a boilermaker in Los Angeles, manning welding equipment and blow torches at oil refineries. When he heard the real money was in Alaska, commercial sockeye salmon fishing in Bristol Bay, Silvey and he flew north. They pitched a tent on the side





The $400,000 Treehouse

"It's fun to have things that are magical," says Todd Graves, standing near a flat-screen TV in the living room of his backyard treehouse in Baton Rouge, Louisiana. A fan of the Animal Planet series *Treehouse Masters*, Graves had the show build him a tree-home fit for a billionaire in 2015. His three-level aerie, wrapped around a 100-foot live oak, boasts a well-stocked bar, a spacious bedroom and a functioning half-bath. The pine ceiling uses reclaimed wood from an old sewing factory; the bar and an ornate stained-glass window were salvaged from New Orleans after Hurricane Katrina. A 70-foot swinging bridge connects the 400-square-foot living quarters to a lakefront viewing platform overlooking LSU's campus. Graves paid around $400,000 for the treehouse—about as much as typical Americans spend on their actual home—and uses it to host the likes of rapper Nelly, NFL star Ja'Marr Chase and basketball great Shaquille O'Neal, who was inspired to build his own speakeasy-themed treehouse in Georgia. "I like things with great stories behind them," says Graves, who also owns a 66-million-year-old triceratops skeleton, Harrison Ford's Raiders of the Lost Ark jacket and Elvis Presley's sunglasses. "I just won a bid on one of Napoleon's hats today," he says. "It keeps me dreaming, man."

of the highway, eventually making their way to the docks and talking their way onto a couple vessels. "We rammed boats, boats rammed us. We were catching so much fish," Graves remembers. "*National Geographic*'s flying planes over, medical helicopters are coming in, you're hearing on the radio somebody died."

"I wasn't too happy about the salmon fishing," says Gay Graves, Todd's mother. "But he always called home."

When the duo returned to Baton Rouge about a year later, $50,000 in hard-won savings in hand, they looked a lot more creditworthy. Their cash, $90,000 from a few local investors and a $50,000 Small Business Administration loan was enough to lease the space just off LSU's north gates. They got to work, installing everything from the menu board to the wood-panelled walls to the bathroom plumbing themselves to save money. They tooled around the South in a U-Haul scooping up used kitchen equipment and restaurant booths on the cheap. Graves worked with local food suppliers to essentially steal Guthrie's menu but tweak it to his liking (Guthrie's slightly thicker crinkle fries have "too much inner softness of the potato", he says, while his competitor's slightly thinner Texas toast is "not as dense" as he'd prefer). While scrambling to open the restaurant, he connected with Gwen, now his wife of 25 years, who was running a nearby McDonald's franchise, bonding with her over such conversation starters as: "How do you salt your fries?"

Sales hit $5.1 billion last year, or a staggering $6.6 million per store. A typical fast-food joint is lucky to break $2 million

Graves and Silvey almost called their chicken joint Sockeye's, in honour of their salmon fishing days, until a friend wisely suggested naming it after Graves's dog, a yellow labrador named Raising Cane, an intentional misspelling of the Biblically inspired idiom that means to cause a ruckus. (Raising Cane III, his third yellow lab and the chain's current mascot, has 100,000 Instagram followers.)

The first Raising Cane's opened in August 1996, with Graves, Silvey and a crew of eight manning the registers and fryers. It made a $30 profit the first month and just kept going. Six months in, Graves set about convincing his SBA lender to finance a second location near a strip mall on a quieter stretch just south of LSU's campus, this one with a drive-thru. "We started getting different customers," he says. "Tee-ball teams on Sunday, mom and dad coming home from work, businesspeople during lunch."

Silvey, tired of the 100-hour weeks and ready to ditch the kitchen for an MBA and the Web 1.0 boom in Silicon Valley, soon wanted out. In 1999, Graves paid him a six-figure sum and agreed to take his name off the lease and bank liabilities—a great return for a 27-year-old for just a few years' work. Then again, Silvey's stake would now be worth north of $10 billion. (Silvey, who remains friends with Graves, later rejoined Cane's as an exec for a half-dozen years and owns a tiny stake of less than 0.5 percent today.) "It's always easy to have hindsight," says Silvey, now the CFO of ClowdCover, a Louisiana-based IT services firm. "There was a level of risk that no matter how many times I replay it, I know I wouldn't have done. It's like you're always putting it on black on the roulette table."



To fund his entrepreneurial dreams, Graves hitchhiked across Alaska in 1995 to find a spot on a salmon fishing boat

Graves kept gambling, on six more locations by 2000 and 24 by 2004. "I leveraged the heck out of the business," he says. "I had a big risk tolerance." A typical manoeuver to finance a new location: Raising subordinate debt from private investors at a 15 percent rate, then borrowing the rest from community banks that would treat the debt as equity, effectively financing 100 percent. "It's not a smart way to grow," he says now. When Hurricane Katrina hit in August 2005, it knocked 21 of his 28 stores offline, nearly costing him the business. He hustled to keep lenders at bay and vowed never to put the company in that position again.

On a typical day, Raising Cane's churns out 6.4 million chicken fingers, 700,000 pounds of crinkle fries and 1.5 million slabs of thick-cut Texas toast

On a typical day, Raising Cane's churns out 6.4 million chicken fingers, 700,000 pounds of crinkle fries and 1.5 million slabs of thick-cut Texas toast. There are advantages to keeping things simple. McDonald's, for example, has to track more than 100 menu items and manage a supply chain that spans fresh apple slices to frozen beef patties to ice cream mix. Cane's has just a handful of items to handle. That keeps costs down and satisfies Graves's obsession with freshness.

Chicken is delivered raw to stores, where it's marinated and hand-battered daily. Toast is buttered and griddled in-house. Every morning, workers hand-squeeze lemonade and whip up batches of the chain's signature Cane's Sauce (a tangy blend of mainly mayo and ketchup).

Because the menu is so simple, food often goes right from the fryers to a customer's plate in as little as 30 seconds. Cane's, which doesn't have heat lamps or warming cabinets, won't serve anything that's more than a few minutes old. It's inexpensive. The most popular Box Combo, with four fingers and all three sides, runs about $10.50. Because the mere act of a customer deciding between, say, a regular tender or a spicy tender would slow things down, Graves won't even offer a spicy option. That keeps lines moving. Cane's sends a car through its drive-thru in about 2.5 minutes, according to an analysis by restaurant trade publication *QSR*, 40 percent faster than McDonald's and three times quicker than KFC.

Around 2004, Graves began offering Raising Cane's franchises to a handful of experienced restaurant operators and star employees to help grow the brand. By 2016, around 30 percent of his restaurants were run by someone else. But he couldn't handle the loss of control. "If we operate our stores at a 95 out of 100 and the franchisees were operating at 85, the 10-point gap drove me crazy," he says. He began buying them out. Now just 22 locations in the US are franchised plus 52 in the Middle East, where he's relying on a local franchisee who knows the landscape.

Last year, Cane's generated $928 million in Ebidta, plenty to service its $2.6 billion net debt load and throw off an estimated $250 million dividend to Graves. He has funneled cash into some 150 personal investments, many of them in real estate, including recent purchases of a $75 million building in Nashville that's home to the local Margaritaville and a $15 million penthouse atop the Four Seasons a few blocks away.

To help manage it all, in 2017 Graves brought on a co-CEO, AJ

McBillionaires

Todd Graves's "chicken finger dream" began with a college job at the Athens, Georgia, outpost of regional chicken chain Guthrie's. Zach McLeroy, co-founder of Raising Cane's competitor Zaxby's, is said to have gotten his start a few years earlier at the exact same restaurant (which is now a Cane's). But they aren't the only billionaires whose journey to the three-comma club began with a fast-food shift.



Jeff Bezos
Net worth: *$241 billion* **(Amazon)**
A 16-year-old Bezos clocked in for 20 to 30 hours a week at a Miami-area McDonald's in the early 1980s, cracking 300 eggs a day, flipping burgers and cleaning bathrooms. "No job is beneath you," he says.



Jensen Huang
$151 billion **(Nvidia)**
After emigrating from Taiwan, Huang took a job at an Oregon Denny's when he was 15. He bussed tables, washed "the living daylight" out of dishes and cleaned the bathrooms before eventually moving up to pouring coffee and waiting tables. He and his co-founders later dreamt up Nvidia while seated in a Denny's booth.



Mark Stevens
$10.5 billion **(venture capital)**
Before earning billions backing LinkedIn, Google and Nvidia, a 16-year-old Stevens earned $2.50 frying onion rings and french fries at a Culver City, California, Jack in the Box. "It teaches you inventory and detail management," he says.



Russ Weiner
$5.4 billion **(Rockstar energy drinks)**
Embarrassed to be seen in his Wendy's uniform, a 15-year-old Weiner would change at the restaurant just before his $3.50-an-hour shifts. He regrets his early shame: "Never be too proud to work."







Aim for the Stars

Catch Graves at a Formula 1 race, the US Open or the Super Bowl, where he throws lavish seven-figure parties attended by the likes of (from top) actor Glen Powell, NFL star Joe Burrow and NBA legend Shaquille O'Neal. "These are multimillion-dollar investments," Graves says, "but my marketing return has been about 4x."

Kumaran, a seasoned industry exec who was formerly the COO of an international chain running more than 100 Hard Rock Cafés, California Pizza Kitchens, Pinkberrys and other brands. Kumaran keeps an eye on Cane's daily operations, leaving Graves to obsess over motivating his 70,000 crew members and promoting the brand.

Graves is never still. The morning of his *Forbes* sitdown, he hosts LSU men's baseball players at the first Cane's store, celebrating their College World Series title by parading a 30-foot tiger float out front. The next day, he travels 140 miles to shoot a video with his dog and football royalty Archie, Cooper and Arch Manning. That same day, NBA player Alex Caruso, fresh off winning a championship with the Oklahoma City Thunder, works a shift at a Cane's store for an Instagram promotion. Graves FaceTimes to congratulate him. He travels constantly, spending about half his time away from his Baton Rouge home, visiting Cane's locations and palling around with the chain's celebrity backers. Last fall, he guest-sharked on two episodes of the hit ABC show *Shark Tank*, pledging to invest some $700,000 in a handful of startups.

It's all marketing. Graves spends as much as 5 percent of his top line, some $250 million, on media and marketing each year, in line with other fast-food chains. But he doesn't tend to go for expensive national TV blitzes. Instead, he prefers to give to local charities ($165 million over the years), sponsor local sports teams and partner with a whole lot of A-listers. He had a breakthrough with Snoop Dogg in 2021, when Graves thought it would make a fun video if the Doggfather worked the drive-thru, handing out orders and his new album. "That went viral," Graves says, "and that's when I was like, click: I can do this stuff for cheap with celebrities and influencers."

Now a procession of movie stars, rock stars and sports stars line up to work with Cane's—more than 80 in all last year, from NFL great Travis Kelce to rapper Ice-T to the WNBA's Angel Reese. When the musician Post Malone, a friend, asked Graves to open a Cane's near his Utah home, Graves let him design his own bright-pink store, then split the restaurant's profits with him.

The obvious question: How long before the menu goes stale? Inflation-fatigued customers are becoming hooked on value menu deals and in-app rewards—neither of which Graves usually offers. Then there's the competition. "There's so much chicken finger interest right now," says Gordon, the industry expert. McDonald's recently made a tender its first new menu item in four years. Fast-growing Wingstop just added a new crispy strip. In June, billionaire Neal Aronson's Roark Capital bought 70 percent of fast-rising spicy finger concept Dave's Hot Chicken at a $1 billion valuation. Even Taco Bell offered chicken tenders this year.

Graves's response is to double down. More stores. More celebs. More employees, and a new, 400,000-square-foot corporate campus in Plano, Texas, to house them. Not a discount or menu change in sight. Instead, he and his co-CEO are making a big push internationally, where they are looking to expand from those 52 stores in the Middle East into Europe and Latin America. The long-range goal? Some $10 billion in sales and 1,600 stores by the end of the decade. It would be hard to bet against him. In a famously difficult industry, Graves has notched 16 straight years of same-store sales growth. Why change now?

"I'm going to keep doing the same thing," he declares. "And if you do exactly what we do, you better be damn good at it, because we're relentless."

Zone Offense

AutoZone made a billionaire out of its founder—and millionaires of its employees. But can one of the top stocks of the last three decades keep it up in the face of new rivals?

By JOHN HYATT



"I started with this philosophy: Everybody wants to be part of a winning team," says AutoZone founder Pitt Hyde (left). "And no matter what position they hold, they want to feel like they can make a difference." Store manager turned CEO Phil Daniele is trying to stay the course

PHOTO BY CODY PICKENS FOR FORBES

Phil Daniele was working for a competing auto-parts chain when AutoZone entered the Jacksonville, Florida, market in 1986. Daniele had worked in car stores since high school, paying his way through college by stocking shelves. He joined AutoZone in 1993 as a store manager in training before being given his own store after a few months, the first of ten titles in three decades. "I'm not a phenomenon. If you look at our leadership team, many of our VPs started out in an hourly role at a store," says Daniele, 56, who is now CEO of AutoZone.

Today, AutoZone—known for its universal get in the zone, AutoZone radio jingle—employs 126,000 people, with over 6,500 stores in the US and another 1,000 in Mexico and Brazil. The retailer sells everything from motor oil and upholstery cleaner to specialised car parts for nearly every make and model. With $18.5 billion in sales last year, it is worth about $70 billion. In the last 20 years, its shares have returned an average of 21 percent annually, trouncing the S&P 500's 11 percent average return (including dividends reinvested) over the same period. AutoZone has

generated nine figure-plus windfalls for its original private equity sponsor KKR, hedge fund billionaire Eddie Lampert and its founder, Pitt Hyde, who stepped down as CEO in 1996.

"I wish I had never diversified—that was a huge mistake," jokes Hyde, 82, who is worth around $2 billion today. He sold most of his AutoZone stock back in the 1990s. Had he kept it, he'd be worth over $10 billion.

But it's not just AutoZone's investors and top brass who have gotten rich, and that is the company's real secret sauce. With a compensation system built around stock options, the retailer has made many of its rank-and-file wealthy beyond their wildest dreams. More than 4,000 AutoZone employees—including many like Daniele who began as hourly employees or store managers in the 1980s and '90s—have become millionaires from their AutoZone stock, Hyde says.

"Our compensation structure is one of the key elements of our success," says Bill Rhodes, chair of the board since 2007 and AutoZone's CEO and president from 2005 to 2023. "There are very, very few companies that are still 100 percent stock options in their long-term incentives. That's what we are with our senior leadership team."

Following a 2006 accounting rule change requiring companies to record options as expenses on their income statement, many S&P 500 companies have favoured compensation packages with restricted and performance-based stock units (grants of stock with no exercise price) over stock options (the right to buy a stock at the price on the date it was awarded). But AutoZone stayed the course and has granted options awards to eligible employees every year for the past 25 years equal to 0.9 percent of its total shares outstanding. Executives can also elect to take 25 percent of their annual compensation in AutoZone stock. "Our people want the risk. They want the leverage that comes with stock options," says Rhodes, who has netted over a half-billion dollars exercising options and selling the stock (before taxes).

As it's grown, AutoZone has restricted eligibility of stock options awards to about 400 higher-level employees, down from over 38,000 in the late '90s. Today, store managers who drive AutoZone's retail sales are incentivised with cash bonuses based on sales quotas. Store hands are supposed to ask people if they need help within 30 seconds of a customer walking into the store. They perform routine maintenance, like changing batteries or installing wipers, at no cost and on site. Hit your targets and drive sales and you'll be compensated for it. Or better yet, one day you may end up in corporate—which means stock options whose value only seems to go up. Employees can also buy up to $15,000 in AutoZone stock annually at a 15 percent discount to market price, through an employee stock purchase plan. The idea is to keep the sales force aligned, invested in AutoZone's future and motivated to sell, sell, sell.

At corporate, the mantra has been buy, buy, buy back its own stock. AutoZone has purchased $38 billion of its shares since 1998 through May 2025, reducing its outstanding share count by over 90 percent from 152 million to 16.7 million as of June. (Nineteen ninety-eight is also when it started limiting stock options.) The company has bought back more shares over time (155.5 million) than it originally had outstanding (152 million). How is that mathematically possible? It's because of the dilution from all those stock options the company awards.

The model has proven durable, thanks to AutoZone's earnings moving in only one direction. Since 1987, revenue has increased every year (growing 11.5 percent annually), while operating income ($3.3 billion last year) and net income ($2.6 billion last year) have increased in all but three years. The company has been disciplined in its capital expenditure, opting for slow and steady earnings growth over breakneck expansion. It helps that the auto-parts industry cruises through recessions, as cash-strapped drivers opt to fix rather than replace their cars. "If you put financial engineering on top of a bad business you're just going to go out of business faster," Rhodes says. "If you have a really good business, putting financial engineering on top of that can optimise performance, or as I sometimes like to say, put it on steroids."

But to keep its well-oiled machine

View it Yourself

DIYers might still grab supplies from the local Home Depot or AutoZone, but the how-to guide went online long ago. Here is a handful of hands-on influencers with seven-figure followings on YouTube



ChrisFix • FOLLOWERS: 10.8 million
Advice on how to do a brake job, replace a transmission or restore your car's headlights using toothpaste.

Karina Garcia • 9 million
The Gen Z–popular "queen of slime" has recipes for making ultra-clear slime, thick and glossy slime, even slime in bulk.

Dad, How Do I? • 5.3 million
Rob Kenney's father abandoned him at age 14. Now he posts tutorials on topics like how to tie a tie, shave or start a campfire.

Home RenoVision DIY • 3.8 million
Contractor Jeff Thorman explains how to do everything from painting a wall to finishing an entire basement.

Kipkay • 2.5 million
An early YouTuber (he joined before Google bought the site in 2006) with gadget hacks such as how to charge your phone with a flashlight or make a Wi-Fi signal booster with a beer can.

chugging, AutoZone needs to keep growing. It holds $9 billion in long-term debt on which it must pay interest ($450 million last year), and it has accelerated share repurchases, averaging $3.6 billion in annual share buybacks from 2021 through '24, compared to an average of $1.2 billion the previous decade.

Its biggest headaches are macro headwinds. For one, its beloved DIY customer—the fix-'er-up guy who comes into the local AutoZone store to be charmed by a motivated salesman—is "a bit of a dying breed," says Phillip Blee, a consumer equity analyst at William Blair. In 1990, over half of Americans identified as car DIYers, but today, DIYers account for only a fifth of the total $400 billion automotive aftermarket. Not only have parts have gotten more expensive, cutting into the value proposition, but cars have become harder to repair as they have become more complex and computerised. AutoZone also faces growing competition for the diehard DIYers from the likes of Walmart, Costco and Amazon. "The big box retailers are some of the more near-term threats," Blee says.

AutoZone increasingly sells directly to repair shops, both independents and national chains, a market that now accounts for an estimated 75 percent of the entire industry and 90 percent of its growth, according to William Blair. In this space, where customer service is less about face-to-face salesmanship and more about delivering parts faster than anyone else, its biggest rival, O'Reilly Auto Parts, has raced ahead, generating $7.8 billion last year from commercial sales, compared to AutoZone's $5.9 billion.

Daniele sees that not as a failure but an opportunity. He says AutoZone is beefing up its distribution network with new megahubs that hold over 100,000 unique car parts for nearly any vehicle, from your sister's new Toyota Camry to your neighbour's beat-up Chevy Corvette. "We've worked on our strategy of expanding our supply chain. We've run it too tight before," says the CEO, who ran the commercial business from 2015 to 2021. And AutoZone isn't loosening its grip on DIYers; it's just looking for them in different places. The chain plans to open 500 new stores in 2028, up from the 190 it has averaged the last five years, 200 of them in Mexico and Brazil.

AutoZone is nothing if not adaptable. Joseph "Pitt" Hyde III founded the company, then called Auto Shack, in 1979 after seeing the writing on the wall for his family business, Memphis, Tennessee–based Malone & Hyde, which sold groceries to independent mom-and-pop grocery stores and small chains in the South. He watched as Walmart—on whose board he sat from 1978 to 1983—gobbled up his market share. His idea was to take Walmart's retailer-distributor model, combine it with a shiny supermarket aesthetic and bring it to a smaller industry with fatter margins. Auto parts, which combined fixed prices, inelastic demand and no clear national brand, struck him as a clear winner. He researched the industry for a year before opening his first store in Forrest City, Arkansas. Within five years he had 170 stores.

"I learned so much from Sam [Walton] about his whole productivity cycle," Hyde recalls. "He was growing rapidly, and as he leveraged his central overhead he gained buying power. Rather than putting it on the bottom line, he reflected it in lower prices. And that's what we instituted at AutoZone."

Clear-eyed about the trajectory of his two businesses' futures, Hyde took Malone & Hyde private with KKR in 1984 and spun out AutoZone (renamed after a lawsuit by RadioShack) two years later. "It was really modeled after Walmart: low prices, great customer service . . . a good old-fashioned way of doing things," says George Roberts, KKR's billionaire co-founder, which made $2.3 billion on its AutoZone stake. Hyde stepped down as CEO and board chair in 1996 after being diagnosed with prostate cancer.

Hedge fund billionaire Eddie Lampert, best known for merging Sears with Kmart, built a 30 percent stake in AutoZone between 1998 and 2001 and came to its board with ideas, including the share buyback programme. "He pitched for us to change our capital allocation," recalls Rhodes, who was then SVP of finance. "We've continued to use that over the years and it's gotten bigger and bigger."

Hedge fund billionaire Eddie Lampert, best known for merging Sears with Kmart, built a 30 percent stake in AutoZone between 1998 and 2001

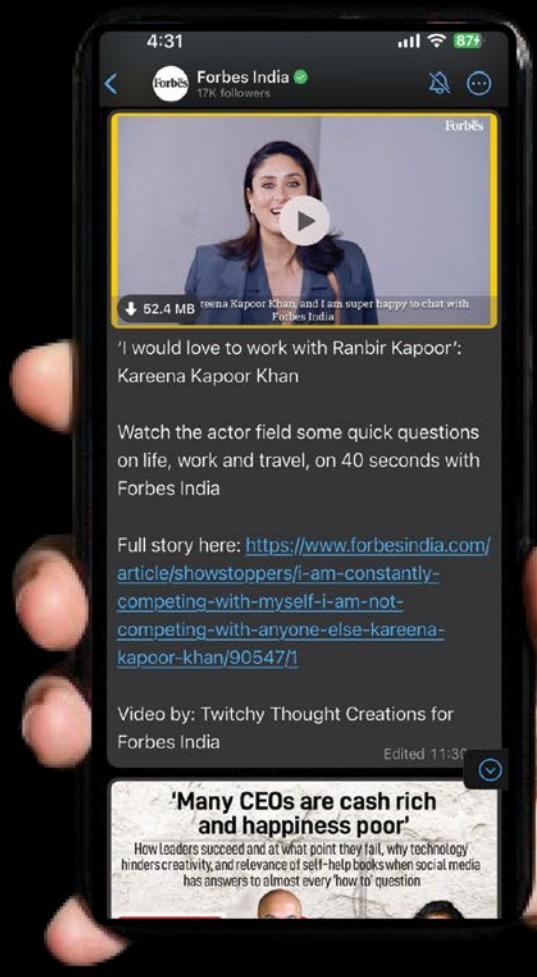
AutoZone's smartest bet was its $57 million ($118 million in today's dollars) acquisition in 1996 of vehicle diagnostics database Alldata, which employees use constantly to identify the exact car part any given customer needs (and how much it will cost).

As AutoZone enters its next chapter, Daniele is determined to uphold what made it so successful and so rewarding. "Our culture has modified and morphed a little bit, but the primary tenets are the same," he says. "If you're committed to the industry and committed to the culture, you can do anything at this company." If AutoZone can keep its stock market magic alive and its flock faithful, he just might be right. F

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SACRED GAMES
VIKRAM CHANDRA
THE PALACE OF ILLUSIONS
A GUARDIAN AND A THIEF
MEGHA MAJUMDAR
Arundhati Roy
THE BANDIT QUEENS

‘I Am Most at Peace When I Am Writing’

Author-columnist Twinkle Khanna on her new book, Mrs Funnybones Returns, *using wit and sarcasm as armours, and why writers need to stay away from AI*

By **KUNAL PURANDARE**

Books have been an integral part of Twinkle Khanna’s life. So much so that her friends in boarding school claim she often missed lunch because she was busy reading. “In that case, I would not be that size... I was big,” she says self-deprecatingly.

Ten years after her first book, *Mrs Funnybones*, was published, Khanna, 51, is out with its sequel, *Mrs Funnybones Returns*. It is based on and curated from the columns she began writing a decade ago. Over the past year and a half, she has revisited and rewritten them to put them in the perspective of a changing India and her own evolution as a writer-thinker.

Settling down with a cup of coffee in her cosy, beach-facing Juhu office—filled with books and movie poster frames—the author-columnist spoke to *Forbes India* about the challenges of writing, why stories of older women fascinate her, reinventing herself after quitting showbiz as an actor, hosting a talk show, *Two Much*, and why artificial intelligence (AI) cannot write for you. Edited excerpts from an interview:

Q Why did it take a decade to come out with a sequel to *Mrs Funnybones*?

I never thought I would do a sequel. After *Mrs Funnybones*, I did a collection of short stories and wrote a novel. And then I did my master’s and followed it with another collection of short stories. It was during that tour that I realised how much this book meant to so many people. I think somewhere, at least for me, maybe because I grew up reading literary fiction, I took the Funnybones voice a little bit for granted. The book has reached labour rooms, war zones, it’s speaking to people and giving them comfort. I realised there is tremendous value in it... in what I had not been seeing all this time.

Q What is the most exciting thing in *Mrs Funnybones Returns* for readers?

For readers, it’s also a way of seeing a decade of India, of women. How that has changed, and how my perspective has also changed. The things we were talking about earlier and what we’re talking about now... and whether there has been a significant change in women’s lives. If you read the newspapers, you’ll say education is better and women have bank accounts. But have they entered the workforce as much as they should have? They haven’t. Has the social structure of their life, their relationships changed? It hasn’t. So, it’s an insight because it covers a decade.

Columnist, writer and former Bollywood actor Twinkle Khanna

Q You use a lot of wit and sarcasm. Is that your style or does it depend on what you are writing about?

In the columns, definitely, I use humour to get the point across because if you make somebody laugh at something, then they look at it in a different light. It’s also more palatable. You can say a lot of things and get away with it, which you would not be able to if you were just putting it down straight, especially when it comes to politics. So, I would say it’s my disguise, it’s my armour, and it lets me get the point across. In some fiction, I definitely use a more reflective voice because that’s the way that story needs to be told. So my voice automatically alters when it comes to Mrs Funnybones. There is only one way to write it. There are certain columns which are serious in *Mrs Funnybones* as well, but by and large, it just happens.

Q Writing is a rewarding experience, but it can be torturous as well. Do you experience writer’s block, and how do you deal with it?

It’s absolutely not rewarding while you’re writing. Absolutely not. You are taking your head and banging it against a wall, hoping something shakes and you get some new ideas. I’ve been writing for about 14 years. For the first few years, I would sit at my desk, and I had this theory that even if the muse is going to somebody else, if I just sit

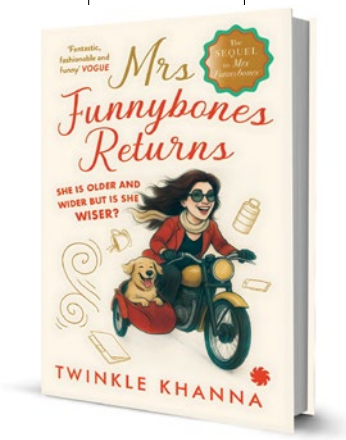
here, I can catch the muse on its way and bring it back to my desk. Now I'm too old and when I sit at my desk, my neck starts hurting. Now I walk... I keep walking. And when I'm walking my dog and I'm seeing people walk by or I'm doing some gardening, the ideas will all come together. I have to do my research, I have to look at all my notes, and then I have to leave it. Then I just walk, and it comes together after which I sit at my desk. So, this is a tip for older writers. We just cannot sit at our desks anymore. Our bodies are not going to let us. So perhaps this works.

Q Do you keep going back to your work, reworking it?

Oh yeah. Earlier, when I started writing columns, I had maybe 11 drafts, but now it's about three to four. The first draft is, I would say, absolute nonsense. It's just whatever ideas I have... they're disjointed. What I do well, though, is find a common thread between very disparate things. Once I wrote a column... it was about a photograph of space and Hema Malini, and I can find that thread. So I think that is the only gift I have—I can find something common between two subjects.

Q You did a master's in writing from London. How did that help you? Would you recommend a workshop or course for aspiring writers?

I did two courses at Oxford during the pandemic—one was for beginners in non-fiction and another was advanced in fiction. And then I went back to university and did my master's. In terms of how I work towards a column, nothing has changed. The framework, the process, the skeleton... everything is the same as earlier. When it comes to storytelling otherwise, whether it's short stories or novels, it has completely changed. The Oxford courses were fantastic, they gave me technical skills, and the master's—because we had to workshop so much with other students, our own work, other writers—gave me the ability to dissect writing and see all the scaffolding behind the walls. So, how do you construct a narrative, what are the techniques you use, how do you work with time across a story. I would highly recommend it because along with this entire structure, you have something to rely on. Now you know you can fix it this way. You have techniques, and you learn what is the most efficient way to tell a story, but no one can teach you how to write. That's part of your unique perspective.



Q You write a lot about societal issues and mostly women are the central characters in your books. Is that deliberate?

If I said I don't think men are that interesting, I don't know what you'd say. But I'm fascinated by older women. I feel as the world starts making them invisible, I find them more and more interesting. I feel they have so much experience, there are so many layers. They have gone beyond binaries. There is no right, wrong, white, black. You know, the grey in their hair is the grey in their life, and I find that fascinating.

Q Are you trying to be a voice for these women and their everyday struggles?

I'm not trying to be a voice for them. I am fascinated by them, and I believe their stories should be out there. Why are we, you know, always focusing on youth? And I think it was Ursula K Le Guin who said that beauty, when you're young, is just a by-product of hormones... I am paraphrasing, but as you get older, you earn it, and that is the real beauty. Why do we neglect that and just look at the one that is purely because of hormones?

Q Your first book, *Mrs Funnybones*, was a bestseller. Have you re-read it recently? If you were to write it today, what is the different thing that you would do?

When *Mrs Funnybones* came out, it did very well, but I kept thinking I want to do something different. I never sit down and say this is perfect. I don't look back. From all my books, when I re-read them or look at them, *Welcome to Paradise* is one that I feel satisfied with. I didn't make any compromises. I wrote it the way I wanted to write it. I wrote it at a stage in my life when I felt I had enough experience behind me to be able to negotiate things like loneliness and mortality and age and the layers of being. For me, that is a book I would not rewrite... every other book, yes, I wish I could... I would rewrite old chunks.

Q What are some of these compromises?

Sometimes there are compromises that you make unknowingly. In another book, for instance, I felt I had to be funny on every page, and so, I put that pressure on myself. The story was meant to be about an elderly couple, but, after discussions, it changed into that of a younger couple. So, those sort of compromises... and I made those

PHOTO BY ASHISH VAISHNAV/SOPA IMAGES/LIGHTROCKET VIA GETTY IMAGES



Actor Kajol (left) with Twinkle Khanna. The duo hosted a talk show, *Two Much*, this year

willingly, nobody forced me to. It didn't happen with *Welcome to Paradise*. With *Mrs Funnybones Returns*, there aren't any compromises because each column and each essay talks about a particular issue in the way I want to talk about it.

Q Have you embraced AI? What do you have to say to writers who rely only on AI, and lose their individuality and writing style?

AI is a tool, and it can be both beneficial and dangerous. For writers, I would say that we need to stay away from it. Maybe it's good for editing, maybe it's great for copy-editing, but I don't see how AI can write for you. AI doesn't have an image in its mind of a rooftop with a big tray of jelly sweets in it, sparkling in the sun, pink and green with little sugar molecules. How would it describe that? It's never tasted pickle... how would it tell you what it's like? And how would it tell you that every time you have a bite of mango pickle, there is somebody, at least for me, there was one Santoshi Amma, who used to give me pickle, who's walking beside me while I'm tasting this pickle, no matter where I am. How does AI do that? Where are the layers?

Q After quitting acting, you have reinvented yourself. You're an author, columnist, entrepreneur and now a talk show host. Which of these roles do you enjoy?

I'm happiest, oh well, not happiest, I can't say that because writing is an extremely difficult process... I'm most at peace when I'm writing. It's the place where I'm both within my mind and I'm also observing it. I find that calming. The rest of it is chaos, but I enjoy the chaos. I'm at a stage in my life where I want to experiment. I want to try new things. I want to see, learn, give it my best, push myself out of my comfort zone. So, whether it means doing a talk show, going back to university, planning a road trip across Ladakh... I want to do things that push me out of my comfort zone because I have only one life. I'm running out of time. I need to do whatever I can to stop myself from stagnating. It's very easy to stagnate right now.

Q How did the idea of starting a talk show come about?

I was interviewing people for Tweak [Khanna's digital platform for women] anyway—for *The Icons*. When they approached me to do this (*Two Much*), I thought it's fun. It's a bit different from what I normally do. It's much lighter. And I would be doing it with Kajol... I've always felt a certain warmth from her, and I felt I could trust her. So, it was a safe space.

Q How do you deal with criticism? Do you get affected by what is written about you?

I started working at a very young age... I was 17. I'm almost 52 now, and at some point, I came to a conclusion that there were only two things I could control—my preparation and my execution of that material. I cannot control outcomes. So, once I have satisfied myself that I have prepared as thoroughly as I can, and I have done it to the best of my ability, I don't bother beyond that with what people are saying. I will listen to them, I will take that feedback, I'll try and incorporate it if it makes sense to me... there is no ego involved. That is their opinion. For example, we are talking about *Mrs Funnybones Returns*. If I was so worried about criticism, I wouldn't have written that first column, and we wouldn't be here.

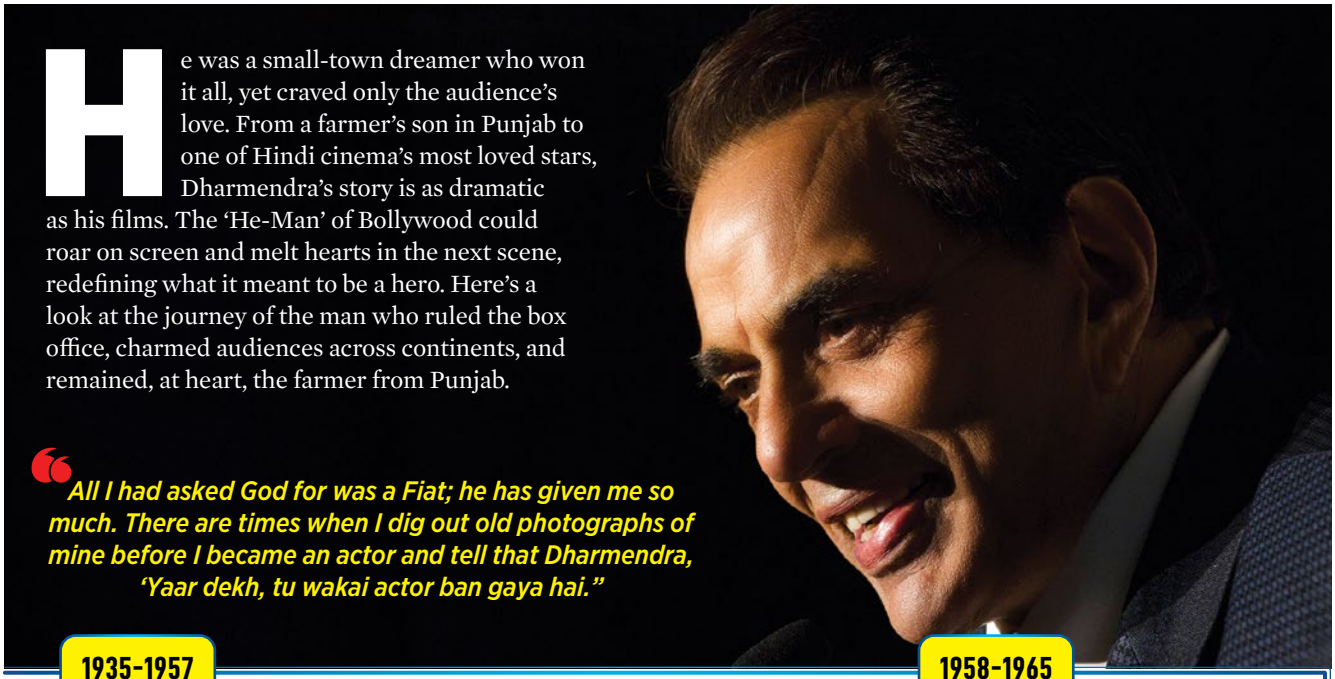
Q What's next?

I don't know. Maybe I want to study... do my PhD or perhaps I want to become the education minister. I have both options in my head now, I have to see what the world gives me. F

Dharmendra

The He-Man Who Made Hearts Melt

1935-2025



MARK BLINCH / FILE PHOTO / REUTERS

He was a small-town dreamer who won it all, yet craved only the audience's love. From a farmer's son in Punjab to one of Hindi cinema's most loved stars, Dharmendra's story is as dramatic as his films. The 'He-Man' of Bollywood could roar on screen and melt hearts in the next scene, redefining what it meant to be a hero. Here's a look at the journey of the man who ruled the box office, charmed audiences across continents, and remained, at heart, the farmer from Punjab.

"All I had asked God for was a Fiat; he has given me so much. There are times when I dig out old photographs of mine before I became an actor and tell that Dharmendra, 'Yaar dekh, tu wakai actor ban gaya hai."

1935-1957

SMALL-TOWN DREAMER

Born
December 8, 1935, Nasrali village, Ludhiana district, Punjab

Parents
Kewal Krishan (school headmaster) and Satwant Kaur

Childhood
Grew up in Sahnewal, studied at Government Senior Secondary School, Lalton Kalan and completed matriculation in 1952

Dharmendra grew up idolising Dilip Kumar, the man he would one day share a stage (and a lifetime achievement award moment) with



1958-1965

CITY OF DREAMS

1958
Wins Filmfare's National Talent Contest, his passport to Mumbai's film world

1960
Debuts with *Dil Bhi Tera Hum Bhi Tere* (director Arjun Hingorani). The film flops, but a new face is noticed

1961-1965

Slowly climbs the ladder with *Shola Aur Shabnam*, *Anpadh*, *Bandini* (Bimal Roy's classic), and *Haqeeqat* (Chetan Anand's war masterpiece)









Receives his first Filmfare Best Actor nomination



1966

TURNING POINT
Phool Aur Patthar (1966), the shirt-ripping scene made him Bollywood's 'He-Man', a title that would never leave him



Trivia
At the 14th National Film Awards, Dharmendra was given a souvenir in recognition of his performance in the film Anupama *(1966). Highlight: Receives his first Filmfare Best Actor nomination*



1967-1969

RISE OF THE ROMANTIC ACTION HERO

1968
Thrillers *Ankhen* and *Shikar* become top grossers

1969
Satyakam with Hrishikesh Mukherjee earns him career-best critical acclaim, a film still studied for its moral gravitas

1970-72

A dream run begins with *Jeevan Mrityu*, *Tum Haseen Main Jawaan*, *Sharafat*, *Mera Gaon Mera Desh*, *Seeta Aur Geeta*, *Raja Jani*, *Samadhi*.
The late 60s were Dharmendra's golden stretch. *Ayee Milan Ki Bela*, *Devar*, *Mamta*, *Anupama* and *Aaye Din Bahar Ke* make him every director's first choice

His pairing with Hema Malini becomes the talk of the town, both on and off screen



Trivia
During the shooting of Seeta Aur Geeta, *the crew nicknamed them 'Dream Pair', it was prophetic, as they'd marry years later amid huge controversy*

1973-1979

HE-MAN REIGNS SUPREME

1973
His most prolific year. *Loafer*, *Jugnu*, *Jheel Ke Us Paar*, *Yaadon Ki Baaraat*, *Kahani Kismat Ki* released

Yaadon Ki Baaraat introduces the 'masala film' formula that would dominate Bollywood for decades

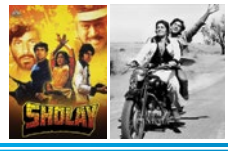


The evergreen romantic number '*Pal Pal Dil Ke Paas*' cements his romantic legacy

1975
Chupke Chupke shows his comic finesse

1975
Sholay (as Veeru) immortalises him in Indian pop culture

The film runs for five continuous years at Mumbai's Minerva theatre. Dharmendra was the highest-paid actor on the set: ₹1.5 lakh in 1975



'Basanti, in kutton ke samne mat nachna!' became one of Indian cinema's most-quoted lines

1977
Dharam Veer, *Chacha Bhatija*, and *Dream Girl*, all major hits

Dharam Veer sells 32 million tickets in the Soviet Union, proof of his global fan following

1980-1989

THE ACTION JUGGERNAUT
Dharmendra dominates the 80s as an indomitable man of action. *The Burning Train* (1980), *Alibaba Aur 40 Chor*, *Ram Balram*, *Ghazab* (1982), *Rajput*, *Samraat*, *Ghulami* (1985), *Hukumat* (1987).





1987
A record-breaking year, seven hits in one year, including *Hukumat*, *Aag Hi Aag* and *Insaniyat Ke Dushman*



1990-1997

FADING YEARS AND FILMFARE HONOUR
The 1990s saw Bollywood shift to the Khan era. Dharmendra's stardom waned but his fanbase remained loyal

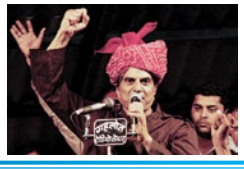
1997
Receives the Filmfare Lifetime Achievement Award



1998-2011

THE ELDER STATESMAN AND POLITICIAN
Reinvents himself in character roles *Pyaar Kiya To Darna Kya* (1998), *Life in a... Metro* (2007), *Apne* (2007), *Johnny Gaddaar* (2007)

2004-2009
Enters politics as BJP MP from Bikaner, Rajasthan



GETTY IMAGES

THE REINVENTED ICON
Yamla Pagla Deewana reunites him with sons Sunny and Bobby, a nostalgic hit



AFP

2012-2024

2013-2018
Sequels falter but his charm remains untarnished

2023
Rocky Aur Rani Kii Prem Kahaani; wins hearts in a brief but memorable role

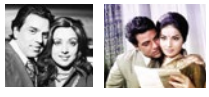
2024
Teri Baaton Mein Aisa Uljha Jiya marks another successful outing

November 24, 2025



Legacy

THE HANDSOME REBEL
Over 300 films, four Filmfare Best Actor nominations, and one Lifetime Achievement Award



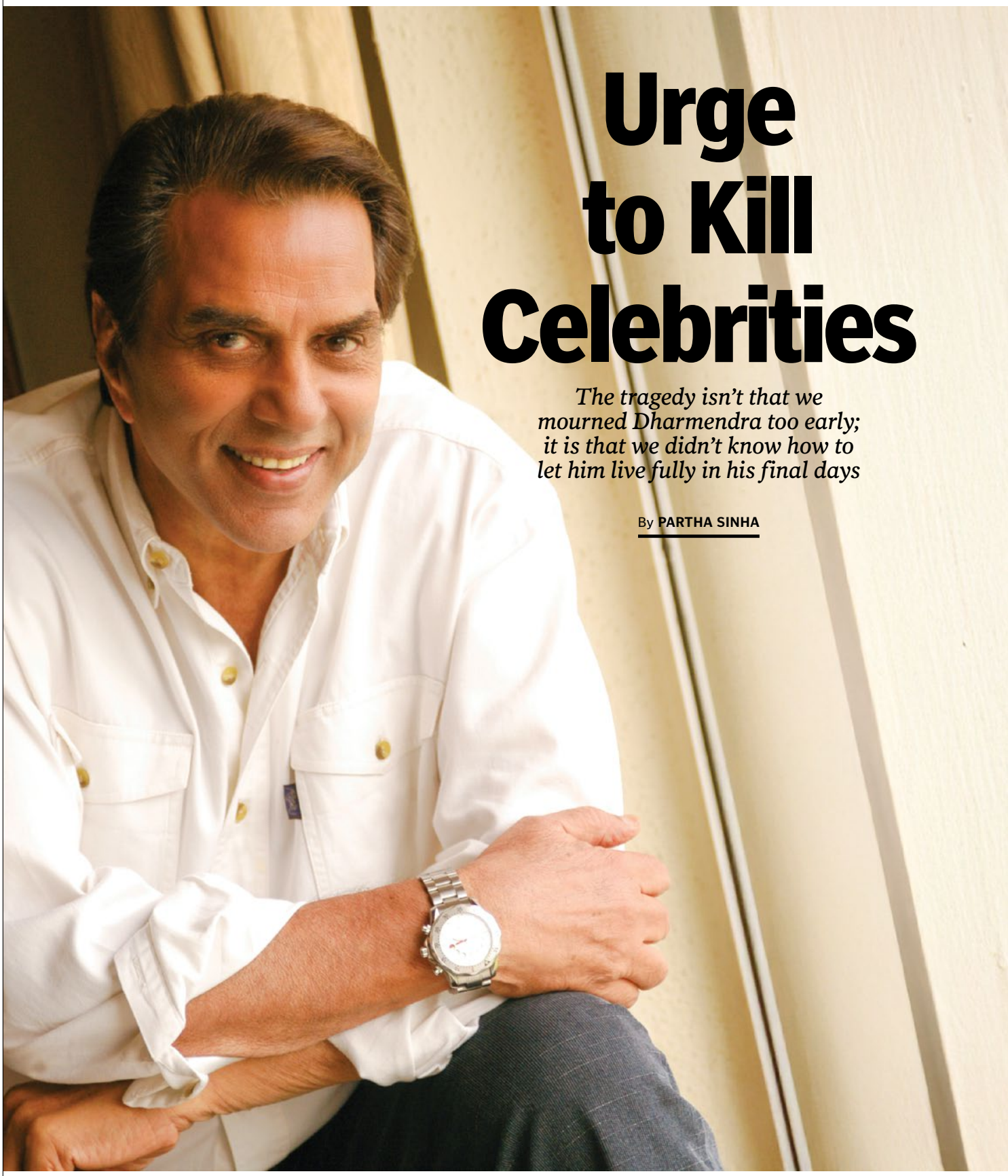
Appeared 18 times in *Box Office India*'s Top Actor list, topping it four for consecutive years (1972-75)



Padma Bhushan (2012)—recognition of six decades of cinema and cultural impact

COURTESY Network 18 creative

COLUMN



Urge to Kill Celebrities

The tragedy isn't that we mourned Dharmendra too early; it is that we didn't know how to let him live fully in his final days

By **PARTHA SINHA**

PHOTO BY BHASKAR PAUL/INDIA TODAY VIA GETTY IMAGES

Dharmendra's death feels different. Not only because we have lost a man who embodied a gentler, unembarrassed masculinity, but also because the nation rehearsed his passing a few weeks too early. While he was fighting for his life in the ICU, people were already posting their obituaries, circulating nostalgia playlists, and drafting heartfelt essays for a tragedy that hadn't yet happened. It was as if we were impatient with the pace of mortality, eager to skip to the end.

Now that the news is real, we are caught in an odd emotional deficit. The genuine grief feels diluted, pre-spent, used up during the false alarm. Dharmendra is gone, but the country grieved him in advance—and that premature mourning says more about us than about him.

This is the modern pathology: We kill celebrities not out of hatred but out of anticipation. We pre-announce their exits the way previous generations reserved crockery for special occasions. A celebrity enters an ICU, and the internet quietly enters obituary mode. The desire is not to deceive; it is to feel ahead of time.

Dharmendra was never a Morgan Freeman—not a serial victim of internet hoaxes. What happened to him was subtler and more revealing. When news of his deteriorating health spread, people rushed to write tributes "just in case". It wasn't misinformation; it was "early grief", the emotional equivalent of arriving too early at a funeral and standing awkwardly in an empty hall.

Why are we so eager to bury people who are still breathing?

Sociologists might say we are a civilisation exhausted by continuity. Everything drags on endlessly now—political dramas, cinematic universes, influencer lives, streaming shows with unnecessary seasons. Nothing ends neatly. But death still does. It gives us clean lines, decisive punctuation. A celebrity's passing offers the kind of closure modern life refuses to, and we crave that closure so desperately that we begin anticipating it.

Psychology offers a more intimate explanation. We kill celebrities early because we cannot bear their ageing. Dharmendra represented a version of India that has quietly evaporated—a kind of large-hearted heroism, unselfconscious charm, and emotional sincerity that no influencer culture can replicate. Watching such figures grow frail unsettles us. Their decline threatens our myths. So, we try to freeze them in the sepia form we prefer, by imaginatively writing the ending before life does.

And then there is the Instagram generation. Not just the young—but also the even more enthusiastic older cohort who think mastering reels is a sign of youthfulness. This new tribe has transformed mourning into content. They produce "aesthetic grief", complete with retro filters, slow-motion Dharmendra clips, and soundtrack-ready sorrow. When he was in the ICU, many had tribute posts ready, paused like drafts in a newsroom. Grief used to be private; now it is curated, templated, optimised.

This performance of mourning collapses the boundary between anticipation and event. The moment a celebrity falls ill, a parallel market of pseudo-memorials springs into action. Not out of cruelty, but out of a compulsive need to be early—early to post, early to feel, early to perform sadness.

Meanwhile, newsrooms have discovered that mortality is the most clickable emotion. Even without declaring Dharmendra dead, channels and portals leaned into a tone of solemn countdown: "Serious condition", "family worried", "sources uncertain". Some of them killed him prematurely, some rehearsed it. Because nothing spikes viewer engagement like imminent tragedy.

The moment a celebrity falls ill, a parallel market of pseudo-memorials springs into action. Not out of cruelty, but out of a compulsive need to be early

Journalism has quietly acquired the instincts of a mortuary attendant checking the clock.

But Dharmendra's actual passing breaks the performance. Suddenly the nostalgia feels too curated, the tributes too rehearsed, the grief too pre-packaged. When the real moment arrived, it had to compete with its own rehearsal.

India loved Dharmendra because he was that rare star who made heroism look human. His death hits not because he was a celebrity, but because he was an era. And perhaps that is why his final weeks exposed our cultural impatience so starkly. We no longer know how to let icons age quietly, or to allow their final days the dignity of uncertainty. We demand narrative certainty even before life is done writing.

In the end, the tragedy isn't that we mourned Dharmendra too early; it is that we didn't know how to let him live fully in his final days—without speculation, without content, without algorithmic breathlessness.

He is gone now. And for once, there is no rehearsal. Just the silence he deserved all along. F

(THE AUTHOR IS A SENIOR ADVISORY PROFESSIONAL)

PRASHANTH PRAKASH, Founding Partner, Accel India

'Future of Health Care Isn't About Living Forever'

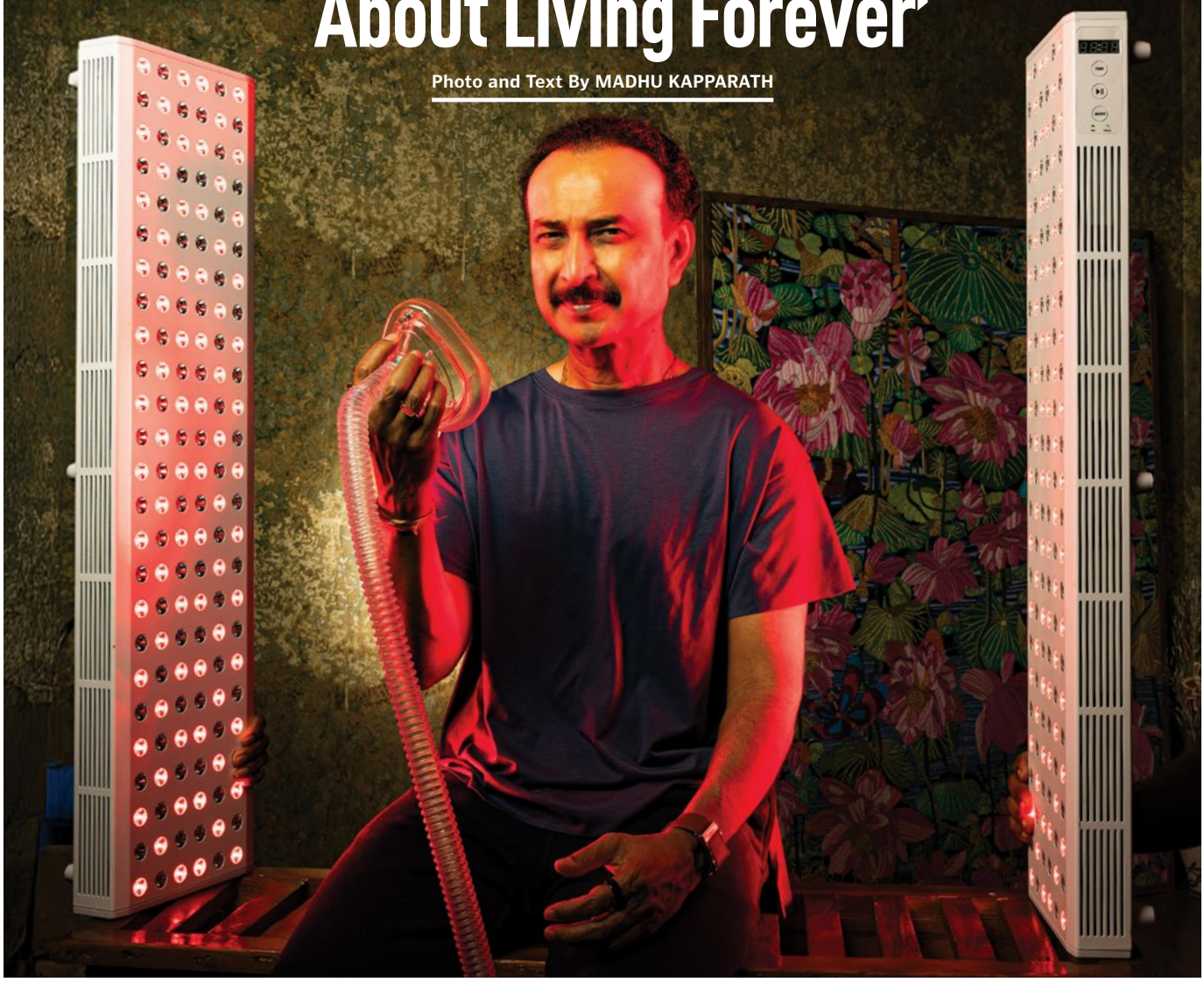
Photo and Text By MADHU KAPPARATH

Making room for recovery on his busy workday, Prashanth Prakash basks in a soft glow from two panels that emit red and near-infrared light to activate the body's own repair systems.

The science behind this photobiomodulation therapy is as elegant as it is powerful: When light reaches the mitochondria, it restores energy flow, calms inflammation and improves circulation. Over time, it helps the body recover faster, sleep better and function more smoothly. "It's not a shortcut. It's simply a way to help your cells find their natural rhythm again," he says. "Everything I've learnt from building companies—feedback loops, data and iteration—now applies to the human body."

As a partner at Accel, Prashanth Prakash has spent decades spotting the next frontier in technology. Now, he's exploring the next frontier within the human body.

A curiosity about identifying health risks in advance while in his 40s has evolved into a deeper pursuit for him: Longevity by design. His focus is on building India-specific health data, predictive models that detect decline before disease and training new physician-scientists who can act early. "The future of health care isn't about living forever. It's about living fully, with strength, clarity and agency," he says. F



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